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FY26 Revenue



31.26%
FY24 - FY26 CAGR



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22 Product Categories#



3,75,000+[#]
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22 States & **5** UTs#

Exclusively focused on premium, value-added dairy products (Source: 1Lattice Report)

Diversified product categories

Manufacturing facilities equipped with advanced machinery to ensure consistent quality of products and operational efficiency

*(Among companies with revenue scale of more than ₹15,000 million) in India in terms of revenue, growing at a CAGR of 31.26% from Fiscal 2024 to Fiscal 2026. (Source: 1Lattice Report) | # As of March 31, 2026

MILKY MIST DAIRY FOOD LIMITED is proposing, subject to applicable statutory and regulatory requirements, receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offering of its Equity Shares and has filed the RHP with RoC, SEBI and the Stock Exchanges on August 4, 2026. The RHP shall be available on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in, and is available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE and NSE at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com, respectively, on the website of the Company at www.milkymist.com and the websites of the BRLMs, i.e., JM Financial Limited, Axis Capital Limited and IIFL Capital Services Limited (formerly known as IIFL Securities Limited) at www.jmfl.com, https://www.axiscapital.co.in/ and www.iiflcapital.com, respectively. Any potential investors should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risk, see "Risk Factors" beginning on page 23 of the RHP. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP and should instead rely on their own examination of our Company and the Offer, including the risks involved, for making any investment decision. The Equity Shares offered in the Offer have not been and will not be registered under the U.S. Securities Act of 1933, as amended (the "U.S. Securities Act") or any state securities laws in the United States and, unless so registered, may not be offered or sold within the United States, except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable state securities laws. Accordingly, such Equity Shares are being offered and sold (i) outside of the United States in offshore transactions in reliance on Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act and the applicable laws of the jurisdiction where those offers and sales occur; and (ii) within the United States to "qualified institutional buyers" (as defined in Rule 144A under the U.S. Securities Act), pursuant to the private placement exemption set out in Section 4(a) of the U.S. Securities Act. The Equity Shares have not been and will not be registered, listed or otherwise qualified in any other jurisdiction outside India and may not be offered or sold, and Bids may not be made by persons in any such jurisdiction, except in compliance with the applicable laws of such jurisdiction. There will be no public offering in the United States.

milky mist[®]

MILKY MIST DAIRY FOOD LIMITED



Largest Private
Packaged
Paneer
Brand*



Largest Private
Packaged
Cheese
Brand**



Among the
Top Two Largest
Private Packaged
Yogurt
Brands#

*In the organized market with a market share of approximately 19% In terms of the organised packaged paneer market value in Fiscal 2026 in India (Source: 1Lattice Report) | **In South India in Fiscal 2026, with a market share of approximately 12% In terms of market value in the Southern region's organised cheese segment (Source: 1Lattice Report) | #With a market share of approximately 13% in terms of market value in the organized yogurt market in India (Source: 1Lattice Report)

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Happening today

● A SPECIAL FAST-TRACK court at Delhi's Rouse Avenue Court will pronounce its order on taking cognizance of the CBI's chargesheet in the NEET-UG paper leak case.

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THE EDITORIAL PAGE TRUST IS KEY, TECH FUND NEEDS MORE GUARDRAILS [PAGE 10](#)

THE IDEAS PAGE PROOF OF DEEP-TECH FUND IS IN OUTCOMES. THAT'S THE AUDIT WORTH DOING [PAGE 11](#)

Anticipatory bail denied, ex-TISS student held for Umar, Sharjeel slogans

Express News Service Mumbai, August 9

THE MUMBAI Police arrested a 30-year-old former student of the Tata Institute of Social Sciences (TISS), after his anticipatory bail plea was rejected by a sessions court, for allegedly holding an event linked to the death anniversary of G N Saibaba, a former Delhi University professor, on the campus without permission.

The former student was arrested on Friday over an FIR filed by the institute in October 2025, and produced before the magistrate court on Saturday. While the police sought his custody for ten days, the court granted custody till Monday.

The court had rejected the pre-arrest bail pleas of two former students, including the 30-year-old, while allowing those of seven others. The other student, whose plea was also rejected, has not yet been arrested, the officer said.

The nine students were booked for allegedly raising slogans seeking the release of Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam, who are behind bars since 2020 under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA). The police had claimed that the two also possessed downloaded books and other material that the prosecution said reflected "Maoist ideology".

The students denied these charges, arguing there is no evidence to support such grave allegations. The 30-year-old »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

POLITICS PAGE 6



NALSAR STUDENTS URGE VARSITY NOT TO INVITE CJI TO CONVOCATION

PROTESTERS PUSH FOR CANCELLATION OF A FOURTH EXAM, MINISTER SAYS IT WAS COURT MONITORED

Jharkhand govt agrees to cancel 3 exams, job panel members quit

CM vows justice; protesters to go ahead with march to Assembly today

Shubham Tigga Ranchi, August 9

THE JHARKHAND government agreed to cancel three examinations, including the preliminary examination of the 14th JPSC Combined Civil Services, following six hours of discussions with two separate delegations of student groups as their protest in Ranchi entered Day 16 on Sunday.

The state government also agreed to the students' demand to involve the Enforcement Di-



Jharkhand ministers and student representatives after holding a meeting in Ranchi, Sunday. PTI

rectorate (ED) to probe alleged financial irregularities related to the 14th JPSC exam.

Amid massive protests, three members of the Jharkhand Public Service Commis-

sion (JPSC) resigned on Sunday. Even as Technical and Higher Education Minister Sudivya Kumar Sonu, who was part of the panel that met the two delegations of students, said

Business as Usual

By EP UNNY

Give J&K's job seekers a full state before they come to you.



the government has accepted 98% of the demands, protesters said they won't compromise until the JSSC-CGL (Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission-Combined Graduate Level)

examination result is cancelled and CBI probe is ordered into all JPSC-linked exams.

For its part, the government said the state cannot cancel the CGL exam results as the test was conducted under the monitoring of the Supreme Court and High Court.

The talks, which began around noon at the state guest house in Ranchi, saw two major factions of the students' movement, besides representatives associated with AISA, meeting the government panel that comprised ministers Deepika Pandey Singh, Sanjay Prasad Yadav and Chamra Linda, besides Sonu. The two factions of protesters are JPSC-JSSC Reform Manch and the JPSC-JSSC Abhyarthi Nyay Manch.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Iran: No talks while US breaches interim deal; 'low keying' it: Trump

Nayera Abdallah, Steve Holland & Enas Alashray Dubai, Washington, Cairo, August 9



Messages being exchanged via intermediaries: Iran Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi

RELATED REPORT, PAGE 12

IRAN AND the US are not engaged in talks and Tehran will not start them as long as Washington keeps breaching an interim deal signed in June, Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said on Sunday, adding that messages are being exchanged via intermediaries.

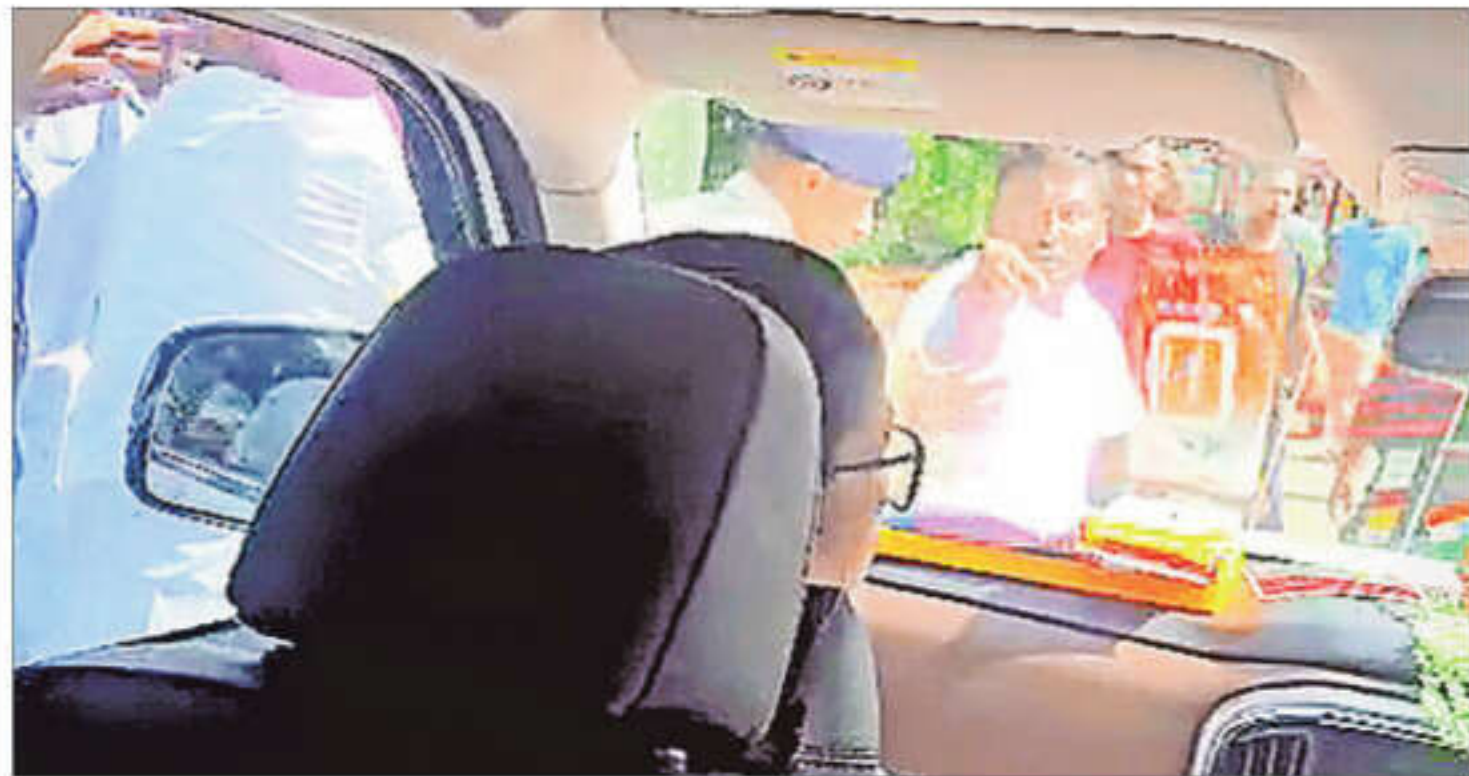
Araghchi repeated Iran's position that an agreement on the Strait of Hormuz between Tehran and Muscat was in the "final stages" but would not reopen the strategic waterway. He said the agreement would set out the new shipping lanes to be used once the US fulfils other conditions and the strait is reopened to traffic.

US President Donald Trump said on Sunday that his administration is watching economic

pressure mount on Iran, according to an interview with *Axios*. "We are low keying it," Trump was quoted as saying. "We are only semi-negotiating with them. We are just watching Iran with its huge inflation and the fact they have no money."

On Friday, a US official said that an agreement between Iran and Oman was close and could soon reopen the waterway. "Once the deal is announced to

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



West Bengal ex-CM Mamata Banerjee in her car during the incident in Halisahar, Sunday. ANI VIDEO GRAB

Mud, slippers thrown at Mamata's convoy; 'no BJP hand', says Suvendu

Sweetie Kumari Kolkata, August 9

FORMER WEST Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee faced protests in Halisahar in West Bengal's North 24 Parganas district on Sunday when she was on her way to visit the family of a Trinamool Congress

NATION PAGE 8

CM ORDERS FRESH PROBE INTO RG KAR RAPE-MURDER

(TMC) worker who died in police custody. A crowd surrounded the TMC chief's car,

shouting "chor (thief)" and "dakot rani (dacoit queen)", and hurled mud and slippers.

The BJP condemned the incident, emphasising it does not endorse violence, even as Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari accused Banerjee of playing politics and defended the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

U20 Worlds: Basant, Shahnavaaz make history as India's jumpers share global podium in US

Prithish Raj New Delhi, August 9

INDIA'S JUMPERS rarely make a global podium. On Saturday, they did it twice at the U20 World Championships in Eugene, US.

Basant Kumar (19) became the first Indian high-jumper to win a medal at the U20 Worlds, claiming silver. Shahnavaaz Khan (19) followed with bronze in the long jump, becoming the first Indian male long-jumper to reach the podium at the championships.

With these two medals, along with Ashish Yadav's



Basant Kumar won a silver in high jump; (right) Shahnavaaz Khan won bronze in long jump in Eugene, Oregon, US, Saturday. AFI



silver in the javelin, India equalled its best-ever haul at the U20 World Championships, matching the tally from the 2021 and 2022 editions.

Basant, who is coached by former national record-holder Sahana Kumari, equalled his personal best with 2.21m but lost gold to Algeria's Younes Ayachi on countback. "A big moment for him and the country. I always knew Basant was going to deliver on the big stage," Sahana Kumari told *The Indian Express*.

Shahnavaaz, who was the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

"I never worried about my batting position and milestones. It was always about the team"

AJINKYA RAHANE
FORMER INDIA CAPTAIN
[PAGE 14](#)

EXPRESS special

In its first month, VB-G RAM G sees almost 50% y-o-y dip in rural jobs

7.67cr person-days in July as against 15.33cr in same month last year; 98% rural households seeking employment offered work: Govt

● Rural jobs generated in July

Fiscal year	Household	Person-days
2022-23	1.75 crore	23.47 crore
2023-24	2.09 crore	27.14 crore
2024-25	1.62 crore	20.30 crore
2025-26	1.42 crore	15.33 crore
2026-27	68 lakh	7.67 crore

SOURCE: SCHEME DASHBOARDS

Harikishan Sharma New Delhi, August 9

EMPLOYMENT GENERATION under the government's revamped rural job guarantee programme saw a sharp decline, registering a fall of 49.94 per cent year-on-year in July, as per official data. The drop came as the government transitioned from the two-decade-old Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (MGNREGS) to the newly-launched Viksit Bharat — Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin), or VB-G RAM G, from July 1 this year.

Official data as on August 9 shows that only 7.67 crore person-days were generated under the VB-G RAM G scheme in July 2026 — which is 49.94 per cent lower as compared to 15.33 crore person-days generated

E. EXPLAINED

Impact on demand

Even though the new rural job guarantee scheme offers higher wages and more days of work, employment generation has slowed significantly. This might impact rural demand — crucial for lifting the economy. Due to the erratic monsoon, Kharif crop area coverage has fallen too, posing a challenge to overall agricultural output.

under the MG-NREGS in the same month last year.

Person-day is a unit of measurement based on an ideal amount of work done by a person in one working day.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

A-I flight turbulence: Pilot's sample sent for confirmatory drug test, result awaited

Plane saw sudden loss of about 300 ft of altitude, landed with 17 injured

ENS Economic Bureau New Delhi, August 9

A DOPE test conducted on the pilot-in-command of the Air India Phuket-Delhi flight that encountered severe turbulence on Tuesday has generated a result that requires confirmatory testing, the Ministry of Civil Aviation (MoCA) said. Samples have been sent for confirmatory testing and the results are awaited, it said.

According to sources, the requirement of a confirmatory test suggests that the initial

screening may have indicated presence of a psychoactive substance in the sample. Confirmatory tests are required as certain foods and medications can throw up false positives in initial screenings.

In a release issued Sunday evening, MoCA said both the pilots have been off-rostered by the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) pending the investigation, which is being conducted by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB).

Air India said that while it was aware of the post-flight screening test conducted on the pilots, the findings were not shared with it.

The Air India Airbus A320 aircraft, operating from Phuket to Delhi, encountered turbulence while flying, which led to a sudden altitude drop of about

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● 518 SPECIES, 5,815 MINUTES OF RECORDINGS IN INDIA'S FIRST OPEN-ACCESS, CROWDSOURCED ECOACOUSTIC DATASET

Birdcall, insect flutter: Experts capture sounds of forest — and their meaning

Sabah Virani Mumbai, August 9

LAST YEAR, a collective of ecologists and enthusiasts set out to capture the sounds of India's key ecosystems. They came up with nearly a hundred hours of recordings across ecologically varied terrain — from the drenched corridors of the Western Ghats to the deciduous forests of the East Deccan. Birdsong dominated, mixed with the calls of insects, frogs, bats, reptiles and even marine animals.

Then came the hard part. Trained ears combed through the 5,815 minutes to pin

down the exact species behind each sound. Where the listener's expertise allowed, the seconds and frequency of the call were marked on a spectrogram, a visual map of the sound. Where it didn't, they simply noted that the species was present.

On July 21, the result was published on bioRxiv, an online server where scientists post studies while a journal reviews them — in this case *Scientific Data*, published by Nature Research. With it, India has its first open-access, crowd-sourced ecoacoustic dataset of multiple distinct groups of organisms, a library of wild sound built by volunteers and free for



anyone to use — a chorus of 518 species across 25 states and union territories.

Set against the staggering



(Left) Chiranjib Bora during a focal recording in Arunachal Pradesh. JIBON DUTTA; Ram Dayal Vaishnav, Dr Chitra Shanker and Prasan Dutt Raju conduct fieldwork in Hyderabad. RAM DAYAL VAISHNAV

scale of the subcontinent's wildlife, the tally may be modest, but it is a step towards using sound to study nature in the

country. Until now, India's eco-acoustic recordings existed in scattered collections. This open-access dataset gives

scientists a shared resource to improve biodiversity monitoring and helps AI identify Indian wildlife more accurately.

"When ecologists do bird surveys on the field, we usually do a point count," said Pooja Choksi, a Mumbai-based ecological restoration scientist and a co-founder of the Indian Eco-acoustics Network (IEN), the collective behind the dataset.

"You go to a spot in a forest, wait for 15 minutes, and note down all the birds you can observe in the distance. But if you rely only on sight, especially in a dense forest, you'll end up missing out on most of the wildlife," she said.

"Recordings can be a perfect

time capsule for how an ecosystem sounds like in time and space. They can capture more species, over frequencies the human ear can't hear, note how they vocalise, and do it periodically over long periods of time. This makes acoustics a game changer for biodiversity monitoring in any ecosystem," Choksi said.

Ecologists have used eco-acoustics to chart changes in a habitat over time, through conservation efforts or after tree felling. Tigers have been found to have vocal fingerprints, their chuffing unique to each. With AI, the arduous task of manually listening back has been simplified — deep learning

models like BirdNET and Perch automatically detect the species heard. All of this is done non-invasively, with a nondescript recorder wrapped around a tree.

In all this, there is a gap for India. Kadambari Devarajan, a Mumbai-based independent researcher who uses data science for conservation, explained why. "Machine learning models for recognising species/ birds through acoustics are largely trained on data from the Global North," she said.

"And as every ecosystem has its unique soundscape, made up of a mix of endemic and common species, background

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Amarnath pilgrimage suspended after heavy rain; repair work on both routes continues

Naveed Iqbal
Srinagar, August 9

IN VIEW of the repair work necessitated by recent rains, and forecast of more rains in coming days, the annual Amarnath yatra has been suspended on both routes, beginning Sunday. The 57-day yatra is unlikely to restart this year, officials said.

The yatra commenced on July 3 and was expected to conclude on August 28 but has been suspended on both tracks: Chandanwari track in Anantnag district, and Baltal in Ganderbal district.

Divisional Commissioner, Kashmir, Anshul Garg, said, "Due to the recent rains, a necessity for the repair and maintenance of the Yatra tracks at vulnerable stretches has been felt, which is being undertaken by Border Roads Organization."

In addition, adverse weather conditions have been predicted by the India Meteorological Department (IMD) for the next few days. Hence, the yatra will remain suspended from both

No hearse, MP hospital sends body home in trash collection vehicle

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, August 9

THE BODY of a deceased woman was allegedly transported from a government hospital in a municipal garbage vehicle in Madhya Pradesh's Chhatarpur after the family was unable to arrange a hearse, exposing a basic infrastructure gap at a civil hospital where authorities admit that a dedicated vehicle for the purpose has been sought repeatedly but not provided.

The incident occurred at the Bada Malhera Civil Hospital after the body of Rukhsana Khan, who had been missing since July 4, was recovered from a garbage dump on the Surajpur Road area on August 5. Police suspect she was murdered and sent her body to the hospital for a post-mortem examination.

After the procedure, her family waited for a vehicle to take the body home but, accord-

Four detained for 'selling non-veg' on Kanwar routes; shops razed

Press Trust of India
Bareilly, August 9

POLICE HAVE detained four people after raiding two shops allegedly selling non-vegetarian food along a designated Kanwar routes here, officials said Sunday. Portions of two shops were also razed.

The action comes amid heightened police and administrative surveillance on Kanwar routes during the ongoing Sawan month.

Authorities have directed traders not to sell meat, chicken, fish and other non-vegetarian food along designated routes during the pilgrimage and warned of legal action for violations.

In the first incident, police received information on Satur-



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[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Jharkhand

While there was agreement on several broad demands, the student groups remained at odds with the government over the issue of JSSC-CGL examination.

Even as the government proposed a high-level judiciary inquiry committee headed by a retired judge to probe the matter, the students remained firm on their demand of cancellation of the exam.

Meanwhile, Chief Minister Hemant Soren reiterated his promise to deliver justice to the agitating youths while asserting that dialogue, not batons, can solve all problems. Soren on Sunday also alleged that vested interests were working to disrupt democracy in the state, adding the students' stir should not be politicised. "Unable to accept the state's self-reliance, vested interests are working at full force in Jharkhand to disrupt democracy here. Samvad and not 'lathidanda-bandook' (dialogue, not batons), can solve all problems.

"Weapons are meant for enemies at the border. I promise the exam protesters that justice will be delivered with full transparency," the CM said, addressing Jharkhand Adivasi Mahotsav. "Justice will not only be done, but will also be seen to be done," he said.

Governor Santosh Kumar Gangwar also urged the students to solve the matter through "dialogue" and not agitation, while saying that the government's doors were always open for them.

Earlier in the day, the Governor accepted the resignation

Araghchi on talks

restore commercial shipping without impediments, the United States will lift the blockade of Iranian ports," the US official said.

US actions would be tied to Iran's implementation of its commitments, the official said. The comments indicated delicate sequencing towards a deal that sources said appeared to be set to give Tehran control over ships entering the Gulf through the strait — something shippers said was not easily workable.

The latest status of the agreement was not clear and Iran's response suggested other factors would also come into play. Araghchi said reopening the strait would depend on conditions including US compensation to Iran for its widespread attacks.

The secretary of Iran's top national security body, Mohammad Baqer Zolqadr, also listed ending US threats against Iran, stopping aggression against Iran and its Lebanese, Palestinian, Yemeni and Iraqi allies, lifting a blockade and sanctions on Iran and freeing Iranian assets. The United Arab Emirates said on Saturday that Iran had attacked a ship affiliated to its state oil

REUTERS

Mamata

police, saying they had done their job well. The CM also denied the involvement of BJP workers in the attack.

Addressing the media outside the home of Birju Keot, the TMC worker who died in police custody, Banerjee alleged that bricks, stones, shoes, and mud were hurled at her convoy. The TMC chief alleged that the attack was a "well-planned conspiracy" that could have resulted in fatal injuries had her car windows been open. She accused the police of standing by during the attack.

"Bricks were hurled at my vehicle. If the windows had not been closed, my head could have been smashed. I have never witnessed such an attack in my life. I was attacked in the presence of the police ... Every-

Birdcall

hands of anyone who needs it. A field researcher mapping an ecosystem with BirdNET can feed this data into the model, instead of depending only on recordings their own team has gathered over time.

"Researchers in India already use global deep learning models for acoustic analysis, with individual modifications and data inputs to fine tune the model's accuracy in the habitat they're working in. But this is all happening in individual silos, wherein the data and resources are fragmented. With a one-stop for a vast amount of data, all those efforts can be pooled to-

testing agency but they didn't agree to it. They said they will initiate inquiry into all the exams related to Abhay Tiwari and TDPL," added Rajak.

Abhay Tiwari alias Manoj Kunmar Tiwari, a Block Supply Officer (BSO) in Godda district, accused of playing a major role in the recruitment racket, was arrested in the case earlier this month.

According to investigators, Tiwari was simultaneously working as the Marketing Manager of TSR Data Processing Private Limited (TDPL), the private testing agency associated with conducting the examination.

On the JSSC-CGL examination, Rajak said, "We want the cancellation of the exam as we provided all the evidence of the paper leak." He said that as part of long-term reforms, the government has said it will seek assistance from institutions such as IIMs and XLRI to undertake comprehensive reforms in the functioning of JPSC and JSSC.

The government also agreed to establish fast-track courts for speedy disposal of cases and proposed that reports of all economic and judicial investigations be submitted within 90 days, according to the students.

Though student delegations had held discussions with government representatives earlier as well, the Sunday meetings were conducted through separate delegations representing different factions of the ongoing agitation.

Meanwhile, on World Indigenous Day, several members of the Adivasi communities joined the protest at Jaipal Singh Munda stadium to express solidarity with the agitating students.

Drug test

300 feet and caused injuries to a few passengers and cabin crew members. The flight landed safely in Delhi with 17 people, including 13 passengers and four crew members, requiring hospital admission.

The aircraft was carrying 137 passengers and eight crew members. The plane was flying over Odisha at an altitude of about 36,000 feet when the incident occurred, according to flight tracking data.

"As part of the Standard Operating Procedures following such an occurrence, both flight crew members underwent the prescribed psychoactive substance screening test. The screening test in respect of the Pilot-in-Command (PIC) indicated a result requiring confirmatory testing. Samples have accordingly been sent to the designated laboratory for confirmatory analysis, and the final report is awaited," MoCA said.

"The occurrence has been classified as a Serious Incident and is under investigation by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB). Pending investigation and completion of the prescribed process, both flight crew members have been taken

to get involved' ... the family members are saying. "We are satisfied with the administration and police. We want the case solved. He was in lockup, beaten while in that condition, fell ill, and we want justice. The local government and police can provide us justice; Mamata Banerjee cannot."

"Mamata Banerjee went there on a holiday without informing the police, taking a lawyer along to play politics. The police made such elaborate arrangements, which I doubt she even qualifies for under current protocols. However, our instructions are clear. As a former CM and given her age, she should be provided with full security and respect. The police did their job well, they didn't do anything wrong," said the CM.

"And, when you have committed so much theft, you're bound to hear the word 'thief'. From now on, wear those noise-

gether," Khanwilkar said.

The IEN grew out of Project Dhvani, a collective that Khanwilkar, Choksi and avian ecologist Vijay Ramesh began as PhD students at Columbia University in 2018. Relunched as the network in 2024, it drew over 600 people interested in eco-acoustics, formal expertise not required.

In 2025, a core group of ecologists and engineers put out the call, with a few ground rules: the recordings would be free for anyone to use under a Creative Commons licence, labelled and published, and anyone who sent in at least 30 minutes would get

TISS

former student was arrested from the Chembur area soon after his plea was rejected.

The Trombay police had in October 2025 filed an FIR naming nine persons in the case, which was later transferred to the Mumbai Police Crime Branch. According to the FIR, based on a complaint by the TISS associate dean, around 10-12 students gathered between 7.30 pm and 8.30 pm on October 12, 2025, at the Deonar campus without permission to pay homage to Saibaba. The event included placing Saibaba's photographs on a tree and reading his poems, the police said.

The students, aged 21-30, were booked for offences including promoting enmity between religious, caste or community groups, making statements prejudicial to national integration, and unlawful assembly.

Additional Sessions Judge V B Bohra, who rejected the pleas of two former students on Friday had said: "No doubt G N Saibaba came to be acquitted of charges levelled against him and, therefore, act of paying homage to him by accused persons cannot be termed as illegal. However, the act of accused persons appeared to be not limited to paying him homage. They even allegedly raised slogans in the nature of releasing Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam from jail, who are facing trial for an offence under UAPA i.e. unlawful activities against the Nation."

off roster by the DGCA. Further action, as appropriate, will be taken based on the outcome of the investigation and confirmatory test results," it said.

Upon landing in Delhi, the aircraft was moved to a hangar and its flight data recorder and cockpit voice recorder secured for detailed examination as part of the investigation. On Tuesday, MoCA had said that the DGCA was investigating the incident. But since it has been classified as a serious incident, it will now be probed by the AAIB. The bureau is expected to investigate all aspects of the incident, including its handling by the pilots. In that context, the final drug test result could be significant.

"We are aware that a post-flight screening test was conducted on the pilots in accordance with applicable protocols. However, the results of the test have not been shared with Air India, and we are therefore not in a position to comment on any findings. Air India undertakes regular drug testing of crew members in compliance with civil aviation regulations, independent of any specific flight or operational incident. We will continue to cooperate with the relevant authorities as required," an Air India spokesperson said.

cancellation sets that people use in helicopters; then you won't hear the word ... There were no BJP flags, no BJP workers present. It was a massive public outrage," Adhikari said.

The Halisahar police arrested 48-year-old Keot, the husband of former Kanchrapara municipal councillor Jenny Sharma Keot, on August 7 on charges of extortion and financial fraud, and under the Arms Act. He was produced before the Barrackpore court, which remanded him to police custody for five days. Keot suddenly fell ill in the lockup early on Saturday morning and was declared dead upon arrival at the Jawaharlal Nehru Memorial Hospital in Kalyani. His family alleged severe physical torture and assault, claiming there were visible injury marks and bleeding on his ears. The police have ordered an investigation into the allegations.

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

own recordings of birds and frogs.

Teotia's husband, Sameer Singh, an electronics engineer, handled the incoming recordings and checked their quality, throwing out any that arrived without a species being named. Before the dataset went to Scientific Data, independent experts spot-checked a random 2 per cent, and 98 per cent held up. Most of it came from Kerala and Madhya Pradesh. Of the nearly 6,000 minutes, 3,311 are pinned down to the exact second and pitch of each call; the other 2,504 loosely confirm a species' presence.

Rural jobs

While the VB-G RAM G dashboard shows 767 crore person-days in July, the Rural Development Ministry said around 9 crore person-days were generated during the first month of implementation of the scheme.

The number of households who availed the rural job guarantee scheme came down by 51.45 per cent, to 68.94 lakh, in July this year under the VB-G RAM G scheme. Under MGNREGS, the figure stood at 1.42 crore in the same month last year.

The number of households and person-days under the rural jobs scheme have actually been the lowest in the last five years. At 0.68 crore, the average number of households that availed of the VB-G RAM G scheme is less than 40% of the average 1.72 crore households over the previous four years. Similarly, this July's person-days are also just 35% of 21.56 crore average person-days over the previous four years.

In March 2025, 17.56 crore person-days were generated under NREGS — which was 0.70% lower than 17.69 crore person-days in March 2024. This year-on-year decline in the monthly figure of employment generated under NREGS continued till June 2026, the last month of the UPA-era scheme.

The July slide in employment generation under VB-G RAM G is significant in view of the erratic monsoon. As per the IMD, 50 per cent of the country's 741 districts have reported deficit-to-serious-deficit rainfall from June 1 to August 3. In such a situation, the rural job guarantee scheme becomes a fallback option for unskilled agricultural labourers.

According to the Union Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare, area coverage under kharif crop was reported at 894.22 lakh hectares as on July 31, 2026 — which was 26.50 per cent lower as compared to 920.72 lakh hectares in the corresponding period last year.

Sources said that one of the reasons for drop in employment generation may be because of a pause in the scheme during the Kharif sowing season. However, there is no data available about pauses in the sowing season.

Responding to an email from *The Indian Express*, an official with the Ministry of Rural Development said, "VB-GRAM G Act, Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

jump at the Inter-State National Championships in Bhubaneswar.

While his performance at the U20 Worlds was not what he had hoped for, a world championship bronze medal at 19 is a strong start to his long-jump CV. "Today, I was only thinking about one thing: somehow, I had to finish on the podium and win a medal for India. It's a proud moment for me, and I'm happy that I didn't miss the opportunity to win a medal for India," he said.

Last year, when he crossed the 8m mark for the first time at the World Continental Bronze event in Bhubaneswar, Shahnavaz took a moment to remember his late father, Naseemudin. He wrote on his bib, "8+ jump, I miss dad", as a tribute. "Writing on the back of the bib was my way of paying tribute to my father, who passed away in 2018 because of an ailment. My father drove a jeep to ferry passengers between villages. I miss him," he had told this newspaper.

Shahnavaz is now part of a growing pool of Indian long jumpers. "This is probably the best year for the Indian long jumpers overall. The competition has increased and these youngsters are pushing each other and me also," two-time Commonwealth Games medalist Sreeshankar had said last month at the Inter-State Championships.

Asked about Shahnavaz, Sreeshankar said: "He is one of those guys who would always want to improve. He works extremely hard in training and when I see his work ethic, it just tells me how far this guy can go."

Athletics

title favourite after setting a personal best of 8.30m earlier this season, could not replicate that effort due to cramps and a heel injury. He still managed a best jump of 7.87m. "My first and second jumps were fine, but after the third jump, I started getting cramps and also injured my heel. That became the main problem. I had come here hoping to set a personal best because I was in good form," he said.

Basant is a Petty Officer in the Indian Navy and has improved massively under the tutelage of Kumari, with his first breakthrough coming earlier this year at the Junior Federation Cup. "When he jumped 2.21m at the Junior Federation Cup, I could see that he had improved massively. When he started training with me, he used to jump 2.11m," said Sahana.

Basant has been on a phenomenal run in the 2026 season, winning gold at the Asian U20 Athletics Championships. Hailing from Anupgarh village in Sri Ganganagar, Rajasthan, he is part of the rising generation of Indian high jumpers following Sarvesh Kushare's exploits at the World Championships, Diamond League and Commonwealth Games.

Hailing from Pratapgarh in Uttar Pradesh, Shahnavaz has been one of the breakthrough long jumpers of the season. Training alongside Sreeshankar Murali at the National Centre of Excellence (NCoE) in Thiruvananthapuram, Shahnavaz announced himself with his 8.30m

‘DEAN OF SCHOOL OF SOCIAL SCIENCES GAVE PERMISSION, THEN CANCELLED IT’

JNU cancels auditorium booking for discussion on Umar Khalid’s book

University has accused organisers of ‘non-disclosure of the full facts’ about the event

Vidheesha Kuntamalla

New Delhi, August 9



FILE

Umar Khalid has been held in jail without trial on charges under UAPA for almost 6 years.

JAWAHARLAL NEHRU University (JNU) has refused the use of an auditorium in one of its schools that had been booked for a discussion on Umar Khalid’s book citing “non-disclosure of the full facts” about the programme.

Umar Khalid has been held in jail without trial on charges under UAPA for almost six years now. His PhD thesis was published this June as a book titled ‘Fractured Communities: Adivasi Histories and the Politics of Power’.

The cancellation of the booking was communicated in a letter from the School of Social Sciences (SSS) on Sunday, a day before the event, which was scheduled at the SSS-1 Auditorium on campus from 3 pm to 6 pm on August 10.

In a post on X, the university said JNU was a “democratic and decentralised institution”, and that permission for the event had been granted by the Dean of the School of Social Sciences, who had also “taken action” to cancel it.

“The booking of the auditorium SSS-1 stands cancelled because of non-disclosure of the full facts about the program which is going to take place on 10th August 2026 from 3 pm to 6 pm,” the university said in the post.

Like several other posts on JNU’s official X handle, this post too tagged the Vice-Presi-

dent of India, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Prime Minister’s Office, the Office of the Home Minister of India, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, Union Education Minister Pralhad Joshi and the Ministry of Education.

The event, organised by the Jawaharlal Nehru University Students’ Union (JNUSU), was billed as a discussion to mark The International Day of the World’s Indigenous Peoples.

The event poster listed Delhi University professor Prabhu Mohapatra, historian Prof Uma Chakravarti, artist Shuddhabrata Sengupta, author and activist Harsh Mander, and Umar Khalid’s partner Banojyotsna Lahiri as speakers.

Official sources at JNU told *The Indian Express* that the school had earlier allowed the event in “good faith” after students approached the administration to book the auditorium for a program to mark International Indigenous Peoples Day, which was established by the United Nations General Assembly in 1994, and is observed on August 9 every year.

However, the sources

claimed, the students had not disclosed that the event would feature a discussion around Umar Khalid or his book.

‘Breach of trust’

“This is a breach of trust, and the university’s concern is that a matter involving Umar Khalid cannot be discussed at an official university platform while his matter is sub judice,” an official source said.

This source said that “the students should have submitted the pamphlet or details of the program before seeking permission”. According to the source, JNU had not “prohibited the program”, but had advised that it not be “promoted like this”, or organised using the university’s platform.

The organisers of the program, however, disputed the university’s explanation for cancelling the booking, and said the book discussion would be held regardless of whether the auditorium was available.

JNUSU president Aditi Mishra told *The Indian Express* that all the required procedures had been followed.

“All the processes were followed to hold discussions on the book. We had approached the Dean of our school (SSS). We made a payment of over 500 rupees to book the auditorium. But we had been getting calls since yesterday to not hold this event. And today (Sunday) we got this notice. The event will happen outside of SSS at the same time tomorrow (Monday) even if they don’t give us the auditorium,” Mishra said.

Avinash Kumar, JNUTA Secretary and an assistant professor at SSS whose name appeared on the request for booking the auditorium, told *The Indian Express*: “I want to make it clear that the stated reason for the cancellation of the booking of the SSS auditorium is false.

The Dean, School of Social Sciences, was fully informed that the event was going to discuss Umar Khalid’s book ‘Fractured Communities’.

“The JNUSU before reaching out to me had already met and spoken to the Dean and the requisition form was filled as per his advice. So there is no question of lack of full disclosure. And if the full disclosure was not made, then why was permission for the auditorium booking approved and granted in the first place?”

Prof Kumar, who is also an office-bearer of the JNU Teachers’ Association (JNUTA), said the administration should “come clean” on the real reason for the cancellation of the booking.

“Why can’t they permit a discussion on this book in the SSS auditorium? Isn’t this book based on the PhD thesis submitted by Dr Umar Khalid at CHS/SSS/JNU, and was he not granted a PhD degree by JNU for that thesis? The book has been published by a leading publisher (Juggernaut) and there is no reason why a book discussion cannot be held,” he said.

“Instead of making false claims and hollow statements about democracy, the administration should declare under which rule of the university they have unilaterally cancelled without any consultation at any level the venue for the event,” he said.

In a statement issued on Sunday, JNUTA said, “The JNU Students’ Union has already clarified that the Dean was fully informed about the event and the booking of the venue was done as per his advice.”

The Indian Express contacted the Dean of the School of Social Sciences, Prof Vivek Kumar, who declined to comment.

LG orders rotation of long-serving officials, tells govt to redraw list of sensitive depts

Devansh Mittal

New Delhi, August 9

LIEUTENANT GOVERNOR (LG) of Delhi Taranjit Singh Sandhu has directed that officials posted at the same post for extended periods be transferred, and that the list of sensitive departments be redrawn, officials said on Sunday.

This comes two days after the government effected an administrative reshuffle involving 16 IAS and DANICS officers, making changes across the Urban Development, Finance, Environment, Education, Food Safety and Transport departments.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has also recently pushed for a systematic rotation of officials, particularly those who have remained in the same de-



LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu. FILE

partment or assignment for long periods.

Officials had told *The Indian Express* last month that the Delhi government is planning a major administrative reshuffle, with around 60-70% of cadre and ex-cadre officials likely to be transferred. These officials and staffers “have been working in a ‘comfort zone’ for

over five years” in their departments, sources had said.

Sandhu has also directed that Chief Vigilance Officers (CVOs) be posted immediately in all sensitive departments of the Delhi government, according to government sources.

The directions follow a review by the LG of the vigilance systems, processes and practices that have been in place in the Delhi government for over a decade, officials added. He recently met the Principal Secretary (Vigilance), Government of the National Capital Territory of Delhi (GNCTD), on the subject, an official said.

As part of the directions, the existing circular governing postings of longer duration is to be reframed, with all officials posted at one place for long periods to be moved out,

sources said.

The LG has also directed that the government’s list of sensitive departments be reframed. During the review, it emerged that some departments with higher financial allocations had not been included in the list of sensitive departments, while others that were seemingly less sensitive figured on it, according to officials.

Sandhu further directed that a standard mechanism and operational guidelines be devised for CVOs, detailing how they should supervise adherence to the Central Vigilance Commission guidelines in contracts and tender processes. The Vigilance department has also been asked to hold regular meetings of departmental CVOs to review vigilance work, officials added.

AAP says govt sold rice for poor to pvt firm at twice the price; minister refutes charge

Devansh Mittal

New Delhi, August 9

THE AAP on Sunday alleged that the BJP-led government in Delhi had orchestrated a “rice scam” involving subsidised foodgrain meant for the poor. Food and Supplies Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa, however, dismissed the allegations as “false” and “malicious”.

Addressing a press conference, AAP Delhi unit president Saurabh Bharadwaj alleged that on the recommendation of Sirsa’s department, the Food Corporation of India (FCI) agreed to supply 31,000 metric tonnes of rice every week to an Assam-based corporation at a heavily subsidised rate. Instead of the grain being distributed among the poor, he further alleged, it was sold to a private company in Haryana at twice the price.

Bharadwaj claimed that the rice, procured for Rs 23 per kg, was allegedly being sold to a private vendor in the open market at Rs 46 per kg. “This means



Food and Supplies Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa; (right) AAP Delhi president Saurabh Bharadwaj. FILE



that approximately Rs 23 in commission was being earned on every kilogram of rice. In other words, 31,000 metric tonnes of rice was being sold for Rs 143 crore every week, while Rs 70-71 crore was being earned as commission. According to the plan, if this continued for three years, rice worth a total of Rs 22,000 crore would be sold to the private company, and Rs 11,000 crore was earned as commission,” he alleged.

According to Bharadwaj’s allegations, the Assam-based corporation wrote to Sirsa on January 7, offering procurement

and distribution of cheap rice among Delhi’s poor. He claimed the Minister kept the letter pending for four months before marking it on April 8 to the Special Commissioner, rather than the Secretary or Food Commissioner, with a note that it be considered positively as per rules. The same day, he alleged, Additional Commissioner Arun Kumar Jha emailed the FCI calling the matter “urgent”, followed by further emails on April 13, 16 and 17.

Bharadwaj claimed Jha was suspended after the Centre’s vigilance department detected

the arrangement. “It is completely wrong to suspend only officer Arun Kumar Jha... officials are being made scapegoats while the Minister and the Chief Minister are being protected,” he alleged.

“The Centre should now have the ED and CBI investigate the matter and should seek the resignation of the Minister and the Chief Minister,” Burari MLA Sanjeev Jha said.

“Sh. Saurabh Bharadwaj and Sh. Sanjeev Jha have today again made baseless, false, fabricated and malicious allegations against me, clearly intended to defame and malign me. Such a malicious campaign appears to be their modus operandi...,” Sirsa posted on X.

“I give both Saurabh Bharadwaj and Sanjeev Jha 24 hours to withdraw these false allegations and issue a public apology, failing which I shall be constrained to initiate appropriate legal proceedings against both of them and hold them accountable for these malicious acts. Apology or will meet in court,” he stated.

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New Delhi

From forged documents to fake bank auctions, how Delhi's richest property buyers were sold luxury homes that were never on the market, reports **Pragynesh**

NO. 9, Amrita Shergill Marg is one of the most exclusive addresses in Delhi. Minutes from the Prime Minister's residence, embassies and Parliament, the Lutyens' Delhi bungalow would almost never be expected to come up for sale.

Police said 38-year-old businessman Mohit Gogia, who has been arrested, allegedly used the luxury status of the property to pull off his biggest scam.

He allegedly tried to sell the bungalow to realtor Sonakshi Bansal, daughter of Unity Group co-founder and director Krishna Kumar Agrawal, claiming that it had been seized by SBI and would be sold through a bank auction for around Rs 75 crore.

Police said the claim was backed by forged documents, making the property the centrepiece of an alleged Rs 200-crore property fraud.

Gogia's victims, police claimed, were not first-time buyers but seasoned real estate developers who coveted premium properties like No. 9, Amrita Shergill Marg DLF Camellias and Magnolias in Gurgaon.

Over the last several months, Delhi Police's Economic Offences Wing (EOW) arrested six people involved in the alleged fraud, including Gogia, his wife Shweta and businessman Abhinav Pathak.

The beginning

On a humid August afternoon in 2024, Bansal met Gogia at her Black Teak Realty real estate advisory firm. Gogia had come to her office on the fifth floor of Agrawal Towers — an eight-storey red-brick building in Central Delhi's Rajendra Nagar — with Pathak, a family friend and the proprietor of the Delhi-based Abhinav Biotech.

"He asked if he could buy a penthouse in one of our developments, and told us he was a real estate dealer, and along with his wife Shweta Gogia, ran a firm called MG Leasing and Finance... He also told us that he is looking for partners to 'develop' (as a joint venture) a parcel of land he had in Gurgaon's Sector 63," Bansal said in her statement to the police.

Gogia allegedly said his company was authorised under the 2002 Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (SARFAESI) Act to sell properties that banks confiscate from loan defaulters.

As Gogia started frequenting the Agrawals' office in Rajendra Nagar to discuss the Gurgaon land deal, the family decided to verify his background.

They found that he owned a whole floor with lavish interiors in an upscale locality of Patel Nagar, and a Lamborghini sports car. He also owned the Obello chain of luxury salons in Delhi and was hailed as an up-and-coming entrepreneur of the "luxury and auction market" in an article in a leading Indian publication on June 20, 2025, said police.

In September 2024, Gogia made what police said was his biggest gambit.

According to Bansal's complaint, Gogia overheard Krishna Kumar Agrawal saying his family was thinking of buying a house in Vasant Vihar and offered him the even more exclusive address at the heart of Lutyens' — 9, Amrita Shergill Marg.

By then, police said, months of meetings over the proposed Gurgaon joint venture had taken place. Gogia had become a familiar face at the Agrawals' office.

"He informed my father about a property at No. 9, Amrita Shergill Marg, Lodhi Estate and assured it will be made available through SBI under an auction at about Rs 75 crore," Bansal said in her complaint, now part of the FIR.

"I, along with my husband, father and brother visited the site and noted that there were two properties 9 and 9A Amrita Shergill Marg... Mohit Gogia clarified that both properties would be made available together."

A bungalow on Amrita Shergill Marg can cost up to Rs 100 crore. But Gogia, police said, claimed that the property, along with the adjoining 9A, would cost Rs 75 crore — three-quarters of the price of one. He allegedly assured the family that he had access to the bank's auction process and could secure the property before it reached the open market.

Bansal allegedly told police that a security guard at the property told her that the property was with SBI.

A source in the police, however, said that SBI never listed the property for auction. "The SBI confirmed to us that it had never listed the bungalow for auction, but it had been mortgaged as collateral for a third-party loan," the source added.

Bansal told police that by October 2024, she had paid Rs 43 crore of the Rs 75 crore. For the remaining amount, she was told she could get a loan from SBI.

Simultaneously, Gogia allegedly prom-



No. 9, Amrita Shergill Marg in Lutyens' Delhi and (left) 6 B, Rajendra Nagar, accused Mohit Gogia's last known address. PRAGYNESH

CONNING DELHI'S ELITE



Mohit Gogia almost sold the Ambience Mall in Gurgaon for around Rs 180 crore, police found during probe. RENUKA PURI



A woman paid Mohit Gogia Rs 12.5 crore after being promised an apartment in Gurgaon's upscale DLF Camellias. RENUKA PURI

ised to sell the developed Sector 63 Gurgaon plot to Bansal's cousin and business partner, Mrinal Mittal, for Rs 60 crore.

Police alleged the two transactions together accounted for around Rs 135 crore, making them the largest among the cases currently being probed by the EOW.

The delay

Gogia's promises soon gave way to excuses, said police.

According to Bansal's complaint, Gogia first blamed income tax raids in November 2024. "He told us to be patient," Bansal said in her complaint, adding that Gogia then promised to hand over possession of the two Amrita Shergill Marg properties by March 2025.

But two months later, Bansal was still awaiting possession.

Gogia allegedly claimed the property could not be released because of an outstanding second mortgage of Rs 1.3 crore. According to the complaint, Bansal issued another cheque to clear the amount.

She was then allegedly given what Gogia claimed were property papers and house keys. However, Bansal still did not get possession of the properties.

When the family confronted Gogia in May, he allegedly handed them post-dated cheques for the money that Bansal had paid, telling them to encash the cheques if they did not get possession by the end of the month.

The cheques allegedly bounced. In June 2025, the family approached Delhi Police. The case was later transferred to the EOW.

No. 9, Amrita Shergill Marg

Nestled side-by-side on a particularly verdant stretch of Amrita Shergill Marg and separated only by a shared boundary wall, bungalows 9 and 9A are like many other old Central Delhi houses — multi-storeyed homes lying almost entirely covered by lush neem and gulmohar trees.

Bungalow No. 9 — the first property offered to Bansal — lies vacant. But 9A bears unmistakable signs of occupation, from a nameplate to the SUVs parked outside.

"The owner passed away a few years ago. His wife, daughter and other family members live here now," said Shambhu, a security guard posted outside.

A woman, who identified herself as the owner's daughter, denied knowing anything about the sale of the property. "These bungalows have been in my family for years," she said.

The victims

By the time the two Unity Group FIRs reached the EOW, investigators were already probing other cases against Gogia. What they allegedly did not know was the scale of the operation, with investigators finding at least 12 cases against Gogia across India.

One of Gogia's victims was Braham Singh Tanwar.

The 56-year-old real estate dealer from Mehrauli first met Gogia in May 2024 while trying to buy a second-hand luxury car.

"He came to meet me in a black Mercedes Maybach, and took me to his salon in Rajender Nagar, where some Range Rovers and BMW 7 Series were parked. After we wrapped up a deal for some Fortuners, he offered to sell me a land parcel in Gurgaon and a flat in DLF Magnolias for Rs 31 crore," Tanwar said.

One of Gurgaon's most luxurious apartment complexes, a flat at DLF Magnolias typically costs between Rs 42 and Rs 85 crore. For Tanwar, Rs 31 crore seemed like a bargain.

Gogia's paperwork looked impeccable, Tanwar said, with bank letterheads, 'bank confirmations' and authentic-looking barcodes that would take clients to what seemed like a bank website.

Another alleged victim was a woman who paid Gogia Rs 12.5 crore after being promised an apartment in Gurgaon's super-luxury residential property, DLF Camellias. On November 22, last year, Gogia was arrested in the case.

"Further, we got to know that he had once almost sold the Ambience Mall, Gurgaon, to someone for something close to Rs 180 crore," said an officer.

Police said that as per Pathak, Gogia had initially attempted to sell the mall to him. "When a case was registered against Pathak and Gogia by EOW, Pathak filed a counter complaint alleging that Gogia had told him that he is buying the mall for Rs 500 crore and that Pathak could have a share in it," said an officer.

● Fraud and forgery

● Gogia's victims, police claimed, were not first-time buyers but seasoned real estate developers.

● His claim was backed by forged documents, making the 9, Amrita Shergill Marg property the centrepiece of an alleged Rs 200-crore fraud.

● Investigators found that at least 12 cases were registered against Gogia across India.

● Accused told police that if anyone filed a complaint or court case, they would identify a new party and use the money to repay the complainant.

"It was extraordinary... the best of lawyers, the richest of families, were being taken for a ride by a college dropout," the officer added.

The backstory

Gogia was born in 1987 in South Delhi's Malviya Nagar to a businessman father and a homemaker mother. One of two siblings, he dropped out of college in the second year and joined a private firm, where he met his now-wife Shweta, with whom he has two children.

In 2012, he started a financial services company and expanded into buying and selling second-hand cars before opening MG Finance and Leasing in 2016. In his disclosure statement, he mentioned owning restaurants and clubs in Delhi, Mumbai and Bhopal.

His last known address is 6 B Rajendra Nagar — a house just 7 km from the Amrita Shergill Marg bungalow.

A typical Delhi Richie loft, it occupies the third floor of a building every bit as ostentatious as the realtor: boxy with a classical façade, ornate wrought-iron railings along its elongated balconies, and decorative vertical columns on its walls.

"I had never seen one person with so many cars," said Krishna Kumar Singh, a security guard at the Rajendra Nagar building. "Luxury cars kept coming and going."

The probe

His arrest last November was not Gogia's first brush with the law. He was first arrested two months earlier in an alleged cheating case involving 181 acres in Punjab's Zirakpur, but was eventually released on bail. Investigators alleged he went on the run anticipating another arrest.

After Gogia, four others, including Pathak, were arrested. All of them are currently in judicial custody. Police said they are investigating the role of Ram Singh (49), a "strongman" financier from West Delhi who could even be the mastermind.

A Class 8 dropout, Ram Singh started Baba Ji Finance, a private lending firm in Subhash Nagar that offers unorganised loans and dabbles in property brokerage, with his wife in 2005.

According to his disclosure report, he has only one employee. Yet all the accused,

including Gogia, have allegedly identified him as their boss.

In his disclosure statements, Gogia alleged that he first met Ram Singh in 2022 and parked his money with Baba Ji Finance for high returns. "In July-August 2023, Ram Singh suggested that we should collect a large amount of money from the market," Gogia allegedly told police. "We planned to collect advance money on the pretext of selling disputed and mortgaged properties."

While Gogia would identify seized properties from publicly available bank records, scout for potential targets and forge documents, others would help procure mule accounts. For his alleged role, Gogia would secure 30% of the cheated sum.

"If anyone filed a police complaint or court case against us, we would identify a new party and use their money to repay the complainant," Gogia said in his statement to the police.

The collapse

But IT raids in 2024 allegedly put a spanner in the works.

Gogia was allegedly forced to pay Rs 3.5 crore in dues, leaving him broke. It could not have come at a worse time: he was trying to snag his most profitable client, the Unity Group family.

"People started pressuring us to return their money. The complaints and criminal cases started," he allegedly told the police.

Days after Gogia's arrest, Delhi Police asked Ram Singh to join the probe. Singh, however, ignored the summons for five months, prompting a local court to issue a non-bailable warrant.

Singh is yet to be arrested, but during his questioning, he had denied the allegations. On Gogia, he claimed to have merely "transferred him money for investment into his property business".

But back in Gogia's old area of Rajinder Nagar, memories of the man who allegedly swindled some of the most elite families of Delhi have begun fading.

At his old building, his name now elicits a confused silence.

"Kaun Gogia?" one neighbour asked, before turning to security guard Krishna. "Yahan Mohit Gogia naam ka bhi koi tha? (Did a man named Mohit Gogia ever live here?)"

Quota for SC/ST: Mayawati says Bhagwat remark reflects RSS's 'casteist mindset'

Express News Service
Lucknow, August 9

BAHUJAN SAMAJ Party chief Mayawati on Sunday hit out at the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh over its recent remarks on caste-based reservation, saying the debate over the "creamy layer" for SC and ST communities was contrary to the constitutional objective of reservation, while accusing the Sangh of reflecting a "casteist mindset".

In a series of posts, Mayawati said reservation for the SC, ST and OBC communities was an issue of "social transformation and economic emancipation" and intrinsically linked to their "self-respect".

For SC and ST communities, she said, reservation was particularly important as caste-based "hatred, exploitation, persecution, injustice and atrocities had not ended".

"Discussing the creamy layer in this context is not only inappropriate but also contrary to the sacred objectives of the supremely venerable Baba Saheb Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar's humanitarian Constitution," she said. Her remarks were in reference to the RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat's statements, where he had said reservation had been "deliberately politicised" and was creating "bitterness in society". The Sangh supremo had also said that beneficiaries should voluntarily give up the benefits of reservation.

Mayawati said that his statement "truly reflects their casteist mindset", adding that reservation was not something that could be judged merely on the basis of economic progress.

"Reservation is fundamentally about granting constitutional and legal rights to equality and equity on a human basis to millions of exploited, victimised, neglected, and scorned people who have suffered under the casteist system for centuries," she said.

"The venom of casteism continues to bite them in every aspect of life," she added.

Counting best bets: Congress presses for early talks with Samajwadi Party

Maulshree Seth
Lucknow, August 9

WITH THE 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections still months away, the Congress is pushing for an early start to seat-sharing talks with ally Samajwadi Party (SP), arguing that the alliance should be built around "winnable" seats rather than the number of constituencies each party contests.

Both parties are conducting separate surveys of all 403 Assembly constituencies to assess their electoral prospects. Congress leaders say the exercise is intended to identify seats where the party's organisational presence, combined with the SP's support base and vote share, could make the alliance competitive. The push for early negotiations is rooted in the Congress's assessment of the 2017 Assembly election, when the parties entered into an alliance but failed to translate the understanding into effective constituency-level coordination.

"Because of late negotiations and lack of adequate coordination at the constituency level, the alliance could not be reflected on the ground (in the previous Assembly polls)," said a Congress leader, who attended a recent meeting of the party's Uttar Pradesh MPs with Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi and AICC general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on the sidelines of the ongoing Parliament session.

The meeting came, sources said, after SP chief Akhilesh Yadav met Gandhi and Priyanka in Delhi.

According to leaders, the broad view was that negotiations should begin early and that seat-sharing should be based not on a numerical formula but on which constituencies offer the alliance the best chance of victory.

"We are clear about one

thing. We want our CM in place but that is up to the SP. We want to increase our presence in the state. For that, it is important to contest 'quality' seats," a party leader said.

The approach reflects the Congress's immediate objective in Uttar Pradesh: rebuilding its Assembly presence and organisational base rather than maximising the number of seats it contests.

The Congress currently has a limited presence in the Assembly and leaders argue that a constituency should not become the party's preserve simply because it has contested it repeatedly.

The surveys being conducted by the two parties are expected to examine previous electoral performance, caste combinations, organisational strength, candidate potential and the extent to which the votes of the two parties can be transferred to each other.

"In an earlier meeting, it was decided that we should prepare for all 403 seats and strengthen the organisation. But as the elections approach, we need to identify the seats where caste combinations and the support of the SP can turn them into winnable seats for the Congress," another Congress MP said.

Congress leaders also see early seat selection as a way of preventing a division of Opposition votes and avoiding contests between alliance partners that could benefit the BJP-led NDA.

The SP, however, is seemingly treading cautiously. A senior party leader told *The Indian Express* that the SP could not comment on the Congress's "internal affairs" and that decisions regarding alliances are taken by top leaders. "We have a bigger stake than the Congress in the 2027 Assembly polls. The seat-sharing would be on the basis of the winability of the candidates," the leader added.



Har Ghar Tiranga Yatra flagged off

Union Home Minister Amit Shah flags off the 'Har Ghar Tiranga Yatra' in Puducherry on Sunday. Tiranga yatras were also held in other states, including UP, Rajasthan, Manipur, MP and Odisha. PTI

Amid tensions over Hasina, Trivedi may call on Bangladesh PM today for BRICS invite

Divya A
New Delhi, August 9

AMID TENSIONS over ousted Bangladesh leader Sheikh Hasina's media event in Delhi last week, High Commissioner Dinesh Trivedi said that an upcoming meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Dhaka counterpart, Tarique Rahman, will iron out the issues between the two nations.

His comment, made at an event at the Indian Visa Application Centre in the Bangladesh capital on Sunday, comes days after Dhaka expressed 'outrage' at Hasina's virtual press conference, which India's Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) was quick to dismiss any role in, while maintaining that it does not endorse anything said at the forum.

"When two leaders meet, a lot of problems are solved. I have

full confidence [about the problem being resolved in the meeting]," Trivedi said on Sunday, adding, "We all respect Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman a lot. He is a people's person, and so is our PM."

Last week, Hasina in her Delhi address said that she was determined to return to Bangladesh in December to put the country on the "right track" by restoring democracy, notwithstanding the risk of facing the threat of imprisonment or a death sentence.

In a statement soon after, Bangladesh's Foreign Ministry expressed outrage over the interaction saying the event hurt the sentiments of its people and could adversely affect efforts to improve bilateral ties with India.

Rahman's foreign advisor, Humayun Kabir, too, had flagged during a meeting with



When two leaders meet, a lot of problems are solved: Envoy to Bangladesh Dinesh Trivedi

Trivedi that such activities [in reference to Hasina's press conference] could undermine the positive progress in Bangladesh-India relations.

In response, the envoy assured Kabir that the matter would be considered appropriately, saying the Indian side

Rahul Navin's tenure as ED Director extended by 1 year

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 9

THE TENURE of Enforcement Directorate (ED) Director Rahul Navin has been extended by a year beyond August 13, a government order issued on Saturday read.

A 1993-batch Indian Revenue Service officer of the Income Tax cadre, 59-year-old Navin has been leading the federal anti-money laundering agency as its full-time chief since August 14, 2024.

The order issued by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet said it has "approved an extension in tenure of Rahul Navin as ED Director for a period of one year beyond August 13, 2026, i.e. up to August 13, 2027, including extension in service beyond the date of his superannuation, that is July 31, 2027, or until further orders, whichever is earlier".

During Navin's tenure, ED has continued and launched

several high-profile investigations, including against multiple online money gaming companies and real estate giants engaged in fraud.

In September 2023, Navin was made acting director of the agency. Before the appointment, he was working as Special Director-Chief Vigilance Officer (ED headquarters).

Holding B Tech and M Tech from IIT-Kanpur and an MBA from the Swinburne University of Technology in Melbourne, Navin has also authored several books, journals and articles on various international taxation and transfer pricing issues related to direct taxation.

The ED investigates financial crimes under two criminal laws — the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) and the Fugitive Economic Offenders Act (FEOA), apart from the civil provisions of the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA).

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WORLD BIOFUEL DAY

Building a cleaner future through bioenergy

World Biofuel Day highlights the growing role of renewable fuels in strengthening energy security and supporting a more sustainable economy.

OBERVED every year on 10th August, World Biofuel Day draws attention to the potential of renewable fuels as an alternative to conventional fossil fuels. The day is also known for the German inventor Sir Rudolf Diesel, whose early experiments showed the possibility of using vegetable oil to power engines. Years later, the idea has acquired renewed significance as countries look for a cleaner, more diverse and locally available source of energy.

Biofuels are usually produced from organic materials such as crops, agricultural residues, animal waste and other forms of biomass. Unlike fossil fuels, these resources can be replenished through natural and agricultural cycles. Ethanol, biodiesel, compressed biogas and sustainable aviation fuel are among the important forms of bioenergy gaining attention across the world.

communities with the country's clean energy ambitions. Moreover, agricultural residues, cooking oil, cattle dung and other organic resources can acquire economic value when they enter organised supply chains. This can create additional avenues of income for farmers and rural enterprises while encouraging better management of biomass. The growth of biogas and compressed biogas projects can also support local economies by creating opportunities in collection, processing, transportation and plant operations.

Turning agricultural residues into opportunity
Biofuels play a significant role when it comes to making energy transitions more environmentally responsible. When produced from suitable feed-

stocks and through efficient processes, they can help reduce emissions over their lifecycle compared with conventional fossil fuels. They can also contribute to reducing the open burning of agricultural residues, a persistent challenge in several parts of the country.

However, the benefits of bioenergy depend on how responsibly it is developed. Ensuring sustainable access to feedstock, improving conversion technologies, and using land and water resources judiciously will be essential to building a biofuel ecosystem that delivers environmental gains without creating new ecological challenges.

Building the next chapter of biodiversity
The future of biofuels will depend on

innovation, investment and a reliable ecosystem connecting producers, farmers, industries and consumers. Several advances in technologies such as 2G ethanol and sustainable aviation fuel are expanding the range of materials that can be converted into useful energy.

World Biofuel Day therefore offers more than an occasion to discuss an alternative fuel. It highlights a broad shift in the way energy can be produced and consumed. By turning agricultural resources, organic waste and other renewable materials into valuable energy, biofuels can support a cleaner pathway that represents an opportunity to combine environmental responsibility with economic growth and rural development.

Biogas: Powering India's Sustainable and Energy-Secure Future

BIOGAS is a dependable renewable energy source that delivers clean, uninterrupted energy 24x7 throughout the year. India currently utilizes only about 10% of its biomass potential, leaving vast opportunities for growth. In addition to generating renewable energy, biogas supports the Swachh Bharat Mission, enhances soil health through organic manure, promotes a circular economy, creates rural employment, and significantly reduces greenhouse gas emissions. Through Government of India initiatives such as NBMMP, BPGP, and SATAT, biogas is transforming dairy farms, poultry farms, gaushalas, temples, hotels, industries, townships, and urban local bodies while reducing dependence on imported LPG and fossil fuels.

GAJANAN PATIL
Managing Director
Urja Bio system Pvt. Ltd. - Pune

India's Biofuel Revolution: Fueling a Sustainable Future

INDIA is witnessing a remarkable biofuel revolution, with ethanol playing a pivotal role in reducing crude oil imports, lowering carbon emissions, and strengthening the nation's energy security. Under the leadership of Hon'ble Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India achieved 20% ethanol blending ahead of the 2025 target, marking a major step towards sustainable development. Union Minister Shri Nitin Gadkari has strongly advocated ethanol as a clean, affordable and farmer-friendly fuel. Universal Forces Industries Pvt. Ltd. (UFIPL) is contributing to this transformation by developing advanced 1G and 2G ethanol plants, reducing production costs and supporting India's vision of a greener, self-reliant energy future.

PRADEEP DHOKARE
Owner, Universal Forces Industries Pvt. Ltd.

Building a more diverse energy from within

For a changing economy like India, energy security is actively linked with economic security. This means reducing excessive dependency on imported fossil fuels, leading to strengthening the resilience of the energy system while supporting domestic sources of production. Biofuels offer an opportunity to diversify this energy basket by making greater use of resources that are already available within the country.

The agricultural sector in India at large offers considerable scope in this regard. Crop residues and other biomass have the potential to become useful inputs for producing energy. This creates the possibility of addressing two challenges together- managing agricultural waste and generating cleaner fuel.

Adding new economic value to rural resources

A significant advantage of the biofuel economy is its potential to connect rural

Biofuel Day, celebrated every year on 10th August, highlights the bridge between sustainable energy, rural livelihoods and India's ambition for greater energy independence

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Hike Hopes

SUPREME COURT Judge B V Nagarathna has advised cadets outboarded from the armed forces due to disability suffered during training to approach the 8th Pay Commission regarding ex gratia grievances. Presiding over a two-judge bench, Justice Nagarathna said earlier this week that the Pay Commission this time is headed by a former woman judge and hence would be more "compassionate". She added that even judges were expecting a raise this time. "You make a representation (to the Commission). Make an attempt. We now have a former lady judge, Justice Ranjana Prakash Desai, heading the Commission. I'm sure we will have more compassion this time. We are also expecting that. Judges also, once in 10 years, get a raise," she said.

Women Pavilion

The four-day Bharatiya Vya-par Mahotsav 2026, being organised at Bharat Mandapam from August 12 to 15 by the Confederation of All India Traders (CAIT), will have a special platform for women entrepreneurs, artists and innovators — 'Nari Vandan Pavilion' — highlighting the connection between women's empowerment and economic development. The Expo, aimed at helping traders and entrepreneurs understand the changing global trade landscape, identify new international markets and explore export opportunities for Indian products, will be inaugurated by Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

Collegium names four judges for elevation as CJs

New Delhi: The Supreme Court Collegium has recommended names of four judges for appointment as Chief Justices of Patna, Calcutta, Bombay and Punjab and Haryana High Courts.

It recommended that Bombay HC Acting Chief Justice Ravindra Vithalrao Ghuge be appointed the Chief Justice of the Calcutta HC. Delhi HC judge Justice V Kameswar Rao's name has been proposed as Chief Justice of Patna HC, and Allahabad HC judge Mahesh Chandra Tripathi has been recommended as Chief Justice of the Bombay HC.

The Collegium met on August 6 decided to recommend Acting Chief Justice of Punjab and Haryana HC Ashwani Kumar Mishra as the Chief Justice of that court. It also recommended transfer of Orissa HC judges Manish Ranjan Pathak and Krushna Ram Mohapatra to Gujarat and Chattisgarh HC, respectively.

ENS

'RECONSIDER CHOICE': STUDENTS PEN LETTER TO VICE-CHANCELLOR

450 NALSAR students urge varsity not to invite CJI to convocation

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, August 9

A SECTION OF students at the NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad, have opposed having Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant as the chief guest at their upcoming convocation. The university has a total of 1,400 students.

About 450 students of the university from different batches, including the outgoing LLB and LLM batch, have written to the Vice Chancellor, the Registrar and Professors of the university requesting them not to invite the CJI, citing his recent comments with regard to a petition against alleged police excesses during the NEET protests last month.

The university is yet to announce the date of convocation or confirm who would be the chief guest. Traditionally, though, the incumbent CJI has been delivering the convocation address at NALSAR for years.

In light of the students' opposition, there is a chance that the university will scrap the

convocation ceremony this year, a faculty member said, pleading anonymity.

The first representation to the authorities was sent on July 23 by 70 members of the outgoing batch of LLB students. By July 25, classes of 2027, 2028, 2029, 2030, and 2031, comprising about 380 students, expressed solidarity with the statement and issued their separate letters to the university administration.

On July 22, the Supreme Court had declined to initiate suo motu proceedings to take cognizance of alleged police excesses during the July 20 crackdown on student protesters in Delhi. When a lawyer submitted that there was video-graphic evidence of police brutality, CJI Kant orally declined to examine the videos, saying that the court's time should not be "wasted".

In their first letter written a day after this comment, the students wrote, "Our concerns arise from the refusal of the Honourable Supreme Court Bench by the Hon'ble CJI to allow urgent listing of a plea



Students' concern pertains to a petition that was refused urgent listing by CJI Surya Kant

concerning the brutal police action against protesters... A convocation is meant to be a moment where the University's own values, including a commitment to constitutional rights, access to justice and reasoned engagement with grievances are visibly reflected in the choices it makes. We feel that receiving our degrees from a dignitary whose recent public conduct... appears dismissive of serious allegations of police brutality against protesting

citizens sits uncomfortably with what we have been taught to value during our time at NALSAR... We would therefore request the university to strongly reconsider the choice of Chief Guest for this convocation..."

In the next couple of days, several students of different batches at NALSAR wrote to the university administration on the same lines. The 2029 passing-out batch wrote, "...We find ourselves in agreement with the concerns articulated by the graduating batch. We also believe that their representation raises questions that extend beyond the immediate interests of one graduating class and instead, concern the Constitutional ethos that Nalsar seeks to embody."

As per the letter written by the 2028 batch, the students stand in "vehement opposition" to the presence of the current CJI at the convocation.

The letter from the 2030 batch of students was more direct in its wording. It read, "As reported on record (CJI made the comments) 'Please don't

waste our time. We don't have time to watch these videos'. Even in the past, the CJI had made a statement calling youth "parasites and cockroaches attacking the system"... we believe that such conduct from the highest office of justice in India does not embody what our Constitution stands for and does not align with the values NALSAR has stood by throughout its history."

To be sure, the CJI had issued a clarification, saying he had been "misquoted" by sections of the media and that his criticism was directed solely at those who had joined different professions through "fake or bogus degrees".

When *The Indian Express* reached out to the NALSAR university administration, the V-C was unavailable for comment. A senior member of the faculty, however, said, "The administration has been very tight-lipped about this. There are talks that they could cancel the convocation this time around to prevent further embarrassment to the Chief Justice of India."

Vande Mataram will not be sung in full in Kerala: State Minister

Press Trust of India
Thiruvananthapuram/
Kasaragod, August 9

Kerala Health Minister K Murali-leedharan and Congress MP Rajmohan Unnithan on Sunday said that the full version of *Vande Mataram* will not be sung in Kerala.

Murali-leedharan told reporters that in Kerala, as always, only the first two couplets of the national song will be sung. "In all state government programmes only the first two couplets were sung in the past, and that practice will continue even now," he said.

Unnithan said that the full rendition of *Vande Mataram* will not take place in Kerala "in this lifetime". He also said, while speaking to a TV channel, that while he was unaware of any direction by the Chief Secretary for the complete rendition of the national song, it will not be sung in full "even if Narendra Modi threatens to shoot us down".

Both of them were responding to an August 6 letter of Kerala Chief Secretary Bishwanath Sinha, stating that the 2026 edition of the campaign, launched in 2022 under Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav, had been integrated with the third phase of the nationwide commemoration of 150 years of the National Song *Vande Mataram*, as approved by the National Implementation Committee chaired by Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

All physical celebrations during the period would combine collective singing of *Vande Mataram* with the hoisting or display of the National Flag, while digital participation would be routed through the Har Ghar Tiranga portal, where citizens could upload their "Selfie with Tricolour", the letter has said.

EXPRESS special

After Bihar setback, will upper-caste discontent hurt BJP in Uttar Pradesh

Lalmani Verma & Vikas Pathak
Lucknow, New Delhi, August 9

FOLLOWING ITS defeat in the Bankipur bypoll in Bihar, sections of the BJP believe the pressure from the upper castes, one of the party's oldest support bases, is likely to increase as the Uttar Pradesh polls approach.

The ruling party has been facing pushback from the upper castes in the state since the University Grants Commission's (UGC) equity regulations sparked protests earlier this year. On August 3, the Rajput Karni Sena organised a rally in Jaipur against the now-stayed regulations — the police used force to stop the protesters from marching to the BJP office — showing that the pressure may be building up in other pockets of the Hindi heartland, too.

These developments have played out against the backdrop of the protest at Delhi's Jantar Mantar. The BJP believes that the agitation received the sort of firepower not seen in the last 12 years because the issue of exam reforms directly affects urban, upper-caste families, a traditional support base for the party. "It began with the Ambedkarites. Then the Left entered the protest. But it was the large participation and sympathy from the upper castes that made the movement difficult to handle," said a BJP leader.

UP leaders cautious

After Bankipur, the BJP identified distress among the upper castes over the UGC regulations as a key factor behind its loss. And now, it is wary of a similar repercussion in UP.

The regulations notified this January were meant to address discrimination, including caste-



Rajput Karni Sena supporters stage a protest over the UGC equity regulations, in Jaipur on August 3. FILE PHOTO ROHIT JAIN PARAS

based prejudice, in higher education institutions. However, they triggered protests and calls for their withdrawal among sections of mostly upper-caste students. These groups claimed that the rules could create divisions over caste and result in "harassment" of students in the general category. The Supreme Court later stayed the regulations, observing that they raise important questions which, if left unexamined, could have "very sweeping consequences" and "divide society".

Several UP BJP leaders from the Brahmin and Thakur communities said there was simmering anger over the regulations and they were still finding it hard to pacify their communities.

"They argue that upper castes stood with the BJP in its time of struggle and during the Ram Janmabhoomi movement when OBCs and Dalits had not consolidated behind the party as Hindus. They fought for the BJP in booths. They question why the same BJP had taken a decision that has damaged them," said a BJP leader the Brahmin community in Sultanpur.

Another Brahmin leader in

adjoining Pratapgarh district said the party believes the community will vote for it despite its anger. "A section of Brahmins is saying that they may vote for the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) if they decide to go against the BJP. They are unlikely to support the Samajwadi Party (SP) as they are not comfortable with their Yadav vote bank."

An upper-caste leader in Ayodhya said BJP functionaries were uncomfortable about answering questions on issues such as UGC regulations and exam paper leaks. "It would have been better had Dharmendra Pradhan resigned as Education Minister over the UGC regulation issue, instead of resigning later under pressure from students protesting on paper leaks. His resignation on the UGC issue would have sent a favourable message among the upper castes," said the functionary.

An upper-caste leader in Lakshimpur Kheri said the anger was directed more at the Centre than the Yogi Adityanath-led state government because UGC was part of the Union government's domain. "But just like Thakurs voted against the BJP in the 2024

elections, and Brahmins in the recent Bankipur bypoll, the upper castes are threatening to vote along similar lines in 2027 UP polls. The central leadership must provide a remedy as it cannot afford to lose UP if it has to retain power in the Centre in 2029."

Leadership's message

Last month, in a series of closed-door meetings, BJP president Nitin Nabin urged party colleagues not to view such matters through the prism of their own caste. "Nabinji had assured that the intention behind the UGC regulations was not wrong and the government would course-correct," said a leader who attended the meet.

At one meeting, BJP general secretary (organisation) B L Santhosh urged UP BJP leaders to deal with the UGC issue "carefully" and inform people about the steps the government had taken so far. "He said some wrong use of words in the notification had led to a negative message," a leader said.

In Rajasthan, the upper-caste mobilisation against the BJP has occurred through the Rajput Karni Sena, which decided to protest against the UGC regulations in Jaipur. Like the upper castes in Bankipur, their dissatisfaction with the BJP stems from what they see as the party's emphasis on the OBCs, Dalits, and other marginalised groups.

"We will now undertake a campaign in Haryana," Rajput Karni Sena spokesperson Vijendra Singh said.

However, the general sense among Rajputs in Rajasthan is that as of now the discontent remains contained among sections of the Karni Sena. The Rajput group's campaign has not yet drawn the support of influential figures from the community.

'Gen Z belongs to us': Pradhan breaks silence, says nothing more important than country

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, August 9

FORMER UNION Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, who resigned following intense protests over the NEET paper leak issue, said his ministerial responsibilities were insignificant before the aspirations of the new generation of the country.

Addressing a gathering in his Parliamentary constituency, Sambalpur, on Saturday, Pradhan said he tried to explain the reality about the resolve of the new generation to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who later engaged directly with the Gen Z.

"I belong to the land where legends like Bhimabhoi, Utkalmani Gopabandhu Das and Gangadhar Meher were born. My responsibility is nothing before the resolve of the new generation people. There is nothing more important than the country's interest," said Pradhan, his first public statement weeks after submitting his resignation.

Pradhan, who was a key figure in the Modi government ever since the NDA came to power in 2014, appreciated the new generation, saying their aspirations can't be ignored.

"The Gen Z belongs to us ... Some people tried to deceive the Gen Z. Around 20 crore (people of) new generation in the country have a great re-

sponsibility on their shoulders to make India the Viswaguru," said Pradhan, adding the government is committed to fulfilling their aspirations.

Citing the sacrifices made by noted freedom fighters such as Veer Surendra Sai and others, the former minister said historically, it is the youth who led the change and offered sacrifices.

Pradhan, among the prominent figures of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) from Odisha, received a rousing reception on Saturday as he travelled from Bhubaneswar to his constituency by road.

BJP leaders in various Assembly constituencies in the state accorded a warm welcome to Pradhan on his journey to Sambalpur, proving his enduring dominance among the BJP cadres in Odisha.

BJP sources said Pradhan would tour across Odisha in the days to come.

In the eye of a storm over the NEET-UG exam paper leak, which sparked widespread protests, Pradhan resigned as the education minister on July 25.

Pradhan's resignation was the primary demand made by youth protesters at the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protest site in Delhi as well as a precondition for the Congress and other Opposition parties for debating a tough new law against the issue scheduled to be tabled in Parliament.

Revanth set for 'Varuna Yagam' today to seek rain in Telangana

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, August 9

ON AUGUST 10, Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy will perform a 'Varuna Yagam' on the banks of the Nagarjuna Sagar Dam to seek "bountiful rain in Telangana", according to the CM's Office.

After the *yagam* on Monday, the date for which was set by priests, vedic scholars, and astrologers of the Yadagirigutta temple, Reddy will also participate in a *purnahuti* (concluding offering) ceremony. "Special prayers will be offered with a resolution that the Krishna and Godavari rivers and local tanks receive good inflows, and agriculture and livestock thrive in the season," a CMO release said.

Reddy's trust with the religious ritual has come in the middle of a monsoon season that began in June at a 61% rainfall deficit. While the monsoon caught up in July, with Telangana receiving 224.3mm of rainfall against the normal 227.6mm, shrinking the monthly deficit to a marginal 1%, the cumulative rainfall deficit over the last two months remains at 5% for this monsoon season.

The *yagam* comes amid persistent Opposition pressure on the Congress government from the BJP and Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS), who have expressed concerns over the state's agricultural output this year.

"We have been raising the concerns of farmers before the Congress government. From the Congress government's apathy to clear financial assistance for

farmers to possible disruption of free power for farmers, there are several issues plaguing the agriculture sector," said a BRS leader, who added the party does not oppose the *yagam*.

The BRS, however, has been strongly opposing the creation of a separate Farmers' Power Distribution Company, claiming it would threaten the ongoing 24-hour free electricity supply to the agriculture sector.

The party has also been criticising the Congress over alleged delays and non-implementation of financial schemes, including Rythu Bharosa investment support for farmers. The BRS has also been demanding the immediate release of water from tanks and bunds for crop protection owing to the delayed rains.

The BJP, meanwhile, has been criticising the government for non-implementation of central schemes for farmers. The BJP Kisan Morcha has been demanding the implementation of the PM Fasal Bima Yojana, claiming the state's hesitation in implementing the scheme has left local farmers vulnerable to natural calamities.

The party has attacked the state government for months-long delays in procurement of paddy and maize at Indra Kranti Pathakam (IKP) procurement centres.

"There is nothing wrong in holding a *yagam*," said BJP state president N Ramchander Rao, adding that CM Reddy is only trying to ward off the farmers' ire. "What is preventing the state from implementing the PM Fasal Bima Yojana," Rao asked.

● 29-YEAR-OLD ARJUN AYANKI'S LAST THREATENING POST TO THE POLICE PRIOR TO HIS ARREST WAS ON AUGUST 6, FOLLOWING WHICH SEARCH FOR HIM WAS INTENSIFIED

Political worker who went rogue and defamed Kerala CM lands in police net

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram,
August 9

FOR DAYS, a former political worker-turned-history-sheeter had become a thorn in the side for Kerala Police. He would allegedly send out voice notes threatening police officers who took action against him, write "defamatory" posts against the CM on social media, and caution the state's home minister against trying to "intimidate" him.

Over the years, Arjun Ayanki had built a substantial following on social media — his Instagram handle has 1.29 lakh followers — where he would boast about his

exploits and issue threats when not posting pictures of himself in various poses: reading a book, playing snooker, showing off a tattoo.

In the early hours of Sunday, luck ran out for the 29-year-old who was arrested from his hometown Kannur where he had gone to consult his lawyer.

According to police, Ayanki has 23 cases registered against him. The immediate reason for his arrest was his threat to police officers who probed his recent alleged criminal activities.

In May, Ernakulam rural police had arrested Arjun and his friends from a resort, on charges of conspiring to commit a crime.

Before the arrest, Arjun had announced through social media reels that the group had come to the city to attend a wedding.

After being released on bail in June, Ayanki took to social media to threaten the inspector who had arrested him. Even as police moved the court to cancel his bail, Ayanki continued to issue threats to police through social media, inviting a fresh case against him.

His last threatening post to police was on August 6 following which the search for him was intensified. After being arrested on Sunday, he was remanded in judicial custody. On Monday, Ernakulam rural police will seek



Arjun Ayanki was arrested from his hometown in Kannur

his custody in connection with the latest case pertaining to threatening an inspector, officials said. ADGP (Law and Order) P Vijayan told the media:

"Challenging the police is tantamount to challenging society. The police are meant to serve society and are an integral part of it. Hence, such challenges to the police have to be seen as challenges to society itself. There should not be any more Arjun Ayankis."

He said, "We had been tracking him (Ayanki), but he kept moving from one location to another... While the police were pursuing Arjun, the Home Minister (Ramesh Chennithala) gave us clear instructions to follow the rule book."

Reacting to Ayanki's arrest, Chennithala said Kerala is not a land of gangsters but of peace-

loving people and asserted that no one was above the law.

A dedicated worker of the CPI (M) and local leader of its youth wing DYFI at Azhikode in Kannur, Arjun was among the first party workers to burst onto the social media scene. As the CPI(M) came to power in Kerala a decade ago, Ayanki's social media presence grew and he developed a dedicated fan base.

However, sources said, the apparent decline in political violence in the state forced several criminal gangs, once hired by political parties, to scout for new avenues. Ayanki then nurtured a gang, which later took to smuggling gold from the Middle East.

In 2021, Ayanki faced a setback when five members of his gang, who were chasing another gang in a bid to seize a consignment of gold smuggled through Kozhikode airport, were killed in a road accident. Probe into the smuggling racket led the Customs department to Ayanki who was then arrested.

After his name figured in the smuggling racket in 2018, Ayanki, in a facebook post, claimed that he had snapped ties with the CPI (M). As the CPI(M) increased its distance from him, Kannur Police, in 2022, recommended action against Ayanki under the Kerala Anti-Social Activities (Prevention) Act

(KAAPA), describing him as a habitual offender. After being released on bail in the smuggling case, Ayanki continued his tryst with the criminal world. In the next two years, he got involved in three other criminal cases one of which was related to a robbery of a gold trader in Palakkad, said police. Ayanki remained in judicial custody till 2024.

Once out of jail, he continued to enjoy his social media clout until he rubbed the CM and the Kerala home minister the wrong way. Following home minister Chennithala's warning to goons threatening police officers, Ayanki wrote, "Don't try to intimidate me".



The West Bengal Junior Doctors' Front holds a rally to mark two years since the rape-murder of a PG trainee doctor at RG Kar Medical College and Hospital in Kolkata, Sunday. PTI

CM orders fresh probe into RG Kar rape-murder

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, August 9

WEST BENGAL Chief Minister Suvenendu Adhikari announced a fresh probe into the rape and murder of the doctor at the state-run RG Kar Medical College and Hospital in Kolkata on the second anniversary of the incident on Sunday.

Adhikari said the government took the decision on the request of the deceased's mother, who is now a BJP MLA. "Ratna Debnath had written to me, requesting a fresh investigation. After extensive discussions with the chief secretary and a team of experts, I am announcing a fresh investigation under the Special Commission Act, 1952," he said. Adhikari also alleged that the police had failed to perform their duty in relation to this case, and ordered a separate probe into the alleged lapses in the cremation of the victim, and directed immediate action against those responsible.

Meanwhile, a two-minute silence was observed on Sunday at all government hospitals across West Bengal to mark the incident. The West Bengal Junior Doctors' Front, which led extensive protests in 2024, held a clinic for underprivileged people at Chitpur in north Kolkata.

"We are holding the clinic seeking justice for the on-duty doctor who was raped and murdered," said one participating doctor.

The Junior Doctors' Front later held a memorial march from College Street to Esplanade

for the victim, demanding that proper justice be served by way of arrest and trial of other people who may have been involved in the crime directly or indirectly. A day earlier, State Health Minister Sharadwat Mukhopadhyay had announced that his department will initiate a separate investigation into the rape and murder case.

Mukhopadhyay said the health department will summon everyone present at the hospital on the night of the incident. In addition, the investigating officers will also speak with the victim's teachers and professors. He said, "If, in the course of investigation, the department thinks former health minister (Mamata Banerjee) should be summoned, that decision also will be implemented."

The health minister stated the inquiry will also comprehensively examine what specific shortcomings or loopholes existed at the time in the hospital's internal security and administrative framework, and how those deficiencies were subsequently rectified.

Meanwhile, Asfaquallah Naiya, a member of the Abhaya Mancha that spearheaded the protests in the wake of the incident, said, "The state government is observing silence; we are welcoming that. But if the investigation of the RG Kar rape and murder case is also silenced, then it will not be accepted. Till date, we don't know exactly what happened on that night. We want proper justice."

(WITH PTI INPUTS)

Ban entry of minors to casinos: Goa commission

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, August 9

OFFSHORE CASINOS and other licensed casino operators in Goa have been directed to prohibit the entry of minors, as per a communication sent to the state home department by the Goa State Commission for Protection of Child Rights.

The child rights body said that the exposure of children to gambling environments is contrary to the principles of child protection, and may adversely

versely affect their physical, mental and moral development.

The Commission said the Goa Children's Act, 2003, mandates the state to protect children from exploitation and specifically provides that "inducing a child to gamble or assist in the gambling trade is a punishable offence". "Ensure mandatory age verification at all entry points through valid government-issued identity documents. Display prominent signboards stating 'entry of children below 18 years is strictly prohibited,'" read the letter.

Samrat promises education reforms: Students can seek help even at 11 pm

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, August 9

USE OF AI to better assess students' knowledge and abilities, a mechanism that allows them to call teachers even at 11pm if needed, and camps where they would get to interact with Ministers, MPs and MLAs directly: These are some of the reforms the Bihar government has promised in backdrop of widespread protests over examination-related issues across the country.

CM Samrat Choudhary made the announcements at a two-day workshop-cum-chintan camp organised by the Education Department that kicked off on Sunday. The measures include formation of two state-level committees – one on education quality and another for examination reforms, special cooperation camps, and dedicated directorates for student welfare.

The scheme will be launched on August 15.

Flagging the vulnerability of examination systems to leaks and individual wrongdoings, Choudhary said, "If one person sells his integrity, the question paper reaches the market. If even one person in the entire system fails, the whole system collapses."



“If one person sells his integrity, the question paper reaches the market. If even one person in the entire system fails, the whole system collapses.”

SAMRAT CHOUDHARY,
CHIEF MINISTER, BIHAR.

collapses."

The examination reform committee will examine ways to make board, competitive and classroom-based assessments smoother, more transparent, fair and modern. It will also suggest ways of using technology and AI to better assess students' knowledge, understanding and analytical abilities.

Choudhary said that strengthening the examination

system was necessary to prevent young people from losing confidence in it. "The young generation should not feel that it is being cheated. This needs to be addressed," the CM added.

While referring to challenges involved in conducting matriculation, intermediate and college examinations, as well as teacher recruitment examinations and Bihar Public Service Commission examinations, he stressed the need to use technology.

Choudhary said the government had enacted a provision under which people found involved in such offences could be kept in jail for up to one year under the Goonda Act, or CCA (Bihar Control of Crimes Act). "No one is to be spared. A system must be established in which the rule of law prevails," he said.

The government will also organise special cooperation camps, where ministers, MPs, MLAs and officials will interact with students in schools and colleges and seek their suggestions and grievances. Choudhary said the suggestions would be uploaded on a portal and if a grievance was not resolved within 30 days, he would hold a separate monthly cooperation camp for students at the CM's level.

For student welfare, the government will create directorates in all departments concerned to improve coordination and implementation of schemes, and to facilitate direct interaction with students, Choudhary said.

He said Bihar needed to strengthen its education system as large numbers of students go outside for studies. Referring to his experience as finance minister, Choudhary said an analysis had shown around Rs 18,000 crore was being spent on education outside Bihar.

Choudhary said an online system for one-to-one teaching was being prepared for launch on Independence Day. As part of this, students could seek help from teachers even at 11 pm. He said the system would use registration and OTP-based access and allow government to track its usage.

The government, the CM said, would expand its model-school programme, which would support preparation for examinations such as NEET and JEE. Choudhary said 551 model schools had already been identified, 143 more were being added and the government intended to take total number of model schools to 1,001.

UP Police gun down gangster accused of minor's rape and murder

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, August 9

A RS 50,000 REWARD-carrying gangster, wanted in connection with the alleged rape and murder of a minor girl, was killed in a police encounter in Uttar Pradesh's Bulandshahr Sunday morning.

Monu, a native of Bulandshahr, had seven criminal cases registered against him across Bulandshahr, Aligarh, Bareilly, and Gautam Buddha Nagar districts, said the police.

According to Dinesh Kumar Singh, Bulandshahr Superintendent of Police, the encounter took place near Chaprawat on the Bulandshahr-Gulaathi road during a routine vehicle-checking operation. Officers signalled two men riding a motorcycle without a registration plate to stop, but they allegedly opened fire and tried to flee, police said. The police claimed to have chased the motorcycle and returned fire in self-defence.

The pillion rider sustained gunshot injuries while the driver managed to escape, leaving the motorcycle behind. The police approached the injured man, who was identified as Monu.

Officers rushed Monu to a local community health centre, from where he was referred to the district hospital. He died while undergoing treatment, said the police.

Monu had been on the run since August 1, when a case was registered against him for the alleged rape and murder of a minor girl at a Bulandshahr police station. A search operation is currently underway to track down his absconding associate.

• BRIEFLY



The aircraft which skidded off the runway at Baramati Airfield during a training exercise on Sunday. ANI

MAHARASHTRA

Training aircraft skids off runway at Baramati airstrip, pilots safe

A TRAINING aircraft of a private aviation academy skidded off the runway while taxiing before take-off at Baramati airstrip on Sunday. Police said that the pilot-in-command and the trainee cadet pilot in the aircraft were unharmed. This is the second safety incident at the Baramati airstrip since the plane accident in January in which the then Maharashtra deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar was killed. The Baramati police said the incident occurred on Sunday afternoon when a trainee pilot of the private aviation training academy was to take off for a training sortie from the Baramati airstrip, located around 95 km from Pune city. ENS

Nine injured in steel plant blast in Jharkhand

AT LEAST nine workers were injured in an explosion in a furnace chamber at a private steel plant in Jharkhand's Ramgarh district on Sunday, an official said. The incident occurred at Murpa village under the Kuju outpost limits in the afternoon, he said. Chief Factory Inspector Manish Sinha said, "Workers sustained burn injuries after hot metal splashed following an explosion in the furnace chamber of the plant. Factory inspector in Hazaribag has been directed to inquire into the issue and submit a detailed report at the earliest," he said. PTI

Jeep mows down constable in Bihar, 1 held

A JEEP mowed down a Bihar police personnel and injured another before it crashed into a roadside eatery here, wounding the owner, and overturned, officials said on Sunday. Muzaffarpur's Deputy Superintendent of Police Suchitra Kumari said the incident occurred on Saturday evening when Bihar Special Armed Police Constable Bhargav Bhushan and a sub-inspector, both posted at Motipur police station, were going to a local market. According to eyewitnesses, a jeep ran over the two police personnel, killing Bhushan on the spot. PTI

Why Shivakumar is set to tweak Cabinet amid simmering discontent

Johnson TA
Bengaluru, August 9

THE GLARING absence of a woman minister, inclusion of an MLA accused in a corruption case, omission of an OBC leader close to ex-chief minister Siddaramaiah, resentment among senior MLAs denied ministerial berths – and the question of allocation of portfolios to 19 ministers inducted on August 3 are set to take new Karnataka CMD K Shivakumar to Delhi again.

The Congress CM is likely to visit the central leadership over next few days to discuss various issues including tweaking of the Cabinet for addition of a woman minister and a few ministerial changes to prevent discontent from damaging the party.

With the monsoon session of the state Legislature slated to begin on August 13 and the Opposition BJP and JD(S) looking to target the Congress over the Cabinet expansion issues, some ministry changes are expected, apart from portfolio allocations, ahead of the session.

"There will be some changes carried out. A woman minister will be inducted soon," a Congress legislator said. One of the key factors for the Congress for this revision has been to ensure there is representation for the umbrella coalition of castes and communities that have backed the party for decades.

In terms of caste balance, the current 33-member Shivakumar Cabinet is slightly different from the 34-member Siddaramaiah Cabinet, with the key differences being the absence of a woman minister and the enhanced representation of the SC and Muslim groups and the reduced Lingayat presence.

While the name of a first time MLC, Gayathri Shantigowda, featured as the sole woman minister in a list of 20 ministers originally released by the AICC on August 3, she did not take oath amid a controversy over her candidature with Siddaramaiah backing his former cabinet colleague Umashree for the woman's berth.



Karnataka CMD K Shivakumar

"There will be some changes in the woman candidate for the Cabinet. Umashree is likely to be sworn in," sources said.

The caste balance in the current Shivakumar Cabinet is seven Lingayats (20%), six Vokkaligas (17%), seven from SCs (20%), three from STs (9%), three from Muslims (9%), one Christian, and probably six from OBC groups (17%) if an OBC woman candidate is inducted.

The caste balance in Siddaramaiah Cabinet in 2023 was eight Lingayats (23%), six Vokkaligas (17%), six from SCs (17%), two Muslims (6%), three from STs (9%), six from OBC groups (17%), plus one each from Christian, Brahmin and Jain communities. In 2023 polls, the Congress won 135 of the state's 224 seats with wins in 37 out of 48 seats where it fielded Lingayat candidates. 21 of 43 seats (45%) where Vokkaligas were fielded, 10 of 15 seats with Kurubas (65%), and nine of 15 seats (60%) with Muslim candidates. Out of 36 SC seats, the Congress bagged 21 (60%), while of 15 ST-reserved seats it got 14 (93%).

According to party sources, the caste balance in the recast Cabinet has been done in line with population share of castes. Siddaramaiah is seeking the inclusion of a third Kuruba minister in the form of two-time MLA Basavaraj Shivannavar from the Haveri region. His inclusion will take the Kuruba representation in the Cabinet to 9% and that of the OBCs to 20%.

Siddaramaiah had suggested his picks for the Cabinet after it was sought by the party leadership but has since remained silent.

After lion sightings & a fatal attack, Gujarat to hire 25 forest trackers for Mount Girnar

Parimal A Dabhi
Ahmedabad, August 9

THE GUJARAT Forest Department will deploy 25 trackers exclusively for the Mount Girnar region to protect the pilgrims climbing through the stairways to the shrines above, after the fatal lion attack that killed a 12-year-old and lions were sighted along the route, both in July.

The authorities have received around 3,400 applications for the tracker posts on Mount Girnar, one of the most revered pilgrimage sites in Gujarat.

Nearly 10,000 steps lead to the peak of the mountain which has shrines important to Hindus and Jains that can be accessed by three stairways. Pilgrims usually climb through the night or early morning to reach the shrines through the Old Staircase, New Staircase and the Datar Staircase.

As recently as Thursday (August 6) night, three lions were spotted crossing the old and new staircases, Junagadh Deputy Conservator of Forests Akshay Joshi told *The Indian Express*.

Forest officials maintained continuous vigil on the big cats till they crossed into the forest and there was no human-wildlife conflict, DCF Joshi said in a statement.

The Forest department authorities have also appealed to people to move only in groups in night time, not to leave their kids alone at all and to follow the instructions of the forest department.

The DCF Junagadh dis-



A video grab shows a lion crossing a staircase used by pilgrims. GUJARAT FOREST DEPT

trict, who is also a member of the Gujarat State Lion Conservation Society (GSLCS), an arm of the state forest department, announced the new openings of forest trackers for the region last month with July 22 being the last date to apply. And around 3,400 candidates have applied for the post.

The final appointments are expected to be done soon following completion of ongoing interviews and subsequent verifications.

To be appointed on an 11-month contract, each tracker has been offered a salary of Rs 15,914 per month. The candidates should be under 35 years old and should have cleared Class 10, apart from having a "keen interest in wildlife".

The Junagadh DCF said that apart from the minimum educational qualification, the aspiring candidates' fit-

ness and knowledge about wildlife will be among the key areas to be considered in the recruitment process.

On July 11, a 12-year-old boy who was climbing the mountain to one of the shrines with his family was dragged away by a lion, raising serious concerns about the safety of the pilgrims.

Following the incident, Forest and Environment Minister Arjun Modhwadia had announced a range of measures to ensure security of pilgrims on Mount Girnar and the new hiring is a part of them.

Forest officials said that the forest trackers will be placed on duty at the area around Mount Girnar to see that the lions do not venture towards the stairs of the pilgrimage and even if they do they can be guided properly towards the forest.

• AROUND 650 GUESTS INVITED TO THE 80TH INDEPENDENCE DAY HIGH TEA; FOCUS ON HERITAGE FROM MAHARASHTRA, GOA, MADHYA PRADESH & CHHATTISGARH

Crafts from four states adorn President's At Home invite

Divya A
New Delhi, August 9

DIDOM DAIMARI, an environmental conservationist working in Assam's Udalguri for over 12 years, recently received a white bag from the Rashtrapati Bhavan. The parcel comprised some rare craft items and an invite — to participate in the At Home reception hosted by President Draupadi Murmu on August 15.

Daimari is among around 650 guests, including over 100 eminent citizens, invited to the 80th Independence Day high tea. Also on the list is Hemlata Suryavanshi from Ujjain, for participating in the Yuva Aapda Mitra training programme, and Leh's Tashi Namgyal, fondly called "Yakzee", who has worked towards community welfare.

Officials said the focus of this year's high tea is to highlight the heritage and traditions of four states — Maharashtra, Goa, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh. So be it the menu, decor or performances, everything will have a touch of central India, they said.

The specially curated menu includes 'patoleo' from the Konkani region, comprising rice-flour parcels filled with coconut and jaggery; mini farra from Chhattisgarh; khamang Kakdi from Maharashtra and Jabalpur's gatpat, a tangy mix of potatoes and tomatoes sauteed in ghee, from Madhya Pradesh.

The invite bag — designed in collaboration with the National Institute of Design, Ahmedabad — showcases several environmental practices and conserva-



The invite bag contains a handwoven Maheshwari stole, figurines handcrafted using Pitwa art from Bastar

tion initiatives from the four states. Its outer cover is inspired by the Kaavi art of the coastal Konkani region. A wrought iron

bell is attached to the address slip, which has been handcrafted by tribal ironsmiths in Bastar using recycled scrap iron.

The bag also contains a handwoven Maheshwari stole that will be used to welcome guests upon their arrival. It also includes a display frame featuring figurines handcrafted using 'Lauh Shilp' or Pitwa art, a world-renowned tribal craft from Bastar. Mirroring the daily life and culture of local tribes, this eco-friendly art form transforms recycled scrap iron into minimalist sculptures.

A pair of Azulejo tiles in the bag depicts Goa's Khajian lands, which are community-managed coastal wetlands, reclaimed from mangrove forests. Developed centuries ago, this ancient agro-aqua ecosystem uses an intricate network of dykes (bunds), embankments and sluice gates to control tidal river water, preventing saltwater

from flooding crops while supporting paddy cultivation, fishing, and salt-panning.

Beneficiaries of certain Central government schemes, including Pradhan Mantri Matsya Kisan Samridhi Yojana, Dharti Aaba Gram Utkarsh Abhiyan for tribal welfare and Gen-next Support for Innovative Startups by the Ministry of Electronics and IT, have also been invited to the high tea, said officials.

Earlier this year, the Republic Day At Home focused on the vibrant heritage and handicraft of the eight northeastern states. In 2025, the Independence Day At Home reception hosted by the President was themed around the cultural heritage of eastern India, highlighting crafts from Bihar, Jharkhand, Odisha, and West Bengal.

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INFRASTRUCTURE

‘Third Mumbai’: Can it decongest Maximum City?

Sabah Virani
Mumbai, August 9

MORE THAN 50 years after it was formed in 1975 to steer planning in and around Mumbai, the Mumbai Metropolitan Region Development Authority (MMRDA) is setting the scene for “Third Mumbai”, or Karnala-Sai Chirner (KSC) New Town — a massive area of 323.44 sq km over 124 villages in Uran, Pen, and Panvel talukas of Raigad district.

Chosen for falling in the influence area of the Atal Setu and the Navi Mumbai International Airport (NMIA), ambitious plans are in store for the planned city to decongest Mumbai.

Idea of Third Mumbai

The idea started taking shape around the time the Atal Setu — a 21.8 km-long sea bridge connecting South Mumbai and Navi Mumbai — was to open to the public in early 2024. Both the bridge and the NMIA were believed to add to Raigad’s potential. Third Mumbai was the instrument to capture the land value created by the public infrastructure and strategically plan out the development that the infrastructure is bound to attract.

In March 2024, Maharashtra’s Urban Development department invited suggestions and objections on the contours of KSC New Town. Then, MMRDA was tasked with developing the area from scratch. Parts of the area under the Navi Mumbai Airport Influence Notified Area and Khopta New Town Notified Area were enveloped into the new town.

Current status

- First, a land use plan — a thorough map of what currently exists in the area — is in the works. Much of the vast land is villages, forests, and green areas, which will be left as they are, dwindling the developable area to around 104 sq km. Farmlands are next, which are on the cards to be acquired. There are also warehouses, owing to the Jawaharlal Nehru Port Trust located near Uran, which are not to be disturbed yet, pending a policy decision.
- The process of land acquisition was set off in March 2026, laying down options for compensation. Villagers have multiple options for compensation, be it in the form of land or monetary compensation.
- In April, MMRDA began the preliminary phases of land acquisition by inviting farmers and land owners to submit their contest for acquisition. This has been slow to come, with several villages opposing the project as a “land grab”. Although this has delayed the land use plan, it is expected to be ready by August end.
- MMRDA has engaged Singapore-based urban development consulting firm Surbana Jurong to plan Third Mumbai’s layout, while also thinking about transport infrastructure and basic utilities.

NAVI MUMBAI

- The government and urban planners tried to decongest Mumbai with planned centres like Navi Mumbai in the past.
- Although the satellite city now has a thriving population, urban planners take a dismal view of how it has turned out.
- It has taken decades to establish itself. Only in recent years, sales of residential properties and rates have been on the rise.

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Early investors have already started trying to catch people interested in a prospective home in Third Mumbai. For now, investors will have to transact directly with the landowners, hoping to bargain for a better price. Once MMRDA acquires the land, investors will go to it.

Gulam Zia, executive director at the real estate research consultancy Knight Frank, said: “If the MMRDA takes on the initiative on ensuring basic facilities and good mass rapid transport, the area will thrive naturally.” A metro line between Mumbai and the NMIA is already in the works.

Officials in the MMRDA said, “We are working on Third Mumbai now, but city making is a long term plan. Nothing is going to bear fruit in the next five to 10 years, but once the basic infrastructure is in place, the returns will pour in.”

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ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

Scientists can now shrink and rewrite proteins with AI. Here’s what that unlocks

SCIENTISTS AT Duke University, North Carolina, have come up with an Artificial Intelligence system termed Raygun, which can miniaturise, enlarge and extensively rewrite proteins. Their work was published in the journal *Nature* recently.

Why would anyone want a smaller protein?

Proteins are already minuscule, typically a few nanometres across. Shrinking them sounds like a strange goal until you consider that, much as with a compact car in a

crowded city, a smaller version can go places the larger one cannot.

Gene therapy is a clear case. The aim is to deliver a working copy of a gene into a patient’s cells to compensate for a faulty one. A gene cannot simply be swallowed and has to be packed into a molecular vehicle, typically the hollowed-out shell of a harmless virus. Those shells have a strict capacity limit, and many therapeutically valuable genes are too large to fit.

That constraint has consequences well beyond the laboratory. Gene therapies built on these viral shells are among the most expensive medicines, such as Hemgenix for haemophilia (\$3.5 million), Casgevy for sickle cell disease (\$2.2 million), and Zolgensma (\$2.1 million) for spinal muscular atrophy.

Proteins as sentences

Proteins are polymers, long chains assembled from a small set of repeating units, in their case 20 amino acids. The order of those units determines the shape the chain folds into, and the shape determines the job:

motor, scaffold, transporter, switch. Genes, which encode proteins, are polymers too, written in an alphabet of four nucleotides.

The comparison to language is a natural one. A protein can be read as a sentence in a 20-letter alphabet, a gene as a sentence in a four-letter one.

Evolution encodes the language that governs how a protein’s amino acid sequence gives rise to its shape and function, but scientists don’t fully understand that language. Protein language models act as a kind of translator, learning patterns from millions of protein sequences and linking those patterns to biological structure and function.

Large language models such as ChatGPT can summarise or expand a passage because vast exposure to writing teaches them two things: grammar, meaning what a valid sentence looks like, and gist, meaning what a passage is actually saying, so that it can be rewritten in differ-

ent words. Evolution has handed biology a comparable corpus. Haemoglobin, the oxygen carrier in our blood, turns up in thousands of species, from whales to earthworms, always recognisable but never quite identical. Comparing enough of those variants shows which parts are unchangeable and which tolerate change.

Train a protein language model on hundreds of millions of such sequences and it learns a grammar that generalises across proteins.

What Raygun does

Protein language models supply the grammar. Raygun supplies the second half: how to take the gist of a protein and re-express it, sometimes in considerably fewer words.

A language model describes each amino acid with a longlist of numbers capturing its chemistry and its context. Two proteins of different lengths are therefore

described in formats that cannot be lined up against each other, let alone converted into one another, which is precisely what changing a protein’s length would demand.

Raygun’s answer is to summarise every protein at a fixed resolution. Dr. Kapil Devkota, postdoctoral research and lead computational author of the study, thought of dividing each sequence into the same number of blocks whatever its length, so a short protein gets a few residues per block and a long one gets many, then averages within each block. Much of Raygun’s machine learning goes into working out how to pack enough information into those notes that the protein can be written back out from them.

The second move is what makes generation possible. Raygun can treat a protein not as one fixed summary but as a probability distribution, a cloud of plausible variants rather than a single point. Drawing a sample at a chosen target length yields a complete sequence of that size in a single shot, in about 0.3 seconds on one graphics processor.

The user steers all of this with two dials: how far to stray from the original, and how long the result should be.

Our team tested Raygun across a 17-fold size range, from haemoglobin at 147 amino acids to mTOR at 2,549. The more consequential finding is how much editing the proteins tolerated.

There is also the question of the ethics of such tools, and we are signatories to the Responsible AI for Biodesign principles. The value of computational design runs in both directions: a model that can propose a new protein can equally be pointed at a design of unknown provenance and asked whether it resembles something dangerous.

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EDUCATION

Row around who gets to prescribe modern drugs



ANONNA DUTT

DOCTORS ACROSS Maharashtra went on a strike last week to protest homeopathic doctors being allowed to prescribe modern medicines after completing a bridge course. While the strike was called off after the Bombay High Court stepped in, the issue is still simmering.

The protests began after Dr Neha Siddharth Pawar, 36, early last week became the first homeopathy practitioner from Maharashtra to be registered in the state’s allopathic Maharashtra Medical Council (MMC) — opening the gates for others like her, who have completed the state’s Certificate Course in Modern Pharmacology (CCMP). This was a contentious move, opposed by the practitioners of modern medicine ever since the state Assembly amended the MMC Act in 2014.

Even the homeopathy council opposes the move. “Medical practitioners should work in the respective ‘pathies’ that they have trained in — a pathway such as this will only create a shortcut for students who want to study modern medicine but cannot get through into those courses. They will choose homeopathy regardless of their interest in the subject,” said Dr Tarakeshwar Jain, chairperson, National Commission for Homeopathy (NCH).

He added: “Once this happens in Maharashtra, other states will demand the same. We have, in fact, already received a request from Madhya Pradesh.”

What was the 2014 amendment in Maharashtra?

The 2014 amendment to the Maharashtra Medical Commission Act allows the registration of homeopaths who have undergone the one-year bridge course to be registered with the body that regulates allopathic medicine in the state, albeit in a separate register.

This almost grants equivalence to MBBS doctors and homeopaths who have undergone the course. The amendment has been challenged in court.

“We were told that the token registration [to Dr Pawar] was finally granted by the Maharashtra Medical Council as they were following the processes laid down in the



Resident doctors at JJ Hospital protesting the notification last week. AKASH PATIL

2014 amendment. The matter is still sub-judice but the court has not granted an interim stay so the body was obligated to give the registration,” said Dr Atharva Shinde, president, Maharashtra Association of Resident Doctors (MARD).

He added: “From my conversations with officials, I get the sense that neither the MMC nor the current government is in favour of this step. However, the government cannot go against its own law, so they are waiting for a decision in the court.”

When the Act was amended, the government in the statement of objects and reasons for the Bill had cited a shortage of doctors. “There is continuous demand from different sections of society to give permission to Homeopathic Practitioners to use allopathic medicines in treating patients... Considering the need of people of the State and to achieve the goal of ‘Health for All’, the Government considers it expedient to allow the Homeopathic Practitioners’ who have undergone the course in Modern Pharmacology to practice Allopathy.”

Why was this decision taken?

Officials said behind the official reasoning was another story.

Dr Pravin Shingare, who was working in Maharashtra’s Department of Medical Education at the time and later headed it, said that the push came from colleges of-

Rationale questioned

A shortage of doctors, specially in rural areas, was cited as a reason behind the move.

“As many as 10,000 have passed the CCMP course, most from bigger cities. Will they go to small towns and villages to practise? Also, why should these places not have the services of a fully qualified doctor?” Jain said.

fering homeopathy courses. “In the 70s, the Ayurveda course was changed by the central council, which regulated it to include modern pharmacology. The council allowed Ayurveda doctors to officially prescribe some allopathic medicines. And this led to Ayurveda colleges flourishing.”

Dr Shingare said that homeopathy colleges in the state also wanted to follow suit but were unable to convince the central council that regulated their practice. The colleges then tried to convince the state council, which maintained that changes to the course had to be approved by the central council. Then, they went to the government and politicians.

“When a Bill on the subject seemed imminent, the Department of Medical Education intervened and said there should at least be a one-year bridge course in modern pharmacology,” said Dr Shingare.

What is the situation nationally?

Nationally, practitioners of modern medicine, ayurveda, or homeopathy can practice only their respective ‘pathies’ after registration in their own registers. With modern pharmacology being a part of the Ayurveda curriculum, some states, such as Maharashtra and Uttar Pradesh, allow practitioners to prescribe a limited number of allopathic medicines, such as the ones needed for fever, diarrhoea, or other com-

Maharashtra has allowed homeopathic doctors to give allopathic medicines after a bridge course. Critics of the move include the homeopathy council

mon ailments seen in primary health centres.

When it comes to homeopaths, the national council maintains that the practitioners should not prescribe allopathic medicines.

Dr Jayesh Lele, former vice president of Indian Medical Association and former president of the Maharashtra chapter, was one of the key persons to challenge the 2014 amendment in the High Court. “There are several cases in which the Supreme Court has said that such mixopathy cannot be allowed,” he said.

He cited the *Poonam Verma vs Ashwin Patel* case where the court came down on a homeopathic doctor who had prescribed an allopathic medicine, leading to the patient’s death. In *Dr Mukhtiar Chand vs State Of Punjab*, the court had said there was no scope for a person enrolled in the state or central Register of Indian Medicine to practise allopathy.

“Yet, the practice is being revived here with this registration,” said Dr Lele, adding that this could also lead to one person being registered with two different councils, which is not allowed.

Are the courses similar?

While the process for admission and the course structure for modern medicines and other systems have been streamlined to be made similar, substantial differences exist. Admissions to both modern medicine and other courses happen through the national selection test, NEET-UG. The consistent trend is that the top scorers go on to study modern medicine.

All three courses have several common subjects — usually the ones to understand the human body — including anatomy, physiology, pathology and biochemistry. The courses differ when it comes to the education on treatments. Where the students of modern medicine learn about evidence-based pharmacology and treatments, those studying Ayurveda or homeopathy study subjects such as Tridosha theory, Panchakarma, or law of similars.

What will be the impact of the change?

The move could open the door for similar allowances in other states. Dr Jain from NCH said: “A clause in the central regulations grants states the power to allow homeopaths to practise allopathy, but it has to be for a narrow requirement or for a specific duration or adverse event, such as the Covid-19 pandemic. It cannot be open-ended, as has been done by Maharashtra.”

But Gupta pointed out that because records are now electronic, they can be shared easily on a phone, increasing the risk of data leaks and privacy concerns. “It should be the court which can allow it,” Gupta said.

Missed opportunities

Experts felt the Bill misses the mark on procedural safeguards. Joshi said lawyers and judges currently struggle to prove or disprove digital documents. He suggested the Bill could have incorporated modern safeguards such as hash values — a unique digital fingerprint used to verify that an electronic file has not been tampered with — to ensure the sanctity of the evidence.

The wholesale replacement of the Act might cause interpretation issues and multiplied litigation, as parties debate whether the new rules and definitions can be applied to ongoing trials, said Joshi. “The first casualty is always the pending matters.”

Concern over police powers

A major talking point around the Bill has been Section 11, which states that court orders compelling the production of bank records for investigations can be construed as orders made by an officer “not below the rank of a Superintendent of Police”. However, this is not a new power. Section 8 of the old Act contained the exact same provision, allowing an SP-rank officer

Trust is key, tech fund needs more guardrails

THE GOVERNMENT'S fund to spur research and development in deep-tech sectors like AI, space and quantum technology is commendable. Private sector R&D spending has been paltry and the country risks falling behind in the tech race without stable, patient, long-term funding of the kind ordinary venture capital is unwilling to provide. But the intersection of public money and private networks is tricky terrain because taxpayers, not shareholders, bear the risk. The process should inspire confidence that there's a level playing field for all. That's why the questions raised by an investigation in this paper into the Research, Development and Innovation Fund matter.

In its first round, the fund approved Rs 2,192 crore in soft loans to 22 private firms, chosen by a 12-member panel — 11 from private equity and technology, and one non-voting government representative. Drawing experts from the private sector is sound design, they are best placed to sift genuine tech from a pitch deck. But when 15 of the 22 selected firms have investment ties to seven of those very panel members, and nine trace back to the committee's own chairman, the arithmetic of the process becomes as important as its intent. The official response rests on three pillars: disclosure, recusal, and the claim that decisions were taken purely on merit by unconflicted members. Indeed, officials have pointed out that in the fund's second cohort, only one of 13 companies had a panel-member link — evidence, they argue, that the first round's concentration reflected early-mover awareness among well-networked founders, not favouritism. These are valid points. Disclosure and recusal are standard tools for managing conflict in any expert body, and a young, capital-starved sector will always draw its evaluators from among the very people who have been investing in it. But good intentions are not structural safety. Recusal only guards against a member voting on a company they are invested in; it does nothing about the informational and reputational advantage of sitting on the panel in the first place, or about the pull that draws founders towards investors who also sit on committees controlling access to public capital. In an economy where ownership and capital are already visibly concentrated across sectors, a public fund for deep-tech — where costs are high, credible ventures are few, and information is scarce — cannot rest its defence on the good faith of its selectors alone.

The remedy is not to purge private-sector expertise from the process, that would defeat the fund's purpose. It is to balance the instincts of innovation with the discipline of compliance; widen and rotate the selectors' pool so that no single network's judgement carries disproportionate weight; bring in outside academic and scientific evaluators for initial screening; separate technical assessment from financial interest; publish conflict disclosures and recusal records as mandated practice, not as answers obtained in Parliament. Venture-capital speed and public accountability will pull in different directions. But a fund built on public money must earn trust in its architecture, not just assert it.

Monsoon has revived, but keep an eye on weather

CUMULATIVE RAINFALL deficiency in the current southwest monsoon season (June-September) has reduced to 11.5 per cent, from 38 per cent in June and 22.8 per cent till July 15. The interesting part about this seeming turnaround is that the dreaded El Niño was only in a weak-to-moderate phase in June. Yet, not a single rain-bearing low-pressure system (LPS) was formed, as against a normal average of three stretching over 11 days for that month. July, by contrast, not only saw four LPSs develop (normal is three). It also recorded 24 LPS-active days (normal: 14). As a result, despite El Niño becoming a moderate-to-strong event, the month registered a 2.4 per cent all-India rainfall surplus. The monsoon situation thus, far from worsening (the India Meteorological Department had predicted below-normal precipitation for July), has revived.

That revival has also helped narrow the overall gap in progressive area sown under kharif crops from 20.8 per cent till the first week of July to 2.9 per cent at month-end. The rains post mid-July have boosted late plantings, including pulses, soyabean, sesamum and cotton, that were significantly lagging behind. Moreover, they have been lifesaving for the already sown crops facing moisture stress from the monsoon's prolonged break. But for the recent showers, even those crops would have suffered stunted vegetative growth. In short, kharif hasn't been the unmitigated disaster that many were fearing after a dry June and amid concerns over an intensifying El Niño. For now, things look manageable. Even in fertilisers, the shortages haven't been dire. Production and imports of urea have, in fact, been higher in April-June 2026 over April-June 2025.

That said, the standing kharif crop needs a couple of good spells of rain in the second half of this month and early September. The Met Department has forecast below-normal rainfall for the entire second half of the monsoon season, on the back of a continued strengthening of El Niño conditions. With El Niño expected to turn into a "very strong" event during October-September and persist through the next quarter, the effects could be felt in the upcoming rabi or winter-spring crops as well. Also, El Niño's impact is known to come with a lag. The government cannot afford to take its eye off the weather. Proactive supply-side management will remain key.

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY



EC's real test: Winning the confidence of the Opposition

BARELY TWO weeks after the publication of my memoir *India and I*, interviewers and readers have repeatedly asked why I believed the Opposition deserved preferential treatment by the Election Commission (EC). The answer lies at the heart of what I believe is the constitutional philosophy of election management: The ruling party needs regulation. The Opposition needs reassurance. The EC must provide both.

The framers of our Constitution deliberately placed the EC beyond the reach of the executive. Elections could not command public confidence if the referee was perceived to be close to one of the contestants, especially the ruling party. The Commission was therefore created as an independent constitutional authority, entrusted with protecting the integrity of the electoral process.

That independence is not merely legal; it is institutional.

A serving civil servant appointed as Election Commissioner relinquishes his service and assumes a constitutional office. In my case, I resigned from the Indian Administrative Service a year before retirement. That separation reflects a profound constitutional principle. Once appointed, an Election Commissioner no longer serves the government of the day. His allegiance belongs exclusively to the Constitution.

The Supreme Court has repeatedly reaffirmed this constitutional vision. In *TN Seshan v. Union of India* and, more recently, in *Anoop Baranwal v. Union of India*, it underscored that an independent EC is indispensable to free and fair elections, which form part of the Constitution's basic structure.

But constitutional independence cannot be measured only by legal safeguards. It must also be reflected in institutional behaviour. The EC must consciously maintain an arm's-length relationship with the executive.

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Any perception of a cosy relationship between the executive and the EC is antithetical to the constitutional scheme and corrosive of public confidence.

That constitutional distance has an important implication. The party in power commands the administrative machinery, public visibility and official resources. The Opposition has only its voice and its confidence that an impartial constitutional authority will hear it fairly.

Recognising this asymmetry does not compromise neutrality. It fulfils it.

When I became Chief Election Commissioner, I gave my officers a simple instruction. If Opposition parties sought an appointment, they should receive one at the earliest. Sometimes requests came with barely 15 minutes' notice. We did our best to accommodate them. Not because they deserved favours, but because they were entitled to confidence that they would always receive a patient hearing.

An EC trusted only by the ruling party has failed just as surely as one trusted only by the Opposition. It must command the confidence of both. But the confidence of the Opposition is often the more exacting test because those without power are naturally more anxious about the fairness of the referee.

One incident from the Bihar Assembly election of 2010 illustrates why.

Around 11 o'clock on the eve of counting, Lalu Prasad Yadav telephoned me with an unusual request. He wanted only bank employees to supervise counting in his constituency. Although all arrangements had been finalised, I asked the Chief Electoral Officer to accommodate the request, come what may.

The following evening, after he had lost, he telephoned again. This time he appeared inclined to



S Y QURAISHI

Every EC is judged twice: First by how efficiently it conducts elections, and then by the confidence it inspires among those who lose them. The second test is statistical. The second is constitutional

question the Electronic Voting Machines. I told him candidly that people would laugh if he did so. He accepted the advice. A modest accommodation had preserved confidence in the electoral process.

Throughout my tenure, the Bharatiya Janata Party sat in the Opposition. Its leaders frequently approached the Commission with complaints and representations. They received the same patient hearing. Arun Jaitley initially viewed me with some reservation, but that disappeared as he experienced the Commission's even-handedness. Years later, he generously described me as "one of India's most mature and credible Chief Election Commissioners." I treasured those words because they reflected confidence earned through institutional fairness rather than personal friendship.

The philosophy I followed was not an individual innovation. It is reflected in India's own Model Code of Conduct (MCC). Significantly, one of its most important chapters is devoted to the "Party in Power". It restrains ministers from using official machinery for campaigning, prohibits the misuse of public resources and bars policy announcements that may influence voters. The constitutional instinct is unmistakable: Those who wield power require greater restraint because they already possess overwhelming advantages.

One of India's greatest democratic achievements has been the extraordinary legitimacy of its electoral verdicts. Governments changed. Prime Ministers lost office. Powerful Chief Ministers were voted out. Candidates gracefully accepted the verdict and began preparing for the next election. This confidence in the process made our elections a model for emerging

democracies.

It is precisely because that reputation is so precious that recent developments should concern us all. During the 2024 general election, Opposition parties repeatedly complained that their representations alleging violations of the MCC were not receiving prompt and transparent consideration. Even Election Commissioner Ashok Lavasa protested, for which he was hounded out. More recently, 23 Opposition parties took the extraordinary step of writing to the Chief Justice of India expressing serious concerns about the EC's handling of the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls. Around the same time, the Trinamool Congress publicly alleged discourtesy in its interaction with the Commission, an allegation firmly denied by the Commission.

Whether these grievances are ultimately upheld is not the central issue. The deeper concern is that a significant section of the political spectrum felt compelled to seek relief from another constitutional institution rather than the EC itself. No EC should ever allow such a perception to develop.

In my experience, most defeated candidates can accept defeat. What they find difficult to accept is the feeling that nobody listened to them before they lost.

Every EC is judged twice: First by how efficiently it conducts elections, and then by the confidence it inspires among those who lose them. The first test is statistical. The second is constitutional. Together, they determine the health of our democracy. That conviction shaped my own philosophy as Chief Election Commissioner.

The ruling party needs regulation. The Opposition needs reassurance. The EC must provide both

Quraishi is former chief Election Commissioner of India and the author of *India and I – A Hundred Memories*. Not a Memoir

To lower cost of credit, track information asymmetries



APOORVA JAVADEKAR



PRASANNA TANTRI

The real bottleneck is the cost of finding, evaluating and monitoring creditworthy borrowers, and this loads up into lending rates

THE RBI kept interest rates on hold at its August 5 monetary policy committee meeting. While the decision may appear passive, it is very much an active one to keep real rates suppressed to boost credit supply and consumption or investment. With the RBI expecting inflation to inch up to 5.9 per cent in Q3-FY27, a pause in the current policy translates into negative real rates of around 65 basis points. This is sharply lower compared to 2 per cent-plus real rates during 2016-2018, and even lower relative to the expected real rates in the US.

Bank and NBFC credit to the small and medium sector and retail segment has recovered strongly since Q4-2025, from when the expected real rates started to fall. For an economy aspiring to sustain growth above 7 per cent, that is welcome news. But monetary policy rarely comes without trade-offs.

A study by Gabriel Jiménez, Steven Ongena, José-Luis Peydró and Jesús Saurina, analysing more than 23 million bank loans in Spain, established the risk-taking channel of monetary policy. It confirmed that extended periods of low real rates after the 2008 financial crisis induced weaker banks to approve riskier borrowers, require less collateral and eventually experience higher defaults. Our own research using the Ministry of Corporate Affairs credit registry establishes similar risk-taking by Indian banks during the first half of the 2010s when real rates were low, which played a role in a full-blown NPA crisis that ensued.

Why does this happen? Lower real lending rates compress banks' profitability from traditional lending, encouraging a search for higher-yielding borrowers, which are naturally risky. At the same time, as Giovanni Dell'Ariccia and his co-authors argue, when real profitability declines, the bank's incentive to screen/monitor, which are essentially fixed costs, also falls, leading to a rise in risky lending. Finally, lower interest rates also boost the value of banks' bond portfolios and collateral, strengthening balance sheets and encouraging greater risk-taking.

None of this suggests that the RBI's objec-

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tive of spurring credit-funded growth is misguided. What we are arguing is that the low real rates may not be the most efficient tool in reducing the cost of credit in India.

The real bottleneck is the cost of finding, evaluating and monitoring creditworthy borrowers, and this loads up into lending rates. If the objective is to provide cheaper funding, reducing these information asymmetry costs is a more structural solution, which will allow the central bank to respond to inflationary shocks more flexibly. More importantly, it can make the inflation-growth trade-off less severe.

India has already demonstrated what public digital infrastructure can achieve. The NPCI transformed digital payments, created a financial transactions trail for potential borrowers and merchants, and allowed lenders to lend against these cash flows. Not only did it expand credit access to borrowers who had no credit history, but also lowered the information asymmetry and ultimately the lending costs substantially, without encouraging risk-taking in the system. The RBI's Unified Lending Interface is an important step that will build on this infrastructure.

That distinction is crucial. Lower real interest rates make all borrowing cheaper, including loans that perhaps should never have been made and constrain the RBI's ability to respond to inflationary shocks efficiently, as it has to worry about growth constantly. Better financial intermediation makes good borrowing cheaper by reducing the cost of identifying genuinely credit-worthy borrowers. One works by making money cheaper. The other works by making finance more efficient.

The RBI's current stance may well be appropriate given growth needs and the assessed transitory nature of inflation. But policymakers should also recognise the accompanying risks and enhance risk-monitoring mechanisms.

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Begumpura is a radical vision, not a governance model



RAM SURAT

Begumpura emerged as a prophetic and counter-cultural vision that challenged this oppressive social order in 15th-century. Reading it primarily through the framework of present-day public policy risks obscuring its original historical context and revolutionary intent

THE ARTICLE 'From Ravidas and Begumpura, a philosophy of governance' (*IE*, July 30) by Abhinav Prakash interprets Sant Ravidas's vision of Begumpura in relation to contemporary models of governance and public policy. While it recognises the enduring relevance of Ravidas's philosophy, its analysis is largely shaped by a contemporary political framework. It does not fully engage with the historical, philosophical, and socio-religious depth of Ravidas's thought.

A central limitation is its treatment of Begumpura primarily as a model of good governance. In Ravidas's writings, Begumpura is far more than an ideal administrative order; it is a radical vision of social, moral, and spiritual emancipation. It imagines a society liberated from caste hierarchy, social exclusion, economic exploitation, and institutionalised injustice. By emphasising welfare schemes and administrative reforms, the article narrows the transformative scope of Ravidas's vision and gives insufficient attention to his critique of caste-based social structures.

It also overlooks the profound significance of Ravidas's declaration, "*Kahi Ravidas Khalas Chamara*". This statement is not merely autobiographical but a bold affirmation of dignity, self-respect, and liberation from caste-based oppression. It represents an early and powerful articulation of resistance against the social stigma attached to caste identity and therefore deserves deeper theological and sociological analysis.

Although contemporary welfare initiatives may contribute to poverty alleviation and public welfare, they are not equivalent to Ravidas's vision of justice. Begumpura envisages the transformation of the social order itself by dismantling the structures of discrimination and exclusion. The article also underestimates Ravidas's concept of freedom. His verse, "*Maharam mahal na ko atkavai*", envisions a society in which no individual is excluded because of caste, class, religion, privilege, or political power. Similarly, "*Dom na Som ek so aahi*" expresses the ideal of radical equality by rejecting hierarchical distinctions based on caste or *varna*.

Begumpura emerged as a prophetic and counter-cultural vision that challenged the oppressive social order in 15th-century. Reading it primarily through the framework of present-day public policy risks obscuring its original historical context and revolutionary intent. Sant Ravidas's Begumpura represents a profound vision of a city without sorrow — a society founded upon equality, freedom, justice, dignity, fraternity, and the abolition of caste-based discrimination and exclusion. It should be understood not as an endorsement of any political ideology or programme but as Sant Ravidas's enduring and prophetic vision of a just, inclusive, caste-free, and compassionate society.

The writer, a scholar from SHUATS, Prayagraj, is part of the Bahujan Sanskritik Andolan

40 YEARS AGO

August 10, 1986



Badal, Tohra arrested

FORMER PUNJAB chief minister Prakash Singh Badal and former president of the Sikh Gurudwara Prabandhak Committee Gurcharan Singh Tohra were arrested for violating externment orders prohibiting them from entering the Union Territory of Delhi for one month. The two dissident Akali leaders were arrested following a long wrangle with the Delhi Police at the Singhu border as they refused to accept the externment orders and forced their way into the city.

Two Tamils killed

TWO TAMILS, including a child, were killed and four security forces persons injured

when a foot patrol was fired upon by Tamil militants in the Trincomalee district, according to official sources. The foot patrol is said to have been going from Kattaparaichan. The security forces are said to have been prevented from engaging the terrorists because the incident occurred near a refugee camp.

Terrorist arrested

THE POLICE have arrested a dreaded terrorist, Manbir Singh Chaheru alias general Hari Singh, chief of the "Khalistan commando force", from village Bootan on the outskirts of the city, from the house of Major Baldev Singh Chuman (ret'd). A large number of sophisticated arms, including one light machine gun, one SLR, one Springfield rifle,

two muscats, two .303 rifles, one double bore gun and 1,082 cartridges were recovered from his hideouts.

US continues with N-test

THE US State Department has rejected appeals from six world leaders and insisted nuclear weapons must be tested to counter what it called, "massive Soviet build-up" and to maintain international security. "The heart of the problem we face, in working to preserve peace and stability, is not the testing of nuclear weapons," the Department said in a statement read out by a spokesman, Charles E Redman. He said the Soviets had caused "dangerous disparities" in nuclear weapons with a massive build-up.



Proof of a deep-tech fund is in its outcomes. That's the audit worth doing



V ANANTHA NAGESWARAN

ON ITS first day, the committee that would decide where India's new deep-tech fund put its money was handed a hard brief: There is very little deep tech in this country. Here is two thousand crore. Go and find it.

So they did. They went to the ventures they knew — the ones they had watched, mentored, argued with, and in some cases carried through the years when no one else would write a cheque. They backed the companies whose science had already been proven. And last week, this paper published a so-called investigative report that they had done something troubling: 62 per cent of the first round had gone to firms in which panel members held an interest.

I read the story with sadness, not anger — and let me own my position at once. I serve in this government, so weigh what follows with whatever discount you think that deserves; the argument does not need my office to stand. The sadness, in any case, is not about a single report, a single journalist, or a single newspaper. It is about a habit of mind that keeps us scoring self-goals while the world races ahead.

The question of conflict of interest is a fair one. Public money deserves scrutiny, and it is good that this is being discussed openly. Gopal Srinivasan of the panel said exactly that when the paper reached him. Accountability is the condition of trust.

What is in dispute is the frame. And the frame rests on a fact the investigation never grasped: How the one lakh crore is actually spent.

The money does not go out in a single round through one committee. It is expected to be disbursed over five years through several fund managers, of whom only two have been appointed so far. More are to come. The Technology Development Board's first cohort is a sliver of the whole, and it was appraised on a first-come, first-

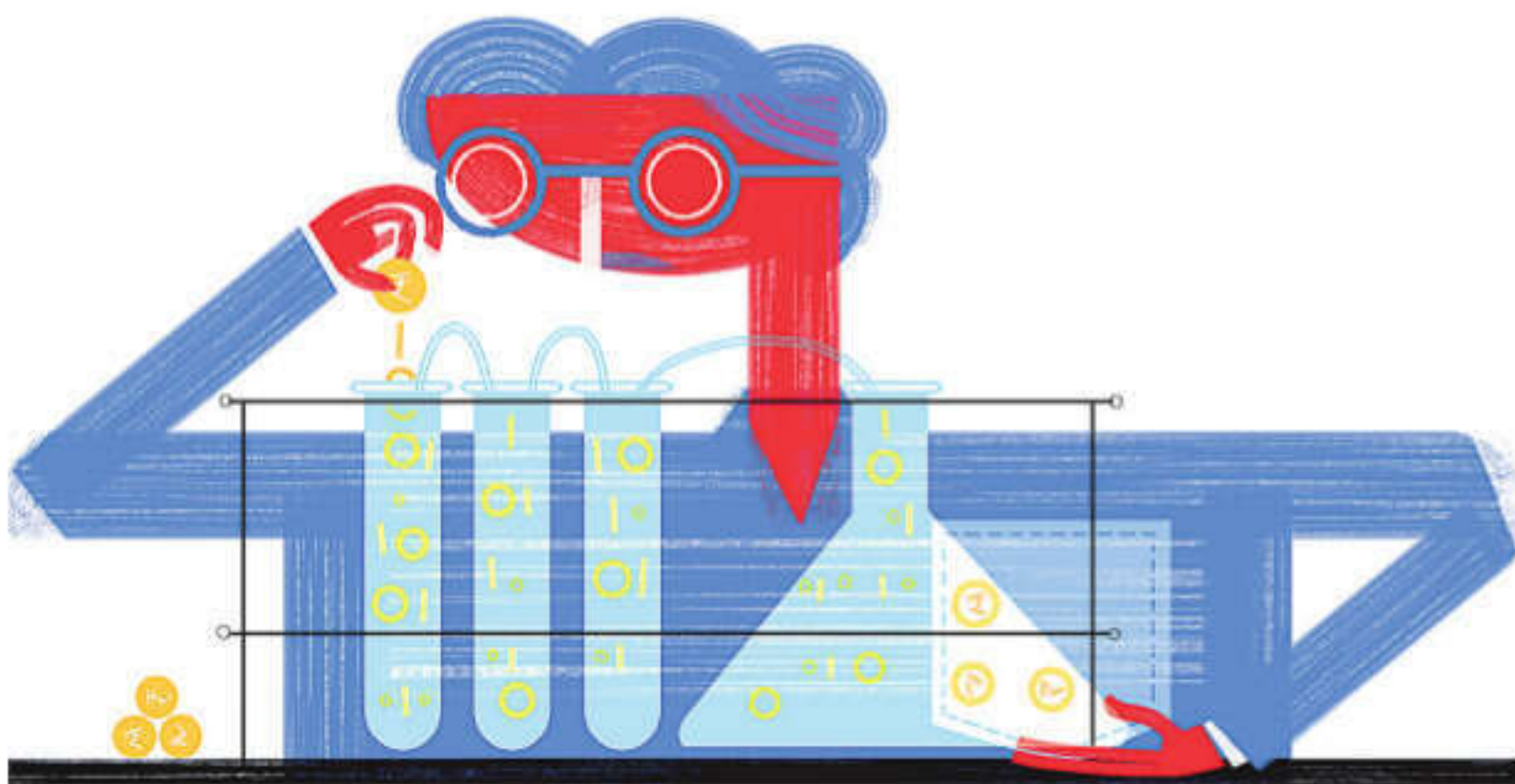


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

served basis. The companies that applied earliest were the ones that heard about the fund earliest — and the ones that heard earliest were, unsurprisingly, close to the ecosystem. That is why the first batch looks the way it does. The Board has already said that in the second cohort, one of 13 firms has a panel link. Not 62 per cent. The number the headline was built on was always going to fall because it was an artefact of sequence, not a pattern of favour.

Now to the harder charge, and the fairer one: A small circle of experts clearing one another's ventures, recusing one at a time, does not pass the smell test. It deserves an answer.

Here is the answer. If you want to find validated deep-tech ventures quickly, you ask the handful of Indians who actually know the field. Anyone in India who knows this field has touched these companies — mentored them, funded a founder, sat on a board. It is the reason they were chosen. The money is the tip of the iceberg of what this group has given to Indian deep tech.

So the design does not pretend to eliminate the overlap. It manages it. Firms that a member founded, owns, or runs cannot even apply, however good they are. A stake of more than 10 per cent automatically disqualifies a

Were undeserving ventures funded? Were deserving ones turned away? Judge the decision on what was knowable then, not on what hindsight reveals now



NICOLAS BLAREL AND SUMIT GANGULY

AMNESTY INTERNATIONAL'S recent report alleging that India sent at least 2,596 shipments of military equipment and components to Israel since the outbreak of the Gaza war has generated understandable attention. Yet, the revelations do not mark a dramatic shift in India's defence relationship with Israel so much as underscore the depth and maturity of a strategic partnership that has been built over the past quarter century.

The foundations of India's defence relationship with Israel were laid during the 1999 Kargil War, when Israel emerged as one of the few countries willing to rapidly provide critical equipment, including ammunition, drones and precision-guided munitions. That experience established Israel as a reliable defence partner and accelerated a relationship that has expanded ever since. Unlike many Western suppliers, Israel has also demonstrated a willingness to transfer sophisticated military technologies to India.

Over the last decade, however, the partnership has evolved beyond a conventional buyer-seller arrangement. Under PM Narendra Modi's "Make in India" initiative, Israeli defence companies have increasingly established joint ventures and local manufacturing partnerships within India. The production of drones, electronics, missile systems and components has become embedded within India's expanding defence industrial base. This localisation means that India's role is no

Reports of sustained military shipments will inevitably invite greater scrutiny from partners across the Middle East and beyond



PRABIR DE

THE SO-CALLED sonali adhyay, or golden phase of India-Bangladesh relations after 1971, appears to have receded. Trade integration, cross-border connectivity, energy interdependence, and the political economy of regional cooperation now face multiple constraints. Although Bangladesh continues to be one of India's principal trade partners in South Asia, the trade relationship stands at a critical juncture, caught between the possibility of renewed cooperation and the risk of reversal.

While imports from India have declined, imports from China and Malaysia have re-

A strategic partnership faces an ethical question

longer confined to importing Israeli systems but increasingly extends to manufacturing equipment and supplying components.

It is precisely this evolution that gives the Amnesty report its significance. If the findings are accurate, they suggest that India has become more than just a customer; it has also emerged as a contributor to Israel's defence supply chain during one of its most controversial military campaigns. At a time when Israel has faced mounting international criticism, legal scrutiny and growing pressure on defence exports from several traditional suppliers, India's manufacturing capacity appears to have helped mitigate some of those supply-chain constraints, particularly in such areas as drones and ammunition.

For years, India has sought to balance an increasingly close strategic partnership with Israel while maintaining its longstanding support for the Palestinian cause and its expanding economic and energy relationships with the Gulf states. That has become more difficult as the Gaza conflict intensified. Reports of sustained military shipments will inevitably invite greater scrutiny from partners across the Middle East and beyond.

Given the complexity and depth of the India-Israel relationship, which runs the gamut from agricultural technology to weapons production, it is unlikely that New Delhi will abruptly terminate its defence ties regardless of the revelations in the Amnesty International report. However, the disclosure is likely to

have two important consequences.

At a domestic level, elements within the Congress who have been sceptical of the steady embrace of the Netanyahu government under Modi are likely to highlight these disclosures and try to embarrass the ruling party. Such an attempt, however, is unlikely to gain a great deal of traction when most of India's public is focused on the student agitation in the wake of the exam paper leaks.

Externally, in the Arab world, it may draw some attention and lead to a few expressions of public displeasure. Nevertheless, it is hard to believe that India's key Arab partners were wholly unaware of India's expanding defence and security links with Israel. More to the point, unlike decades ago during the Cold War, there is no unified Arab opinion toward Israel despite their periodic (and mostly cosmetic) denunciations of Israel's handling of the Palestinian issue. A few Muslim nations, outside the Arab world, ranging from Turkey to Malaysia, may express diplomatic outrage but, once again, New Delhi is unlikely to change its policies because of it.

These political considerations aside, the larger question of the ethics of participating in the joint production of weaponry with the current government in Israel — whose conduct of the war in Gaza has drawn widespread global disapprobation — may be deserving of debate.

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Delhi-Dhaka need reset, must let go of political baggage

portedly increased in the post-Sheikh Hasina period. Energy cooperation illustrates the growing material interdependence between the two economies. India's electricity exports to Bangladesh, the Maitree Super Thermal Power Plant, and the India-Bangladesh Friendship Pipeline have expanded cross-border energy flows and created a more institutionalised framework for infrastructure cooperation. Future collaboration may increasingly depend on renewable energy, grid modernisation, storage technologies, and market-based cross-border power trading. In this sense, energy cooperation is not simply a sectoral issue but a mechanism for building regional public goods. Trade diversion away from India is largely driven by the growing use of non-tariff measures (NTMs), including

sudden land-port restrictions, the withdrawal of transshipment privileges, anti-dumping duties, and stringent testing or certification requirements. These regulatory barriers raise overall trade costs and disrupt supply chains, particularly for garments, food products, and production materials.

India-Bangladesh relations should not be held hostage to the question of Hasina's stay in India. She, her father Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, and her party played a historic role in Bangladesh's nation-building, but the future of bilateral relations

India-Bangladesh relations should not be held hostage to the question of Hasina's stay in India

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> must be shaped by the interests of both societies. Second, both countries should allow a freer flow of goods and services across their borders. If trade retaliation continues to grow, friendship will weaken, and the two countries may remain neighbours without functioning as a true neighbourhood. Third, Bangladesh should not overlook the advantages of being located next to one of the world's largest economies. A well-designed bilateral agreement could shift the relationship from a narrow goods-trade model toward a broader framework covering investment, services, standards harmonisation, digital trade, logistics facilitation, and regional value-chain development. For Bangladesh, such an agreement is especially relevant in light of its forthcoming graduation from least developed country status, which

will gradually alter its preferential access to major external markets. For India, deeper economic integration with Bangladesh supports both its Neighbourhood First approach and its Act East orientation.

The current political flux does not imply an inevitable breakdown of economic cooperation. A durable reset will require both governments to rebuild trust through formal diplomatic channels, transparent communication, and mutually beneficial economic frameworks. Standing at this crucial turning point, the relationship requires a reset that moves beyond accumulated political baggage.

The writer is professor, Research and Information System for Developing Countries (RIS), New Delhi

Problem is not Sanatan Dharma. It's what politics has done to it



GITANJALI J ANGMO

RECENTLY, I wrote that the Sansad Chalo protest was Sanatan Dharma in action. Young people had come from different corners of India, from different faiths, castes, and backgrounds. They stood together for education, a cause larger than themselves. They shared food, made space for strangers, protected one another and somehow became a community without asking who belonged to which community. To me, that was Sanatan Dharma. But it met with a huge backlash. My response section got filled with labels. Sanghi. BJP stooge. RSS sympathiser. It made me wonder: When did speaking of Sanatan Dharma automatically place you on one side of India's political divide? Perhaps the problem is not Sanatan Dharma. Perhaps it is what politics has done to it.

To understand this, remember what many Indians thought they were voting for in 2014. It was more than a change of government. After generations of looking at ourselves through borrowed eyes, Indians were beginning to look inward again. Millions wanted more than economic growth. They wanted to rediscover themselves. The BJP understood that longing better than any other party. It presented itself not merely as an alternative government but as the custodian of India's Hindu inheritance. In doing so, it came to define what "Hindu" politics looked like. But what if much of what we now associate with that politics is the opposite of the tradition invoked in its name?

Sanatan Dharma is not an identity to be defended against another. It is a discipline of living: *Sat* before propaganda, *nyaya* before power, *dhairya* before intimidation, *purvapaksya*, understanding the opponent's point of view before indoctrination, and *lokasangraha*, the welfare of all before one's tribe. Set against these, perhaps what we have witnessed in the last 12 years is not the flowering of Sanatan Dharma but its shrinking.

Consider intolerance and stereotyping. If you question the government, you are labelled anti-national, foreign-funded, a Chinese agent. How did this happen in the land of the Upanishads? Our foundational texts are conversations, dialogues, debates. The Bhagavad Gita exists because Arjuna questions Krishna, Gargi questioned Yajnavalkya. Hindu thought accommodated an astonishingly diverse spectrum. Disagreement was evidence that it was alive.

This is why stereotyping in popular culture troubles me too. When films such as *Dhuanandhar* repeatedly place Muslim or Pakistani characters within a familiar silhouette of villainy, I worry not only about the social consequences but about the storytelling. Real human beings are inconveniently complicated. Great storytelling unsettles our prejudices. Propaganda confirms them.

Then I get into my car and meet Ehsan, my driver. He is Muslim and has one daughter. He does not plan to have more children but aspires to educate her, and give her choices his generation did not have. The stereotype collapses.

Many of our problems with population or social reform, that we lazily turn into a religious one, are often an education and development problem. When we start focusing on education, women's agency, healthcare and economic security, they begin to change. It is for this same reason secularism must also mean equality before the law. If India is secular, why should governments run temples? What forms of state support for religious pilgrimages are justified? And why should marriage, divorce, inheritance, adoption or polygamy be governed differently depending on one's religion? Religious freedom cannot mean unequal citizenship. These are the questions a Uniform Civil Code should allow us to debate openly. Reform what needs reform, but through Parliament, law, education and reason.

A living society questions. A confident government answers. Therein lies the deeper challenge before the BJP. If Sanatan Dharma is truly the inheritance it seeks to protect, it cannot appear only in temples, speeches and election campaigns. It must become visible in the conduct of ministers, the fairness of institutions, and the behaviour of *karyakartas* and *pracharaks*.

Sri Aurobindo said at Uttarpara, "When it is said that India shall rise, it is the Sanatan Dharma that shall rise." He was speaking of inner transformation above outer conquest, recognising a deeper unity beneath our differences. The opportunity before the BJP was extraordinary. It was given both the political mandate and the cultural moment to reclaim Sanatan Dharma by building a modern India upon its principles: Confident enough to question, just enough to protect the dissenter and inclusive enough to embrace diversity. *Dharma* asks something infinitely harder of us than defending Hindu identity. It asks us to transcend identity. To encounter the person before the label. The human being before the vote. That would be being *vishwaguru*: India living her wisdom well enough for the world to emulate.

Whether the BJP becomes the instrument of that renaissance is now up to the BJP itself. If it can live the *dharma* it claims to defend, it may yet play an extraordinary role in helping India fulfil her destiny. If it cannot, another instrument will emerge to carry it forward. Sanatan Dharma does not need the BJP to survive. The question is whether the BJP will choose to become worthy of it.

The writer is founder, Himalayan Institute of Alternatives, Ladakh

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Rationing exercise

INDIA'S PROPOSED amendments in the food-security framework risk turning a rights-based approach into a rationing exercise, echoing outdated charity models rather than modern welfare states. ('Food Security Act amendments will hurt the poorest,' IE, August 8) The writers warn that the proposed changes erode the moral foundation of India's food security regime. By curtailing entitlements under the Antyodaya Anna Yojana, the state appears to privilege fiscal arithmetic over the Gandhian ethic of safeguarding the "last person". In essence, food and nutrition must be treated as rights, not a fiscal "burden".

Abhinav Shah, Lucknow

A cruel process

TARUN TEJPAL'S case is also a study of India's justice delivery system and how much has changed between 2012 and now, despite the more stringent law against offenders. ('Behind Tejpai verdict, survivor's long journey,' IE, August 7) The sessions court took eight years to decide the case that the High Court called perverse. Now the survivor has to wait for the case to be taken before the Supreme Court. This makes the search for justice expensive, and the end of the survivor's agony seem impossible.

YG Chouksey, Pune

Let art be

ART BY its very nature ought to imagine alternative realities and question conventional thought. It was how, for years, a parallel art industry thrived in the Hindi film ecosystem, and gave us numerous gems. ('Blame the ecosystem, not the industry,' IE, August 7) For many years now, majoritarian politics has come to define the creative psyche of the nation. The Indian film industry, Hindi films most of all, needs a nurturing and supportive ecosystem where filmmakers are free to explore every idea under the sun and push their artistic boundaries without fear of being cancelled and shut down.

Rahul Gaur, Gurgaon

Netanyahu says Israel won't pull out of Gaza until Hamas disarms

Reuters
Cairo, Jerusalem, August 9

ISRAELI PRIME Minister Benjamin Netanyahu restated his rejection of Donald Trump's latest Gaza plan in televised remarks to his right-wing government on Sunday, even as Israel's military has effectively halted attacks in the territory under pressure from the US President.

Netanyahu is in campaign mode as he seeks re-election at a vote due on October 27 but is caught between far-right ministers angered by concessions in Gaza and his key military backer, Trump, who wants progress toward ending the conflict there with a new 15-point peace plan. Israel has scaled back attacks in Gaza since Monday, when Nikolay Miladenov, the Gaza envoy for Trump's Board of Peace that oversees the Gaza ceasefire, met with Netanyahu.

A source familiar with Israel's position said it had agreed that the military would only act against what it perceives as immediate threats in Gaza and no longer carry out targeted assassinations as it had been doing on a near-daily basis.

Trump announced last month there had been a breakthrough to end the war, to which both Israel and Hamas agreed.

SAUDI ENERGY MINISTRY SAYS ARAMCO'S JAZAN REFINERY FIRE WAS EXTINGUISHED, NO INJURIES

Houthi attack key Saudi refinery after kingdom signs defence pact

Yemeni military says drone strikes on port city killed 7

Reuters
August 9

YEMEN'S IRAN-aligned Houthis have attacked Saudi Aramco's Jazan refinery, they said Sunday, two days after the kingdom signed a defence pact with Turkey and Pakistan in response to growing regional instability from the US-Israeli war on Iran.

The alliance with Sunni Muslim US allies, Turkey and Pakistan, is intended to strengthen collective deterrence against any act of aggression and stipulates that an armed attack against any of the three would be regarded as an attack on all.

It was not clear whether or how either Pakistan or Turkey would join in any Saudi response to the latest attacks.

The Houthis declared a naval blockade against Saudi Arabia in Red Sea last month, citing what they said was a Saudi siege, an allegation



Smoke rises after a Houthi missile strike on the Red Sea port city of Mocha, Yemen, on Sunday. REUTERS

Riyadh denies.

The Saudi energy ministry said a fire had broken out at the refinery but was extinguished with no injuries and authorities were dealing with the incident, without giving a cause.

The Houthis used a drone to target the refinery, military spokesperson Yahya Saree posted on X. They had struck Aramco sites before in Jazan, which processes 400,000 barrels of crude oil per day in southwestern Saudi Arabia. They had also hit Yanbu on the Red Sea.

In a separate statement, Saree said Houthis carried out missile and drone strikes on the Yemeni Red Sea port city of Mocha. The port, controlled by the Aden-based government, is close to the strategic Bab el-Mandeb strait, which links the southern Red Sea with the Gulf of Aden and the Indian Ocean. Should it be closed, Saudi Arabia would be deprived of an alternative to Strait of Hormuz.

Three Yemeni government sources told Reuters that air defences were engaging drones

launched by the Houthis towards the commercial quay and storage in the port.

Saree said the Houthi strikes targeted Saudi troops and weapons arsenal in the area. There was no Saudi comment on the attacks in Yemen.

Rashad al-Alimi, head of Yemen's Saudi-backed presidential council, on Sunday briefed US Mission to Yemen Chargé d'Affaires Neil Hop on the developments, according to a statement.

He said the Houthis' attack put a responsibility on the international community, foremost among them the US, to "move beyond only containing the Houthi threat to addressing its sources and instruments".

The Yemeni military spokesperson said the attack on the port killed seven people. The Yemeni transportation ministry said in a statement that the attack caused severe damage to the port's infrastructure.

No one from the Pakistan government could immediately be contacted and the Turkish government did not respond to a request on Sunday for comment on the implications of the refinery attack.

Pezeshkian met Mojtaba Khamenei recently: Report

Dubai: Iran President Masoud Pezeshkian met Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei around start of president's third year in office in late July, state media said Sunday, and a paramilitary leader promised footage of Khamenei in the future.

Pezeshkian has given differing accounts in recent weeks about his access to Khamenei, who has not been seen in public since he succeeded his father in the role in March.

On July 21, the president said interactions with the supreme leader were "increasing day by day", but in early August he said communicating with Khamenei was "very difficult". REUTERS

Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan said on Friday, as the alliance was announced, that it was not directed against Iran or any other country, but rather served as a general pledge to support the three allies' security.

• BRIEFLY

UNITED STATES

Ex-President Joe Biden's cancer has spread, very painful, says his son



Former US President Joe Biden during a press meet at the White House

FORMER PRESIDENT Joseph R Biden Jr's prostate cancer has spread to other parts of his body, leaving him in pain, his son Hunter Biden said in an interview broadcast on Friday. "It's metastasized into his bones and further," Hunter Biden told a BBC journalist. "It's very painful and it's very debilitating, in many respects." The former president, 83, was diagnosed in May 2025 with an aggressive form of prostate cancer, his office revealed at the time. Last year, he had surgery to remove skin cancer lesions and completed a round of radiation therapy. NYT

RUSSIA

Deputy PM calls for rail route to Indian Ocean

RUSSIA NEEDS to create a railway route to the Indian Ocean to reduce dependence on strategically sensitive maritime choke points like the Strait of Hormuz and Bosphorus Strait, Russian Deputy PM Marat Khusnullin has said. "A rail link to the Indian Ocean should also be explored. Any options providing access to India are acceptable," Khusnullin told TASS news agency. PTI

UNITED STATES

Woman, baby die after boat sinks near New York

THE OPERATOR of a boat that capsized in New York Harbour, killing a mother and her infant daughter, is facing criminal charges, and authorities are investigating whether the vessel was an illegal charter, the US Coast Guard said Sunday. Twelve people were rescued and police divers later located the 27-year-old woman and the 5-month-old girl in the water. AP

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

PAKISTAN

Security forces kill 15 militants in Balochistan

PAKISTANI SECURITY forces have killed 15 terrorists in separate sanitisation operations in different parts of the restive Balochistan province, state-run media said Sunday. The terrorists were killed in the separate operations in Mastung, Bolan, Washuk, Awaran, Sibi, Khuzdar, Harnai, and Nushki areas during Operation Raddul Fitna 3 carried out over a week, it said. PTI

NEPAL

Bodies of five missing climbers found a year later

NEPALI RESCUE workers have spotted five bodies at a site where the same number of climbers went missing last year, officials said Saturday. Three climbers, an Italian Canadian, an Italian and a German, and two Nepali nationals have been missing since November last year after being struck by an avalanche on Yalung Ri mountain. Two others, an Italian and a French climber, had died at base camp. REUTERS

How a drone 'hellscape' might stop a Chinese invasion of Taiwan

Chris Buckley & Amy Chang Chien
Taipei, August 9

TO REPEL any future Chinese invasion, Taiwan is building fleets of flying drones and unmanned attack boats.

The goal is to use them to help locate and attack Chinese forces approaching the island, relying on Taiwanese soldiers trained to move quickly before China can strike them. US commanders who developed this strategy call it a "hellscape": overwhelming an invading force with waves of drones, missiles and artillery, and mak-

ing an amphibious assault so risky that China's leaders are deterred from trying.

Inspired by lessons from Ukraine and other recent war zones, Taiwan is now accelerating efforts to put that strategy into practice. "Our drone and counter-drone efforts started relatively late, and initially we were trying things out as we went along," Lt. Gen. Huang Wen-chi, the director general of strategic planning for the Taiwanese Defense Ministry, told a committee of lawmakers Wednesday. That has begun to change over the past two years, he added.

On Thursday, Taiwan's mili-



Members of Taiwan's military operating a drone during the annual Han Kuang military exercises in Changhua, Taiwan on Thursday. NYT

tary allowed reporters to watch as troops in central Taiwan practiced using drones for re-

connaisance, as part of the island's annual Han Kuang military exercises, which began on

Wednesday and will run for 10 days. Maj. Gen. Lu Wen-yuan, who helped plan the exercises, said earlier that they would also train troops to take out enemy drones.

Many militaries across the world are embracing the drone revolution, but Taiwan faces a particularly urgent threat: China, which is roughly 110 miles away, claims the self-governed island as its territory.

Chinese leaders say they want to absorb Taiwan peacefully, but will not rule out using force.

They are backing that threat with expanding fleets of warships, planes, missiles and drones, as well as more fre-

quent coast guard patrols and landing exercises.

Taiwanese officials have noted Ukraine's drone-driven gains on the battlefield, and they are trying to emulate Ukraine's David-versus-Goliath approach: using relatively cheap and nimble drones to level the playing field against a much larger adversary.

"Drones are entering a new chapter," said Max Lo, the chairman of the Taiwan National Drone Industry Association. "Taiwan, for its own survival and national defense, is in urgent need of these drones. But it's the same everywhere in the world right now — that's an opportunity for Taiwan." NYT

Ukraine, Russia accuse each other of lethal attacks, Odesa port struck

Reuters
Kyiv, Moscow, August 9

UKRAINE AND Russia accused each other of lethal attacks on Sunday, as President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Moscow was targeting global food security by striking Odesa's seaport.

Three people were killed and 37 wounded in the eastern Ukrainian city of Kharkiv, where a multi-storey apartment block was hit, while authorities in Russia's Belgorod said five were killed and 25 wounded by a Ukrainian drone attack.

Zelenskyy said Odesa's seaport had been damaged by a strike. Local authorities said dozens of drones and missiles hit the southern seaside city, wounding a dozen people.

"In this way, the Russians are at war with the world's food security," Zelenskyy said. He said Russia also hit nine other Ukrainian regions on Sunday.



Emergency crews at the site of an Russian missile strike in Odesa. AP

Odesa in an attempt to cut Ukraine off from the Black Sea.

As Ukraine seeks to disrupt Russia's revenues for waging war, it has hit Russian oil tankers and other cargo vessels in the Black Sea, claiming another three such strikes on Sunday.

Both sides have launched a broader campaign against the other's logistics, with e-commerce warehouses on both sides and Ukraine's petrol stations coming under heavy attack dur-

ing the summer months.

Ukraine's energy ministry said Russia had attacked power facilities in the Odesa region, causing a "significant amount" of the port city's residents to lose electricity overnight. It said power had already been restored to 90,000 consumers.

Russia's Defence Ministry said it hit fuel storage facilities "used in the interests" of Ukrainian military in the ports of Odesa and nearby Chornomorsk.

Sharif's PML-N softens stance on PoK protesters, now calls them 'patriots'

Press Trust of India
Islamabad, August 9

SET TO take charge of the so-called government in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir, the PML(N), headed by Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and his brother Nawaz, seems to be on the back foot in dealing with protesters in the region, following months of violence.

Prime Minister's adviser Rana Sanaullah on Saturday said 99 per cent of the protesters in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) are "patriotic" people.

He further said the political party's representatives would soon meet members of the banned Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC) - a collective of activists that have been spearheading protests in the region.

Till a few days ago, the political party maintained that members of the banned terror-

ist group Tehrik-e Taliban were present among the protesters, to justify the government's crackdown on them.

Addressing a rally on Saturday, ahead of the third phase of "elections" in PoK, Sanaullah said: "Ninety-nine per cent of those associated with the Joint Awami Action Committee are our patriotic brothers."

Sanaullah further said on Saturday, "When the PML(N) government will be formed with two-third majority, it will sit with [Joint Awami] Action Committee representatives. Their first task will be to resolve this issue."

In the two phases of the polls held so far, the establishment-backed PML(N) has won 25 seats - crossing the majority mark in the so-called assembly in PoK, which has 45 elected seats, amid widespread violence and allegations of massive rigging.

Typhoon Dolphin hits China; 1mn evacuated, 1,500 flights cancelled

Reuters
Beijing, August 9

TYPHOON DOLPHIN, the most powerful tropical cyclone to hit China this year, made landfall on the country's eastern coast on Sunday, bringing torrential rain and strong winds and triggering warnings of flooding and landslides.

The typhoon has already swept through Japan's southern Okinawa prefecture, injuring six people and cutting power to more than 50,000 buildings.

Typhoon Dolphin made landfall near Yuhuan in eastern Zhejiang province at about 5:30 pm on Sunday, China's meteorological authorities said.

Torrential rain is forecast through August 10 across Zhejiang, Shanghai, northern Fujian, northeastern Jiangxi, central and southern Anhui, and much of Jiangsu. Parts of central and eastern Zhejiang could receive 250-500 mm of rain, ac-



A child struggles to hold an umbrella as strong winds sweep Shanghai ahead of Typhoon Dolphin's landfall on Sunday. REUTERS

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RG09mljMzg1

cording to forecasters. After landfall, Dolphin is forecast to track westward before slowing over central and southwestern China and gradually losing strength, Wang Haiping, chief forecaster at the National Meteorological Centre, told state broadcaster CCTV.

Transport was widely disrupted across the east of the country and more than 1 million people were evacuated from

their homes. In addition to evacuating at least 30,300 people, Shanghai has cancelled about 1,500 flights, according to flight-tracking data provider Variflight. In neighbouring Zhejiang province, the city of Wenzhou relocated over 900,000 residents and opened more than 1,000 emergency shelters.

In Fujian province, authorities evacuated 98,900 people from high-risk areas.

Taylor Swift songs removed from White House and Trump posts

Reuters
Washington, August 9

SOME TAYLOR Swift songs have been removed from social media videos posted by President Donald Trump's campaign and the White House, which has used two of the American superstar's songs over the past week.

The White House and a representative for Swift did not respond to requests for comment.

Swift has not spoken recently about Trump, although she endorsed his Democratic rival, then-Vice President Kamala Harris, in 2024. During the 2020 campaign, Swift posted on social media Trump was "WELL AWARE we do not want him as our president."



Taylor Swift

Trump has repeatedly criticized Swift. After she endorsed Harris, the Republican said on social media, "I HATE TAYLOR SWIFT!" Last year he wrote: "Has anyone noticed that, since I said 'I HATE TAYLOR SWIFT', she's no longer 'HOT'?"

Artists, including Sabrina Carpenter and Ariana Grande, have called on Trump administration not to use their songs.

• UNIVERSITY OF DELAWARE RESEARCHERS ARE TESTING WHETHER SHARKS CAN SERVE AS MOBILE OBSERVERS BY CARRYING SENSORS THAT MEASURE OCEAN CONDITIONS

Jaws: Scientists turn to sharks to improve hurricane predictions

Reuters
August 9

FROM THE killer shark of Jaws to the tornado-tossed predators of the Sharknado movies, films long have portrayed sharks as objects of summer fear.

But when a shark cuts through the waters off the US East Coast, it now may be doing more than hunting. It may also be gathering data that helps scientists understand the potential intensity of a hurricane before it makes landfall.

University of Delaware researchers are testing whether sharks can serve as mobile near-real-time ocean-data observers, carrying sensors that measure

ocean conditions to inform oceanographic, atmospheric and climate models.

These CTD tags are small electronic devices that measure ocean electrical conductivity, a metric closely related to salinity, as well as temperature and depth, as marine creatures to which they are attached swim and dive.

"Animal-borne sensors have been used successfully by oceanographers for years, particularly on elephant seals in polar regions where scientific observations are scarce," said Aaron Carlisle, principal investigator and a professor in the university's School of Marine Science and Policy.



A mako shark caught by researchers; Researcher Aaron Carlisle works to place a tag on a white shark off coast of Delaware. REUTERS

Sharks offer a new opportunity in such research because they are abundant, widely dis-



tributed and easier to access than many protected marine mammals, Carlisle said. Until

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

now, shark tagging typically has tracked only where these fish travel and the habitats they use.

The University of Delaware researchers select sharks that can collect the measurements most useful for hurricane research, and favour species that surface often enough for their tags to transmit the information to satellites. Previous analyses identified shortfin mako sharks, blue sharks, smooth hammerheads and juvenile great white sharks as strong candidates for research in the North Atlantic.

"We are really most interested in the heat content of the top layer of ocean, which is known as mixed layer," Carlisle

said. "This is the part of the water column that really drives hurricane intensity, warmer mixed layer equals stronger hurricane, as it holds the heat that feeds hurricanes," Carlisle added.

The tagging process begins in early May, when highly migratory species move closer to the coast from their winter habitats further out in the Atlantic, according to Caroline Wiernicki, a University of Delaware doctoral candidate in marine science.

"The tags are attached to the dorsal fin. Then every time the shark fins (swims) at the surface, the tag can communicate and transmit data to the orbiting network of satellite receivers," Carlisle said.

HEADLINE CPI INFLATION ROSE TO 4.38% IN JUNE, WHILE CORE INFLATION HELD STEADY AT 3.9%

Dovish RBI’s core inflation views leave economists unconvinced

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 9

THE RESERVE Bank of India’s (RBI) legal target is 4%, in a band of 2-6%, in terms of the headline inflation rate as measured by the Consumer Price Index (CPI). But comments last week, when it left the policy repo rate unchanged at 5.25%, are making experts believe it is actually targeting core inflation — specifically, inflation minus food, fuel, and precious metals.

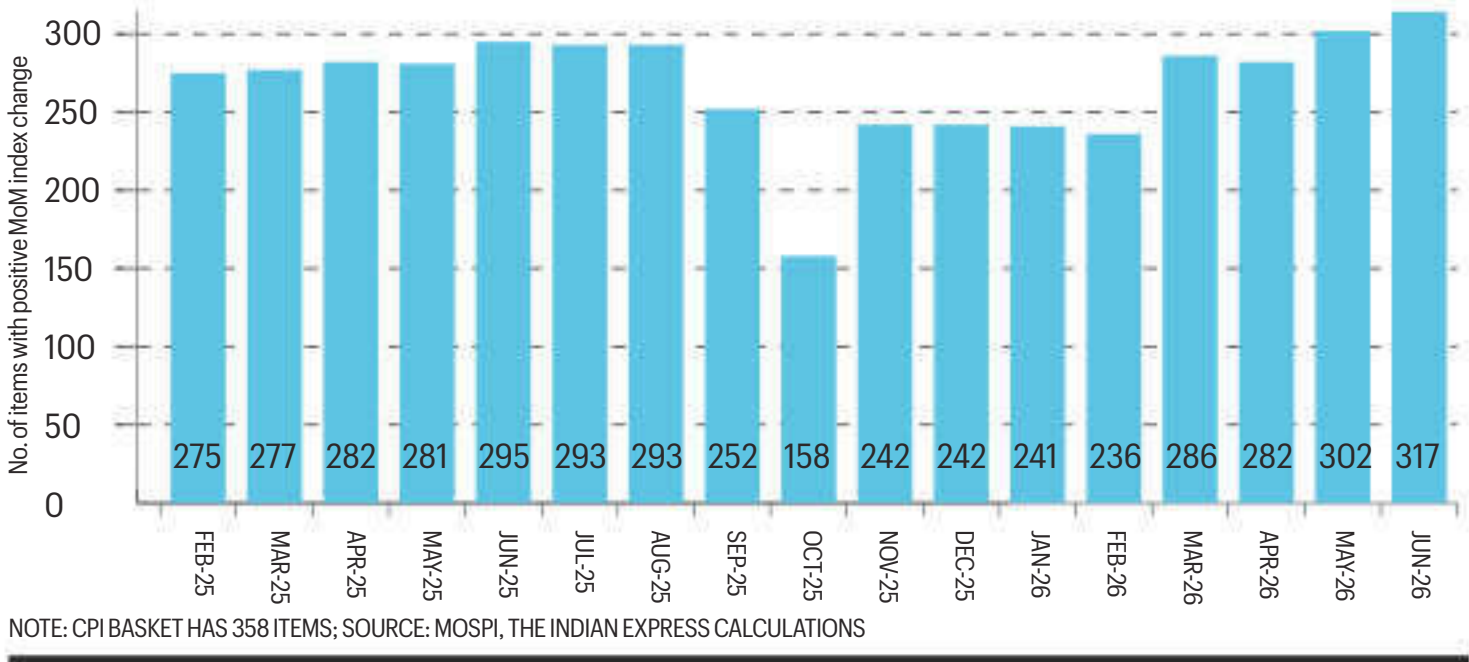
As per latest data, headline CPI inflation in June rose to 4.38% from 3.93% in May, with core inflation unchanged at 3.9%. Core inflation excluding precious metals stood at 2.5%.

This would not be the first time economists think the RBI’s Monetary Policy Committee is focussing more on underlying price pressures than the headline number. However, there is a certain lack of clarity that has left economists scratching their proverbial heads.

The purpose of excluding certain items such as food and fuel — whose prices can be rather volatile — is to understand how consumption demand is behaving in the economy. Households may not drastically change their consumption of food and fuel just because prices rise or fall — people can’t give up eating and necessary travel.

This is why focussing on the Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGF9mljMzg1

● 89% of CPI items saw higher prices in June vs May



NOTE: CPI BASKET HAS 358 ITEMS; SOURCE: MOSPI, THE INDIAN EXPRESS CALCULATIONS

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other items — demand for whom is discretionary in nature and reacts to price movements — can provide more useful information. With gold and silver inflation sky high, they are also excluded to arrive at a narrower gauge of core inflation, often called ‘core core’ or ‘super core’ inflation — or just core inflation excluding precious metals.

Questions about inflation target

According to the MPC, core inflation excluding precious metals “continues to be benign” and is “likely to align with core inflation towards the end of the financial year”. Essentially, core inflation excluding precious metals is seen rising fairly sharply from 2.5% to around 4%

by the end of 2026-27. The MPC’s statement also said any policy action warranted more clarity on inflation and its drivers and this action would have to consider “the need for recalibration of policy rates in line with the evolving growth-inflation dynamics, especially the normalisation of the underlying inflation from its benign levels seen hitherto”.

According to economists from ICICI Securities Primary Dealership (I-SEC PD), led by A Prasanna, the RBI’s statements taken together suggest the central bank has “zeroed in on core ex precious metals as the lodestar for monetary policy”.

Calling this communication “somewhat confusing”, I-SEC

PD said in a note last week that the comments reveal that the RBI may consider policy recalibration — interpreted to mean interest rate hikes — once the two measures of core inflation converge. Prasanna and co are concerned by the language for more reasons than one, first among them being that to suggest the RBI is going to ignore above-target headline inflation — it expects it to average 4.7% in July-September, 5.9% in October-December, 5.5% in January-March 2027, and 5.3% in April-June 2027 — “raises question marks about the inflation target itself”.

Is core inflation benign?

Another question is whether

core inflation excluding precious metals is indeed benign.

“Unlike the RBI, we see early signs that price pressures are spreading beyond food and fuel,” said ANZ economists Dhiraj Nim and Sanjay Mathur. According to them, although core inflation excluding precious metals was only 2.5% in June, the month-on-month momentum in prices was “firm, with annualised inflation in this sub-basket already running at 4-4.4%”. “Rising inflation expectations, elevated global commodity prices and resilient domestic demand suggest underlying inflation could build faster than the RBI currently anticipates,” they added.

Item-level data from the CPI basket indicates broadening of price pressures.

The CPI basket contains 358 items. In February, 236 of them saw higher prices compared to the previous month. This number rose to 286 in March, 282 in April, 302 in May, and 317 in June. Data for July will be released on Wednesday.

It is because of this core inflation focus that the RBI is being viewed as unexpectedly dovish, with Nomura economists expecting a recalibration of policy rates “primarily if there are signs of higher underlying inflation”. They don’t expect a rate hike this year.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

TWO AIRLINES, TWO LEADERSHIP TESTS

What lies ahead for IndiGo and Air India’s new CEOs

Sukaip Sharma
New Delhi, August 9

● FRESH LEADERSHIP

Foreign-origin leadership executives of Indian airlines require security clearance from the government before taking charge

While Walsh has taken charge at IndiGo, Air India said Gebremariam’s onboarding timeline will be announced in due course

LAST WEEK saw major changes in the corner offices of major Indian airlines. On Monday (August 3), Willie Walsh took over the reins at the country’s largest carrier IndiGo as its Chief Executive Officer (CEO), and on Wednesday (August 5), Air India announced former Ethiopian Airlines Group CEO Tewolde Gebremariam as its next CEO and Managing Director.

Both the leaders are joining Indian carriers at a time when they are emerging from one of the most turbulent years for Indian aviation in recent years.

Some of the challenges IndiGo and Air India faced last financial year, and continue to face, were in some measure common to both. These included the Pakistani airspace closure after the Pahalgam terror attack, the sharp rupee depreciation, West Asian airspace disruption, and the surge in global oil and jet fuel prices. Then there were airline-specific crises: the tragic crash of Air India flight AI 171 that killed 260 people in June 2025, and IndiGo’s network-wide operational meltdown in December.

While some of the challenges for the incoming CEOs may be common, the longer-term challenges for the two executives could hardly be more different.

IndiGo remains India’s largest airline by a wide margin and one of the world’s most profitable low-cost carriers. Air India is undergoing a once-in-a-generation transformation programme involving fleet renewal, organisational restructuring, and brand rebuilding. Both airlines are in different zones and looking for different things to chart the next phase of growth.

How Walsh and Gebremariam perform will not just shape the future of the carriers, but also the trajectory of Indian aviation. While Walsh has already taken charge at IndiGo, Air India said details regarding the exact onboarding timeline for Gebremariam will be shared in due course. Foreign-origin leadership executives of Indian airlines require security clearance from the government before taking charge.

Walsh has spent decades leading airlines through restructuring, consolidation, and regulatory change, first at Aer Lingus, then British Airways,

and later International Airlines Group. Most recently, he was director general of global airline industry body International Air Transport Association, where he cemented his position as one of aviation’s most influential voices on airline economics and regulation.

Gebremariam oversaw Ethiopian Airlines’ transformation into Africa’s largest carrier and a global airline, turning Addis Ababa into a major aviation hub while maintaining profitability through challenging economic cycles and global markets. Gebremariam served in Ethiopian Airlines for over 36 years, 11 of which were as group CEO. He took an early retirement from the airline in March 2022 due to health issues, and is currently a senior strategic advisor to Delta Airlines of the US.

On Walsh’s desk at IndiGo

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In his earlier stints as an airline CEO, Walsh built a reputation as a ruthless cost-cutter who

stabilised and expanded airlines while aggressively controlling expenses. At IndiGo, however, cost-cutting is unlikely to be his primary challenge, given its position among the world’s most cost-efficient airlines. Walsh’s earlier roles were often at bloated, loss-making airlines that needed drastic cost cuts. IndiGo is the opposite.

Walsh’s key focus area would most likely be driving IndiGo’s overseas ambitions, specifically long-haul expansion, in an increasingly complex global operating environment. It is already the largest domestic carrier with a 66% market share, and is also the country’s largest international airline, but its network is largely limited to short-haul international routes that can be serviced by its workhorse Airbus A320 fleet.

Walsh is also expected to strengthen IndiGo’s schedule

FDI threshold for CCEA approval to be raised to Rs 15,000 crore

Mukesh Jagota
New Delhi, August 9

IN A move that will further liberalise foreign direct investment (FDI) inflows, the government is considering raising the threshold for large FDI projects requiring the approval of the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) from Rs 5,000 crore at present to Rs 15,000 crore.

Currently, all FDI applications that need government approval and involve investment of less than Rs 5,000 crore can be approved by the Ministry or department overseeing the sector concerned. If the new pro-

posals is implemented, ministries and departments will get power to approve investments up to Rs 15,000 crore.

“Prevailing economic conditions, inflation, the growing scale of investments over the years, and the objective of promoting ease of doing business necessitate a review of the existing threshold,” sources said.

The limit was last revised in March 2016 to Rs 5,000 crore from Rs 3,000 crore. Before 2010, all FDI proposals worth more than Rs 600 crore went to CCEA for approval. In February 2010 it was raised to Rs 1,200 crore, and then by April 2015 to Rs 3,000 crore.

and operational resilience, ensuring that a repeat of December’s disruption is avoided, particularly as its network expands and densifies overseas.

This could mean investing in areas that do not immediately improve profitability and certainly lead to higher costs — additional crew reserves, stronger operational planning, more sophisticated scheduling systems, and greater flexibility to manage unforeseen disruptions.

Gebremariam’s challenges at Air India

Air India’s challenge is fundamentally different, and so would be Gebremariam’s.

Unlike IndiGo, Air India is not fine-tuning and expanding an already successful large airline, but is trying to build a premium carrier that hopes to be counted among the best in the world. Gebremariam will draw on his experiences at Ethiopian Airlines for this.

Under outgoing CEO Campbell Wilson — Air India’s first post-privatisation chief executive — the carrier embarked upon an ambitious transformation programme to shrug off its legacy image of a rundown government-owned airline. But it also faced challenges due to supply chain woes, suffered a tragic plane crash, came under intense regulatory heat, and faced heavy financial losses and headwinds like airspace closures and surging fuel prices. Despite the challenges, the foundational parts of its transformation plan have been executed under Wilson’s watch.

For Gebremariam, the key challenge will be to execute the next stage of the transformation plan, which would involve making product and service standards uniform and build an enviable hub-and-spoke network to equip Air India to compete with other global carriers of repute in terms of reach as well as quality of service. All of this would have to be accompanied by the endeavour to turn the loss-making airline into one that is consistently profitable. Safety is also likely to dominate the agenda. Various aspects of the airline’s transformation — from pilot training to maintenance practices and operational decision-making — will also be judged through the lens of safety as the shadow of the AI 171 crash still looms.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Standalone health insurers gain mkt share, general insurers slip

George Mathew
Mumbai, August 9

STANDALONE HEALTH insurers are steadily gaining ground in India’s non-life insurance market, with their share of premium income rising sharply in the first four months ended July of FY27 even as the broader general insurance segment ceded market share in the overall premium pool, according to General Insurance Council (GI Council) data.

The market share of standalone health insurers accounted for 14.10% of total non-life insurance premium, up from 11.72% in the corresponding period a year earlier. This represents a gain of 2.38 percentage points. In contrast, the share of general insurers — which offer a wide range of cover for motor, fire, marine and marine segments — declined to 85.34% from 86.43%, a fall of 1.09 percentage points, according to GI Council’s provisional data for the cumulative four-month period ended July 2026.

The shift becomes more striking when viewed through premium collections. General insurers recorded a cumulative gross direct premium of Rs 101,812 crore during the four months ended July 2026, up 8.09% from Rs 94,196 crore a year earlier. Standalone health insurers, however, grew much faster, with premiums rising 31.74% to Rs 16,827 crore from Rs 12,773 crore, data from GI Council, the body that represents non-life insurers.

● MARKET TREND

STANDALONE HEALTH insurers’ market share rose to 13.6% in FY26 from 12.5% a year earlier

THE SECTOR was supported by strong demand for health cover and scrapping of GST on retail health insurance

“General insurers have witnessed a decline in fire insurance premium income. They reported a growth of 19.9% in the health insurance segment for three months ended June 2026,” said an insurance official. The trend is consistent with the broader pattern seen in FY26, when standalone health insurers’ market share had already risen to 13.6% from 12.5% a year earlier. The sector has benefited from strong demand for health cover with the scrapping of GST on retail health insurance also supporting affordability and policy sales.

Among the five largest general insurers by market share in the July 2026 data, performance has been mixed. New India Assurance remains the largest general insurer, but its overall market share fell to 14.27% from 15.08%, a decline of 81 basis points. Its cumulative premium grew 3.58% to Rs 17,023 crore.

ICICI Lombard General Insurance, the second-largest among the five, saw its market share decline to 8.99% from 9.38%, a fall of 39 basis points. Its premium nevertheless in-

creased 4.95% to Rs 10,723 crore. United India Insurance was relatively stable, with market share edging down to 7.19% from 7.24%. Its cumulative premium grew 8.69% to Rs 8,572 crore, according to GI Council data.

The other two major players bucked the market-share decline. Tata AIG General Insurance increased its share to 7.07% from 5.91%, while its premium surged 30.86% to Rs 8,430.85 crore. Bajaj General Insurance also gained marginally, with market share rising to 6.83% from 6.67%. Its cumulative premium grew 11.98% to Rs 8,143.55 crore.

Taken together, the five largest general insurers accounted for about 44.35% of the overall non-life premium market, broadly unchanged from 44.28% a year earlier. This suggests that the loss of share by the general insurance category is not simply a story of the largest insurers losing ground to smaller general insurers. Standalone health insurers are capturing a growing portion of the overall insurance premium pool.

Among standalone health insurers, Star Health remained the largest, with its market share rising to 5.11% from 4.69%. Its cumulative premium grew 19.06% to Rs 6,090.72 crore. Care Health recorded 42.12% growth, while Niva Bupa grew 32.30%. Aditya Birla Health Insurance reported an even stronger 45.06% increase, data shows.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

● UNLOCKING RURAL ENTERPRISE GROWTH

India’s 43 million mini and nano rural enterprises could help bridge employment gap, says a report titled ‘State of Rural Entrepreneurship in India 2026’.

7-8 mn
New jobs needed every year until 2036 to meet the Viksit Bharat goal

These enterprises can catalyse employment generation and value creation but only if policy moves beyond piecemeal credit and short training to a targeted, integrated modernisation agenda, as per the report

“Future policy support must focus on sustained capability building and infrastructure upgrades for small rural enterprises,” it said

78% of the loans under Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana — which are collateral-free — are under ₹50,000

The amount is too low to buy big equipment or hire workers, and delayed payments further hinder growth

RURAL ENTERPRISE LANDSCAPE

43.1 million Rural enterprises with less than Rs 25 lakh investment

41.8 million Nano enterprises with investments below Rs 5 lakh

1.2 million Mini enterprises with investments between Rs 5 lakh and Rs 25 lakh

Only 7% are hired-worker enterprises with at least one paid worker, said the report based on data from Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises 2025

93% of all rural businesses are own-account enterprises

Hired-worker enterprises hold 6% of the fixed assets and have 7x higher value added per establishment

SOURCE: TRANSFORM RURAL INDIA AND IDINSIGHT

India achieves 300 GW RE capacity, 60% of 2030 target

New Delhi: India has achieved 300 GW, or 60% of its non-fossil fuel power generation capacity target of 500 GW, the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy said on Sunday.

In a major milestone for the nation’s clean energy transition

and climate action targets, India has crossed 300 GW of non-fossil fuel-based installed electricity generation capacity as on July 31, 2026; over 60% of the 500 GW capacity targeted to be achieved by 2030, a ministry statement said. PTI

● TRUMP IN JUNE REPORTED MORE THAN \$1.4 BILLION IN INCOME FROM HIS FAMILY’S CRYPTO VENTURES LAST YEAR

US Senate advances landmark crypto bill

Reuters
Washington, August 9

US SENATE Majority Leader John Thune moved on Saturday to advance a major bill that would create a regulatory framework for cryptocurrencies which, if passed, would mark a huge victory for US President Donald Trump and the crypto industry.

Thune, a Republican, early Saturday morning filed to set up a key procedural vote on the Clarity Act when the Senate returns from its August recess in mid-September, potentially paving the way for a full floor vote on the bill, according to the US Senate Press Gallery website.

The move suggests Senate Republican leaders believe they may yet be able to wrangle the 60 votes needed for the bill to pass, despite continued opposition by many Democrats.

Currently, the bill needs the support of at least eight Democrats and all of the Senate’s voting Republicans for it to pass.

The legislation would give the crypto industry its first comprehensive federal rulebook, defining when digital tokens are securities or commodities and which regulators oversee them.

Crypto companies say the act is necessary to provide legal clarity for the industry



Passage of Clarity Act would also hand Trump a second major crypto policy win. REUTERS

and could potentially boost the adoption of cryptocur-

rencies. The passage of the Clarity Act would also hand Trump a second major crypto policy win after he signed a bill supporting dollar-backed tokens known as stablecoins into law last year, even as Democrats say his family’s own crypto profits create a conflict of interest.

The crypto industry spent more than \$119 million backing pro-crypto candidates in the 2024 election hoping to advance the Clarity Act and stablecoin law.

Passage of the bill would be a blow for banks, which have fought to limit language that would allow crypto companies to effectively compete

for bank deposits by offering rewards on customer stablecoin holdings.

Trump, who courted crypto cash on the campaign trail and whose family has profited from its own token, has prioritized crypto reform during his second administration and the White House has also been pushing hard for the bill, Reuters had reported.

Trump in June reported more than \$1.4 billion in income from his family’s crypto ventures last year.

Democrats want more restrictions on government officials’ crypto ventures, and negotiations on that aspect of the bill remain fluid.

‘Apple tests China’s CXMT chips for iPhones, MacBooks’

Bengaluru: Apple has been testing memory chips from China’s CXMT across product lines including iPhones and MacBooks, to mitigate a component shortage fuelled by the AI boom, the Wall Street Journal reported on Sunday.

Apple held early talks with CXMT, which is China’s largest chipmaker by market value, about supplying components with the goal of using them in some devices sold in China, the report said, citing people familiar with the matter. Laptop makers HP and Acer have started using CXMT memory chips in devices sold outside the US to ease supply shortages, the newspaper said. REUTERS

● BRIEFLY

China’s July inflation eases to 3-month low

Beijing: China’s producer price inflation eased more than expected in July to its weakest in three months, while consumer inflation also cooled, official data showed on Sunday, as global energy prices retreated despite the West Asia war. China’s leaders, confronting a two-speed economy of strong factory output and exports but weak domestic demand, have pledged to bolster growth by accelerating fiscal spending on already budgeted infrastructure projects through year-end. REUTERS

Maruti sees PV market hitting 6.3 mn by 2031

New Delhi: Maruti Suzuki India expects the domestic passenger vehicle (PV) market to grow to 6.1 million-6.3 million units by fiscal year 2030-31, driven by a revival in demand for small cars and a stronger support utility vehicle segment, Chairman R.C. Bhargava said. Maruti is reassessing its five-year growth targets as it expects the small-car segment to expand significantly faster than in the past five years, the company said in a statement on Sunday, accompanying its 2025/26 annual report. REUTERS

WHY AJINKYA RAHANE

Ajinkya Rahane was one of India's batting pillars and Virat Kohli's trusted lieutenant during the team's dominant run between 2015 and 2022. His career-defining achievement came in 2020-21, when, in Kohli's absence, he captained a depleted Indian side to a remarkable 2-1 Border-Gavaskar Trophy triumph in Australia after the team rebounded from the Adelaide setback. Rahane finished with 8,414 international runs and 15 centuries across 85 Tests, 90 ODIs and 20 T20Is before retiring from all forms of cricket in July this year, leaving behind a legacy of resilience, calm leadership and memorable overseas performances

Devendra Pandey: When did you get the call from within yourself that 'I am done'?

It was a tough call because it was a 30-year journey. I started playing cricket when I was 7-8 years old and represented every age group for Mumbai. After the IPL, I played the Mumbai Premier League (MPL) and then spent some time with my family, sharing what I was feeling. They were surprised because they had seen my entire journey.

But I realised I was still enjoying cricket. Even in the MPL, the passion and effort were the same. I wanted to leave the game while I still felt that way rather than drag on. I didn't want to look back later and feel I should have retired sooner. I have no regrets about the kind of cricket I played or the intensity and attitude I brought to it.

Devendra Pandey: Did you speak to any of your teammates (about retirement) or was it only your family?

I spoke to my father, my wife Radhika and Pravin (Amre) sir, who has been instrumental throughout my career. He said that if I had that feeling, I should respect it. I told him I still felt I could play for another two years, but I had no regrets. I achieved what I wanted and gave everything to the game. I also spoke to Prayagraj sir, whom I have followed since 2012-13 through Vedanta philosophy. He felt the same: 'Because we all know that you have given your best. The way you have played on the ground, the attitude you have played with, you have always kept the team ahead. So, you know it better than us.'

ON DECIDING TO RETIRE

I realised I was still enjoying cricket, and wanted to leave the game while I still felt that way rather than drag on. I didn't want to look back later and feel I should have retired sooner

Devendra Pandey: Was the goodbye note the toughest video to make?

After recording the video, I cried a lot. I was emotional while discussing retirement with my family but I didn't expect the recording itself to affect me so much. The reality hit that I would no longer do something I had loved for years.

The feeling that now, I won't be able to play for India again or go to the dressing room... so many years, from the dressing room to the ground, that wicket... my mind was always on that. That thought stayed with me throughout the recording.

Devendra Pandey: Will the walk to and from the dressing room be one of the things you will miss?

Yes. I will miss the walk from the dressing room to the ground, the anxiety, the nervousness and the preparation before every game. I will also miss the dressing room environment, the teammates and the memories we created together. Those are the things that stay with you for life, and I am grateful for the journey and everyone I played alongside.

Venkata Krishna B: Your debut came after a long wait. But once you got your chance, you scored hundreds away from home. Given that start and how it ended, how would you sum up your career?

I am satisfied because I gave my all. Before making my debut, I spent five to six years in domestic cricket, and every season was a learning experience. Even when I was warming the bench on overseas tours of Australia and England, I learnt by watching the seniors prepare.

Once I got my opportunity in South Africa, things went well. Throughout my career, it was always about the team. I never worried about my batting position and was happy to bat wherever the team needed me, from No. 3 to No. 7 in Tests and in multiple roles in ODIs. It was always about playing for the country, and I am really happy with my career.

Sandip G: You scored several important hundreds, but you also scored a lot of key forties, fifties and sixties. Like in Durban and Bengaluru. How gratifying were those knocks?

If you ask me about my best knocks, I would mention the 112 at the Melbourne Cricket Ground (in 2020 against Australia) and the 103 at Lord's (in 2014 against England). But some of my most satisfying innings were the 48 at Johannesburg (in 2018 against South Africa) and the unbeaten 38 in Sydney (in 2015 against Australia) that helped draw the Test.

Batting at No. 5 meant I often walked in during different situations. It was never about milestones but about contributing to the team. Those challenging situations upped my game, which is why those forties, fifties and sixties were really special knocks.

Sandip G: Those performances came on different tracks too. The Bengaluru innings (against Australia in 2017) was on a turner; the Johannesburg pitch had uneven bounce.

The situation we were in, in Bangalore (it was tough). They won the first Test match and were actually going well in the second Test. My 52 and the 118-run partnership with (Cheteshwar) Pujara changed the game, and we eventually won the series.

Shankar Narayan: You scored hundreds at Wellington, Lord's and Melbourne in 2014. Which knock remains the most special and why?

Your first hundred is always special. Mine was the 118 at Wellington. Before that, I had been dismissed for 96 in Durban because I started thinking about the hundred. In Wellington, when I reached the 90s, I told Zaheer Khan that I wouldn't think about the milestone and would simply watch the ball. That first hundred was really special because I stayed in the moment instead of thinking about the milestone.

Venkata Krishna B: Once the World Test Championship (WTC) was introduced, you played on several challenging pitches, which ultimately had a bearing on the average. How hard was that phase?

It was challenging but as a team, we accepted that approach because WTC points made home victories crucial. Taking advantage of spin-friendly conditions was the best thing to do in India, just as overseas teams used seaming conditions to their advantage.

Yes, batting averages dropped, but the focus was always on getting better and contributing to the team. The easiest position to bat was top two in India at that time because the ball was new and the wicket was really good. Batting in the middle order became

tougher as the ball got older, started reversing and the pitch deteriorated. Sometimes, even scores of 30 or 40 were really crucial.

Ketan: Can you talk to us about the century in each innings against South Africa in Delhi in 2015?

Before those two hundreds, the wickets had been difficult, and I knew I needed to trust my game while making a few tweaks. The Bengaluru Test had also been washed out for four days, giving me time to reflect. That helped me score hundreds in both innings. It remains a special memory.

Sandip G: You, Pujara and Kohli played a lot of cricket together from the first-class days till India. How was the bonding between the three of you?

Pujara and I played a lot together in domestic cricket, while Virat and I spent more time together playing for India. But the bonding we had was really good. We shared one goal — taking India's Test team to the top. From being ranked sixth or seventh in 2015, we gradually became the No. 1 Test side. We constantly discussed and analysed the game, learnt from each other and built a strong bond. Before becoming champions, we also went through difficult phases together in Tests, but it was enjoyable.

Devendra Pandey: Did any teammate speak to you after you announced your retirement? Which message was the most touching?

The first call came from Sachin (Tendulkar) *paaji*, who said he thought I would play

for longer. I told him I didn't want to drag on because I was retiring without any regrets. Irfan Pathan also called, while Pujara, Virat, Rohit and Bumrah all messaged me. I told everyone the same thing: I was satisfied because I had given everything to the game.

Devendra Pandey: In India, you played alongside the likes of Sachin Tendulkar and Rahul Dravid. How did the Indian dressing-room culture evolve during your career?

When I entered the Indian team in 2011, I spent the first five-six months observing the seniors. Sachin *paaji*, Rahul Dravid, (VVS) Laxman *bhai*, MS (Dhoni) and Viru *paaji* (Virender Sehwag) were all very supportive. Back then, only the playing XI got enough time in the nets. The ones outside did not bat a lot in the nets. But what I learned from watching them, I applied when I started playing. As the seniors phased out, the atmosphere changed. Since many of us had played together before, the camaraderie and togetherness was different. Our thinking was different. We believed playing an aggressive brand of cricket could make us win more matches. Then, when a younger generation came in, we wanted to create a welcoming dressing room, appreciate performances and leave no room for ego or jealousy.

Nihal Koshie: You were always calm and composed, without showing emotion as captain. Does that come naturally to you?

I have always been calm on the field. I do have emotions but I don't show them

openly. Everyone has their own style and way of expressing themselves, and I never wanted to copy anyone. I learnt from many players during my career but when I got the opportunity to lead, I wanted to stay true to my own style because of the experience of having played for so long.

Shankar Narayan: Kuldeep Yadav made his Test debut under your captaincy against Australia in 2017. Where do you see his career right now?

Kuldeep has developed immensely over the last four or five years, especially with his pace through the air. It is tough for any player who is in and out of the playing XI because cricket is all about rhythm, whether you are batting or bowling.

Kuldeep is a quality spinner. That is why I backed him in Dharamsala. I knew he was a wicket-taker. Even though he was inexperienced at the time, I believed throwing him into that situation would help because I was confident he would perform. You need to back your players, especially when they are match-winners.

Shuvaditya Bose: You rediscovered your batting in T20 cricket in IPL 2023, where we saw a big jump in your strike rate. How did you change your mindset and batting approach?

From 2019, after leaving Rajasthan Royals (RR), I hardly got opportunities with Delhi Capitals (DC) and spent one season with Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR). A player needs confidence and surety to play with freedom. Before DC, I played for RR for eight years. My job was to anchor the innings while others attacked around me. I

played accordingly.

Before IPL 2023, I spent two months preparing and worked on expanding my range of shots. Chennai Super Kings (CSK) also made one thing very clear: Whenever I got an opportunity, they would back me completely. I wasn't even supposed to play my first game but an injury gave me the chance. That innings against Mumbai changed everything but it was built on the preparation I had put in beforehand.

Mayank Chaudhary: Last year when you led KKR in the IPL, you faced a lot of unusual scrutiny. You were vocal about what was happening. What was going through your mind then?

I was vocal because I wanted to take the pressure away from my teammates, especially our inexperienced bowling attack. I wanted people to focus on me instead of the team so the players could perform freely. As a leader, you sometimes have to take the blame. We had lost five of our first six games but I had seen what our bowlers could do in the nets and believed they would deliver. I am generally not very outspoken, but I felt I had to become a different version of myself. It worked and we started winning.

Shuvaditya Bose: During 2022's Duleep Trophy final, there was an incident where you asked Yashasvi Jaiswal to go into the dressing room for a few overs. What made you take that decision at that stage?

Growing up in Mumbai, playing cricket in the city teaches you discipline and respect for the game. I sensed that the situation was, maybe, getting out of hand and felt it was my responsibility to control my teammate. I told Yashasvi to go inside, cool down for five or six overs and return. Later, the match referee told me he had prepared a four-match ban but tore up the letter because I had intervened. As a leader, you have to read the situation and act. So in the end, I was happy. He didn't get any ban and now he is playing for India.

Sriram Veera: You were a senior player and continued playing after the 2023 WTC final. Do you feel there should be better communication from selectors about where you stand? What were you going through during that phase?

Whatever I had to say on that topic, I have already said. I don't want to look back because I genuinely enjoyed my career.

Whether it was a hundred or a crucial forty or fifty, I was the happiest when my contribution helped India win. The love I received after retiring was overwhelming, and that's what I want to remember.

Sriram Veera: There was a lot of speculation recently about Rohit Sharma's ODI future. Should there be clarity that he would play the 2027 ODI World Cup, or should it be seen from a series-to-series viewpoint?

I think it is important to tell Rohit Sharma he is going to play the 2027 ODI World Cup. Just look at his contribution over several years. It has been amazing. You need the experience of such a player in a World Cup.

There should be no discussions around it. You can't look at it series by series because he is such a big player. Cricket is a game of rhythm, whether you are a youngster or an experienced player. There is no need to talk about his quality. There should be no debate. If he wants to play the 2027 World Cup, he should play. You can't doubt his intensity and attitude. Performances can go up and down but his experience could be useful in crucial matches. We should let them (Rohit and Virat Kohli) play freely. Everyone gets to that stage in their careers but seniors also like it when the captain and the team management back them. Let them just play till the 2027 World Cup.

Jayashree Narayanan: How have your diet and fitness routines changed post-retirement?

Retirement makes it tougher because I am a foodie. But fitness still matters after playing at the highest level for 14-15 years.

I always kept things simple and learnt what suited my body. Balance was the key. Karate and judo from my childhood helped me, while I focused on speed, agility and power rather than heavy lifting. Home-made food remains my comfort food and my favourite dish is *matkichi usal*.

Devendra Pandey: What next for Ajinkya Rahane?

I don't know. I retired only recently. *Sab news ab de dunga toh kaise hoga?* (How can I reveal everything right now?)

Devendra Pandey: How do you want the world to remember you?

A warrior and a perfect team man.



ILLUSTRATION: SUVAJIT DEY

ON HIS BRAND OF LEADERSHIP

As a leader, you sometimes have to take the blame. I wanted people to focus on me instead of the team so the players could perform freely. I felt I had to become a different version of myself



SCAN THE QR CODE TO WATCH THE VIDEO

{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

Why you must sit up straight

A SIMPLE CHANGE in posture may subtly affect how people feel and make decisions. In a study conducted by McGill University, participants who sat upright reported greater feelings of pride, took greater risks in a virtual balloon game and won rewards than those who hunched over. Most didn't realise researchers had influenced their posture, helping rule out the possibility that they were responding to expectations. Researchers used video software to measure neck angle as a benchmark for posture conformity. The results suggest workplace ergonomics could influence more than physical comfort.



Daily avocado lowers cardiac risk

A DAILY AVOCADO may help lower heart disease risk in adults with obesity by reducing the number of LDL (low-density lipoprotein or bad cholesterol) particles circulating in the blood. After six months, participants who ate an avocado every day had a four per cent reduction in cardiovascular risk. Researchers at the Penn State Department of Nutritional Sciences explain that since LDL particles carry LDL cholesterol, people with a higher number face a greater risk of heart disease, even when their total amount of LDL cholesterol is the same as someone with fewer particles.



Cancer-fighting chewing gum

RESEARCHERS HAVE developed a bio-engineered chewing gum that may offer a new way to target microbes associated with head and neck cancer. In tests involving oral samples from patients, extracts from the gum sharply reduced one virus and two types of bacteria linked to the disease. The new study by the University of Pennsylvania builds on earlier research involving chewing gum made from lablab beans (bean gum). The gum contains FRIL, a naturally occurring antiviral protein, which lowered HPV levels by 93% in saliva samples. HPV levels also fell by 80% in oral rinse samples.



Dementia risks you can change

NEARLY HALF of dementia cases may be connected to risk factors that people can potentially change, including smoking and high blood pressure. New research from Lund University has identified how specific risk factors are associated with Alzheimer's disease and vascular dementia, the two most common causes of dementia. Most of the modifiable factors examined, including smoking, cardiovascular disease, high blood lipids and high blood pressure, were associated with damage to blood vessels in the brain. They were also linked to a more rapid buildup of changes in white matter.



What keeps you motivated?

WHAT ALLOWS people to keep working toward a goal when the challenge becomes more demanding? Researchers at Nagoya University in Japan have identified a brain mechanism that may help explain how motivation is maintained. Their study found that orexin neurons play an important role in sustaining and regulating motivated behaviour. Blocking their activity weakened motivation in rats, pointing to a possible new target for understanding why people sometimes struggle to sustain goal-directed behaviour. Loss of motivation is common in conditions such as depression, addiction and ADHD.





CONSULTATION ROOM

BY DR JOHN JOSE

PROF OF CARDIOLOGY & INTERVENTIONAL CARDIOLOGIST, CMC, VELLORE

Why heart valve health deserves attention

As we age, valves thicken, stiffen or narrow down. This restricts blood flow

A FEW DECADES ago, growing older was often viewed as something to accept rather than actively manage. Slower days, less movement and lower energy were simply explained away as "age." Today, that conversation has changed. Healthy ageing is increasingly about disease prevention, preserving independence and maintaining quality of life. Yet preventive care often focusses on what appears in blood reports, scans and routine measurements. An equally important question can sometimes be overlooked: Can the person still do what matters most to them? The World Health Organization (WHO) defines healthy ageing as "the process of developing and maintaining the functional ability that enables wellbeing in older age." Heart health is central to preserving that freedom. Yet discussions usually focus on cholesterol, blood pressure and blocked arteries. A quieter, but equally important, aspect of heart health often receives far less attention — the heart valves.

The heart beats nearly 2.5 billion times during an average lifetime, continuously pumping blood to every organ and tissue. About the size of two clasped hands, it relies on four valves that open and close with every heartbeat, ensuring blood flows in the correct direction. As we age, these valves can gradually become thickened, stiff or narrowed. One of the most common and serious valve disorders is aortic stenosis, a condition in which the aortic valve narrows, restricting blood flow from the heart to the rest of the body. The American Heart Association recognises aortic stenosis as one of the most common and potentially serious forms of heart valve disease.

Unfortunately, heart valve disease often remains outside the healthy ageing conversation until symptoms begin to interfere with everyday life. Heart valve disease is missed because it usually develops slowly. According to the National Heart, Lung and Blood Institute (NHLBI), symptoms may include fatigue, shortness of breath, chest pain, dizziness or fainting. The challenge is not merely medical, it is also cultural.

Many older adults gradually adapt to declining stamina without realising that something may be wrong. They walk shorter distances, climb fewer stairs, avoid physical activity or take more frequent rests. Families often notice these changes but may attribute them to normal ageing rather than an underlying heart condition. Healthy ageing conversations should make room for these subtle changes, particularly when breathing, stamina or confidence in everyday activities begins to decline.

Sometimes the first clue comes during a routine physical examination. A doctor may hear a heart murmur — an unusual sound produced by turbulent blood flow across a diseased valve. An echocardiogram, a painless ultrasound examination of the heart, can then assess how well the valves open and close and how effectively the heart is functioning. Early diagnosis gives patients and families time to understand the condition, monitor progression and discuss treatment before complications set in.

Treatment for severe aortic stenosis has advanced considerably over the past decade. Selected patients may be suitable for a Transcatheter Aortic Valve Replacement (TAVR), a minimally invasive procedure in which a new valve is delivered through a thin catheter, usually inserted through a blood vessel in the leg, without the need for conventional open-heart surgery. However, there is no one-size-fits-all approach to valve disease. The best treatment depends on a comprehensive assessment that considers the severity of symptoms, valve anatomy, age, overall health, frailty, expected quality of life, personal goals and long-term care.

Patients require regular follow-up, adherence to prescribed medications, good control of blood pressure and diabetes, meticulous dental hygiene and prompt medical attention if they develop worsening breathlessness, chest discomfort, dizziness, fainting, fever or a sudden decline in energy levels. Healthy ageing prompts many important questions. How strong are the bones? Is diabetes under control? How good is memory? How healthy is the heart? There is one more question that deserves equal attention: How healthy are the heart valves? Regular health check-ups, paying attention to changes in stamina or breathlessness, timely medical consultation and an echocardiogram when indicated can help preserve mobility, independence and quality of life. Heart valve health deserves to be an integral part of any conversation on minimising risks.

Tabshir Shams

WHEN HE was eight, Pritam Chawla was left out of games because he tired out easily. Although he hated himself for it, he never quite understood why he would slump down after mild activity, feel heavy after eating and excuse himself from exercise class. But his father got him tested for cholesterol given their family history, and he was put on paediatric doses of heavy medication. At 27, he is on injectable drugs and pills to keep his cholesterol levels from surging. Much like Saket Sharma, who had his first heart attack at 38 and has had two rounds of stenting, and 72-year-old Sunil Bhatt*, who realised he had suffered three silent heart attacks before the one that got him to hospital last year.

A Gen Z, a Boomer and a Gen X, they all suffer from familial hypercholesterolemia, a serious inherited genetic condition that causes very high levels of low-density lipoprotein (LDL) or "bad" cholesterol, leading to a high risk of early heart disease and stroke. It is caused by gene changes passed down in families that stop the body from removing extra cholesterol from the blood. Indians experience a disproportionately severe burden of early-onset heart disease linked to it. Most importantly, keeping LDL under tight control is a tough challenge. While healthy habits support heart health, they rarely control the severe genetic buildup of cholesterol on their own. So, missing any one of the drugs or irregularity of use can spike LDL levels.

"People living with familial hypercholesterolemia can never let their guard down as they are required to keep their LDL to below 50 mg/dL if other personal risk factors or early signs of heart disease are present. First is a constant lifestyle check. Second is managing drugs," says Dr Gautam Naik, senior cardiologist at Apollo Hospital, New Delhi. They cannot solely depend on statins, which block an enzyme in the liver needed to make cholesterol. They need inhibitors for PCSK9, a protein made by the liver that reduces its ability to remove LDL from the blood. Drugs block this protein, allowing the liver to clear more LDL cholesterol and lowering the risk of heart attack and stroke.

These can lower cholesterol by about 60 per cent on their own but these injectables can cost up to Rs 40,000 per month for fortnightly dosing. The annual cost is about Rs 5 lakh, unaffordable for most. Over time, the body may require adjustments or stronger combination therapies. Rare, severe forms of familial cholesterol may require advanced therapies such as lipoprotein apheresis (a blood-filtering procedure).

That's why the announcement of Merck's new oral pill, Lipifendra (generic name elnicitide), which has similar properties as the injectable as it drops LDL by about 60 per cent, is giving hope to doctors. Though it has been approved by the US Food and Drug Administration (FDA), it will

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High cholesterol from birth 3 LIVES, 3 GENERATIONS and a lifelong fight against LDL

From a perennially exhausted child to survivors of repeat heart attacks, doctors explain why a genetic condition demands lifelong treatment

take some time coming to India after regulatory approvals here and may be priced a bit lower than injectables.

An unbending drug regime

When Pritam was first diagnosed as a child, he had dangerously high cholesterol at 130 mg/dL when it should have been lower than 110 mg/dL. Today, pursuing an MBA in foreign trade, his cholesterol is still a problem. Before he began injections, his count was at 450 mg/dL, several times the recommended level. "I still feel lethargic and I can't do heavy exercise either. I probably need to change my drug combination again," he says.

The irony, says Dr Naik, is that Pritam's condition has very little to do with what he eats. "His inherited disorder means he cannot remove LDL cholesterol from the blood like normal people. Think of the liver as the body's cholesterol-cleaning system. In his case, the clean-up crew is working half strength and may take several days to do their task compared to a couple of days in normal people. As a result, bad cholesterol stays in the bloodstream much longer and builds up from childhood."

Pritam's daily routine revolves around medication. He reels off the names without pausing to think — Ezetimibe (reduces the amount of cholesterol absorbed from food and bile in the small intestine) with Bempedoic Acid (reduces cholesterol production), Rosuvastatin (statin), Ecosprin (blood thinner) and Fenofibrate (reduces other blood fats and increases good cholesterol or HDL). For him, remembering prescriptions has become second nature.

Dr Naik says patients with familial hypercholesterolemia face a much greater risk of developing heart disease at a young age, so early detection is critical. "Many in India are not even aware that they may be living with this condition until an episode happens. It is then that they tell us that some members in their family tree have al-

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• What cholesterol drugs cost you

Price for common dose-oral tablets shown per strip of 10, in injectables per single dose

Rosuvastatin	Rs 30
Atorvastatin	Rs 45
Fenofibrate	Rs 45
Ezetimibe	Rs 55
Bempedoic acid	Rs 250
Evolocumab (injectable)	Rs 15,500
Inclisiran (injectable)	Rs 1,20,000



INDICATIVE RETAIL PRICES, GENERIC/Common BRANDS, ACTUAL COST VARIES BY BRAND AND CITY, SOURCE: PHARMARACK



SCAN THE QR CODE TO READ MORE HEALTH SPECIAL STORIES

from the OPD

ways had heart attacks in their 40s and 50s. That's why all Indian adults must undergo a baseline health assessment — including a lipid profile, blood sugar, HbA1c and cardiac evaluation — from their 20s onwards. Those with a family history of premature heart disease or inherited high cholesterol should begin screening earlier and undergo more frequent follow-ups," he suggests. In fact, if a patient is diagnosed, he insists that all first-degree relatives get themselves screened as well.

According to American Heart Association guidelines, children with a family history of very high cholesterol or premature heart disease should undergo a cholesterol test from two years of age. Without paediatric screening, these children are at risk of a premature, fatal heart attack in their 30s or 40s. All children should have at least one lipid screening between nine and 11 years, followed by another between 17 and 21 years. Adults should begin routine lipid testing at 19 years and repeat it at least every five years, with more frequent testing for those

at a higher risk.

Healthy habits aren't enough

If Pritam's story illustrates the challenge of living with a genetic disorder from childhood, Saket Sharma's is a reminder that even disciplined lifestyles cannot always overcome inherited risk.

The Gurugram-based businessman has never smoked, been a vegetarian and tee-totaler. He walks regularly, practises yoga and weighs 60 kg. Yet he suffered his first major heart attack at just 38. Since then, he has undergone angioplasty twice — first in 2004 and again in 2014.

Dr Manish Bansal, senior director of cardiology at Medanta, Gurugram, says Saket represents a group of patients in whom standard treatment often proves inadequate. "His LDL remained elevated despite multiple angioplasties. He also developed muscle pain while on statins," he says. He is now on inclisiran, a twice-yearly injectable therapy that helps scoop out LDL cholesterol more effectively.

For Saket, one of the hardest parts has been watching the condition repeat itself across generations. "My son, who is 22, has already started cholesterol medication. My daughter, who is 30, is also on treatment. My wife's father had high cholesterol, and so did my uncle."

Three heart attacks.....

For Sunil Bhatt*, 72, the warning signs never seemed dramatic enough to suggest a failing heart. While working with the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation in 2015, he began experiencing a heaviness in his chest whenever he boarded the train. It felt like acidity.

"I went to a general physician, who gave me medicine for gas. But the problem never really went away. Tests revealed 95 per cent blockages in two major coronary arteries. My resting pulse had shot up to nearly 250 beats a minute. I could literally feel my heartbeat outside my body," he says.

The biggest shock, however, came a few days later. Doctors told him he had already suffered three silent heart attacks before the one that finally brought him to hospital. Dr Bansal says Sunil's case represents one of the more difficult forms of cholesterol management. "He underwent angioplasty, continued to have persistently high LDL cholesterol and developed muscle pain that limited statin therapy. Only injectables work on him but they come with a heavy price tag," he adds.

For many patients, this is the dilemma. The medicines capable of dramatically lowering LDL are also among the costliest, forcing many to either stretch finances or settle for less effective alternatives.

Apart from his medicines, his daily routine now includes small but important adjustments in diet and a school routine-like consistency in his exercise and sleep patterns. "Life has become a series of careful calculations but that's the only way I can play with my grandchildren," he says.

(Name changed to protect privacy)

• CASCADE SCREENING

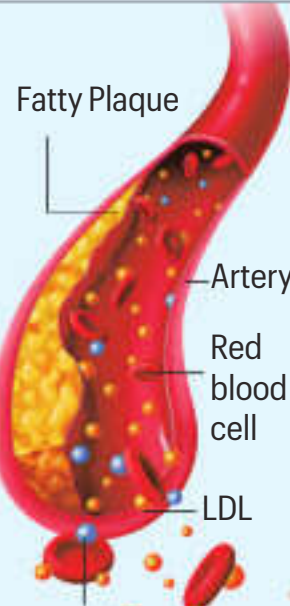
Why family screening can save you from premature heart disease

WHEN ONE person in a family is diagnosed with familial hypercholesterolaemia (FH) — an inherited condition that causes dangerously high cholesterol from birth — the diagnosis should not stop there. Experts are increasingly advocating cascade screening, a strategy in which parents, siblings and children of the affected individual are tested, as one of the effective ways to prevent premature heart attacks.

A parent with FH has a 50 per cent chance of passing the condition to each child. International experts estimate that the condition affects about one in 250 people, making it one of the most common

inherited disorders. Yet up to 90 per cent of cases remain undiagnosed worldwide. In India, that could translate to five to six million people living with the condition without knowing it.

Doctors recommend cascade screening as soon as one person in the family is diagnosed, either through markedly elevated LDL cholesterol levels. All first-degree relatives — parents, siblings and children — should undergo cholesterol testing. If another family member is diagnosed, screenings should then extend to their first-degree relatives, creating a "cascade" through the family tree. Experts also ad-



• Poor cholesterol Levels

Total cholesterol	above 200mg/dl
LDL	above 100mg/dl
HDL	below 50 mg/dl

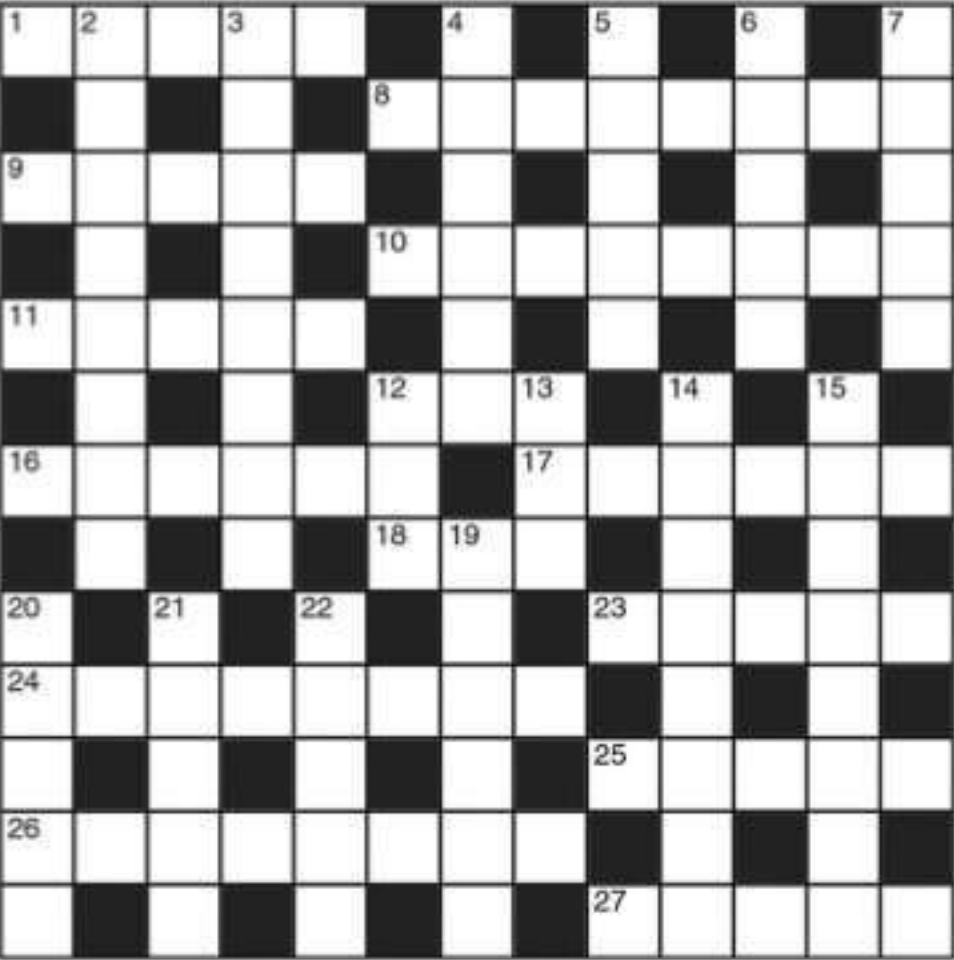
visiting people who have LDL cholesterol levels of 190 mg/dL or higher, those with a family history of premature heart disease (before 55 years in men or 65 years in women), or families in which multiple members have very high cholesterol or unexplained early heart attacks. Children in

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+42RvD_RGf9mjMzg1

affected families should be screened from five to 10 years of age, or earlier if there is a history of particularly severe disease.

How is cascade screening done? Once a person is diagnosed with familial hypercholesterolaemia — known as the index case — doctors first construct a three-generation family tree to identify first-degree relatives, including parents, siblings and children. These relatives are then offered a fasting lipid profile to measure LDL. Family members found to have FH are started on treatment and, in turn, become new index cases, prompting screening of their own first-degree relatives.

CROSSWORD



- ACROSS
- 1 Weapon made from spare parts (5)
- 8 Outstanding feature of country spot (8)
- 9 Many are fond of a spice (5)
- 10 Maybe finding rent a lot but not complaining (8)
- 11 Deprive one of his occupation (5)
- 12 Take a chance with the better half (3)
- 16 Squirm and wither away (6)
- 17 Spoke of alternative possible date (6)
- 18 Furious, being brought back by parent (3)
- 23 Lives with a girl in spring (5)
- 24 Gives way and dies (8)
- 25 Play it softly lad with a ring (5)
- 26 Arrival of actor is seen to cause delight (8)
- 27 Fresh ideas give confidence (5)
- DOWN
- 2 Friend goes to States for talks (8)
- 3 Recommend someone to take legal action (8)
- 4 Promise the old man a part (6)
- 5 Dread variety of snake (5)
- 6 Fare for a boy going to South Africa (5)
- 7 Stake out and fish (5)
- 12 It may be posted in quadruple (3)
- 13 Look up the French word for cat (3)
- 14 The fighters' craft (8)
- 15 Honoured by the voters but dishonoured by the bank (8)
- 19 Superior office (6)
- 20 Rewriting Yeats up to the moment (2,3)
- 21 A charming French accent (5)
- 22 Sand possibly holds uranium in this Arab country (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6062 ACROSS: 1 Weaverbird, 6 Amos, 10 Czech, 11 Outfitter, 12 Diocesan, 13 Allot, 15 Italics, 17 Abolish, 19 Enslave, 21 Mayfair, 22 Sinai, 24 Eventual, 27 At the time, 28 Titan, 29 Ease, 30 Santa Maria DOWN: 1 Wick, 2 Americans, 3 Ethic, 4 Blouses, 5 Rotunda, 7 Motel, 8 Stretchers, 9 Minatory, 14 Fire escape, 16 Imagined, 18 In a canter, 20 Evelina, 21 Mae West, 23 Notes, 25 Totem, 26 Inca

JUMBLLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

We should take care not to make the intellect our god; it has, of course, powerful muscles, but no ____ - Einstein (11)

TYAER

GIYLNT

POLIS

ILMPYP

ANSWER: We should take care not to make the intellect our god; it has, of course, powerful muscles, but no personality- Einstein

SOLUTIONS: Teary, Spoil, Tingly, Tramply

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6406

5			2		7
	4		1	3	
	9	6	4		
7	1				
	2	4	3		
				8	1
	1	9	6		
7	8			9	
4	2			3	

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6405

3	7	9	4	8	6	5	1	2
6	1	5	7	9	2	3	4	8
2	4	8	1	5	3	7	6	9
1	6	2	8	7	5	9	3	4
9	5	4	2	3	1	8	7	6
7	8	3	9	6	4	1	2	5
4	9	7	6	1	8	2	5	3
5	2	1	3	4	9	6	8	7
8	3	6	5	2	7	4	9	1

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

-
- ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): It's the beginning of the week, and you're up for fun socialising. Increased chaos and activity at home might be demanding. Even if pressed, make no commitments. Tonight: Relax at home.
-
- TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): You're keen to express yourself to others today. You'll be convincing, which is good news for those in sales, marketing, teaching, writing or acting. Nevertheless, your primary focus now is on home and family. Tonight: Upbeat discussions.
-
- GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This week begins with a busy, eager pace. Short trips and conversations with daily contacts interest you. See the Moon alert for today, avoid spending. Tonight: Maintain your possessions.
-
- CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): You are careful with money, which is a good thing. Be aware of the restrictions of the Moon Alert today and avoid spending, except for food and gas), because you will be tempted to do so. Meanwhile, make no promises at home. Tonight: You're strong.
-
- LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): You hold all the cards this week because the Sun, Mercury and lucky Jupiter are in your sign. However, don't feel pressured into saying something, doing something or committing to something you don't want. Check the Moon Alert. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.
-
- VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): You might be tempted to buy something beautiful today; however, please be aware of the restrictions of the Moon alert. Tonight: Be friendly.
-
- LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): This is a tricky day because in one way, it's a gorgeous day to be friendly and sociable with everyone. There's a Moon alert, which lightens the feelings of all your social exchanges and encourages a carefree nonchalance to everything. Nevertheless, confusion and deceit are possible. Today: Socialise.
-
- SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): You make a great impression on everyone now with the Sun, Mercury and Jupiter high in your chart. Furthermore, you're eager to travel and expand your world through learning. But today, relations might be confusing. Tonight: Explore and learn.
-
- SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): This is a wonderful week to do all the things you love to do. However, a commitment to a friendship might create confusion for you. You might feel compelled or coerced by someone. Wait until tomorrow to decide. Tonight: Check your finances.
-
- CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): It's easy for you to be charming and gracious right now, especially in the eyes of others. You might feel urged by someone or a strong sense of responsibility to do something, and yet, there is hesitation. You're right, this is why you should wait until tomorrow for clarity. Tonight: Listen and cooperate.
-
- AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Romance with someone might be exotic and compelling. Nevertheless, don't be seduced by someone else, because things are not clear today. Wait until tomorrow, which is a lovely, romantic day. Things will flow naturally. Tonight: Work.
-
- PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): You're motivated to work hard, and you'll accomplish a lot. However, issues about shared property, debt and inheritances are fuzzy. Knowing this, don't act. Furthermore, restrict your spending to food and gas during the Moon alert. Tonight: Enjoy socialising.

The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd
(A Govt. of Kerala Undertaking) Sankaramangalam, Kollam-691 583
Phone: 0476-2651215 to 2651217, e-mail: mo@kmml.com, URL: www.kmml.com

TENDER NOTICE

For more details please visit E-Tendering Portal, <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> or www.kmml.com

Sl.No.	Tender ID	Items
1	2026_KMML_864611_1	Supply of Electric Hoists
2	2026_KMML_864480_1	Supply and application of Acid Resistant Tiles at ARP
3	2026_KMML_864682_1	Supply of Crucible Assembly for Ladle Furnace
4	2026_KMML_864826_1	Supply of 1536 MT of Sodium Silicate

Chavara 07.08.2026 Sd/- Managing Director for The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd

INVITATION FOR EXPRESSION OF INTEREST FOR SALE / ASSIGNMENT OF NOT READILY REALISABLE ASSETS OF SSVJ PROJECTS PRIVATE LIMITED (IN LIQUIDATION) PURSUANT TO REGULATION 37A OF IBBI (LIQUIDATION PROCESS) REGULATIONS 2016

SSJV PROJECTS PRIVATE LIMITED (IN LIQUIDATION)

(CIN: U45203KA1998PTC024063)

Office of the Liquidator: "Shreevathsa", 428, 19th B Cross, 3rd Block, Jayanagar, Bangalore, Karnataka - 560 011, Email: cirp.ssjv@gmail.com / ravi@beleyur.com, Phone: 080 4132 4113

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST

Expression of interest (EOI) are invited from eligible persons/ entities for the sale / assignment of following Not Readily Realisable Assets (NRR Assets) of M/s SSVJ Projects Private Limited – under Liquidation pursuant Regulation 37A of the IBBI (Liquidation Process) Regulations 2016:

Category	Description of NRR Assets	Present Value of claim (Approximate)
A	Claim against NTPC Limited pursuant to Arbitration Award dated 10.11.2017 for the aggregate amount of Rs. 91.98 Crore and interest	Rs. 172 Crores
B	Claim against NTPC Limited pursuant to Arbitration Award dated 09.11.2017 for the aggregate amount of Rs. 45.19 Crore and interest	Rs. 85 Crores
C	Claim against Himachal Pradesh State Electricity Board pursuant to Arbitration Award dated 27.01.2011 for the aggregate amount of Rs. 52.28 Crore and interest	Rs 182 Crores
D	Claim against Sardar Sarovar Narmada Nigam Ltd as per the statement of claim before Arbitration Tribunal aggregate amount of Rs. 325 Crores	Rs. 325 Crores
E	Claim against M/s Satyanarayana Raju & Co., pursuant to the decree dated 10.04.2017 for the aggregate amount of Rs. 3.15 Crores and interest	Rs. 11 Crores
F	Claim towards retention money receivable, approximately Rs. 161 Crores from WAPCOS Ltd., subject to contractual terms and pending legal proceedings.	Rs. 161 Crores
G	All other pending litigations for recovery of receivables	NA

Time Schedule

(i)	Last date of submitting EOI	25.08.2026
(ii)	Provisional list of qualified prospective acquirer(s)	31.08.2026
(iii)	Last date of submitting objection for the inclusion /exclusion of name(s) from provisional list of qualified prospective acquirer(s)	07.09.2026
(iv)	Final list of qualified prospective acquirer(s)	10.09.2026
(v)	Availability of detailed documents relating to NRRAs	Can be sought by sending a request to Liquidator at cirp.ssjv@gmail.com
(vi)	Last date of submitting financial Bid / offer	10.10.2026

Detailed process information document containing terms & conditions and procedure for sale / assignment / transfer of NRR Assets can be obtained by sending an email to the liquidator at cirp.ssjv@gmail.com / ravi@beleyur.com

Sd/-
(Ravindra Beleyur)
Liquidator of SSVJ Projects Private Limited
IBBI Regn. No- IBBI/PA-001/IP-P00189/2017-18/10368
IBBI Regd. Email: ravi@beleyur.com

Date: 08.08.2026
Place: Kolkata

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans on their Balidan Diwas.

 CONSTABLE RAM ASRE SHARMA 59 BN BSF 01.01.1971 – 10.08.2000	 CONSTABLE AJEET KUMAR 59 BN BSF 12.02.1964 – 10.08.2000	 CONSTABLE MANOJ KUMAR 59 BN BSF 05.10.1976 – 10.08.2000	 NAIK BISHNU MAHTO 138 BN BSF 10.07.1964 – 10.08.1996
 CONSTABLE NARESH CHAUDHARY 181 BN BSF 10.10.1975 – 10.08.1999	 CONSTABLE JANARDHAN A V 88 BN BSF 10.01.1969 – 10.08.2000		

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Puran Chand, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating terrorists during an operation in village Beharwal, Punjab on 10 August 1989. For his exceptional gallantry and courage, he was posthumously awarded the Police Medal for Gallantry. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

 Constable Puran Chand 38 Bn 20-3-1967 To 10-8-1989	 Constable Vijay Sahib Solanke 96 Bn 20-6-1955 To 10-8-1993	 Constable Vijay Sahib Solanke 96 Bn 1-6-1967 To 10-8-1993
--	--	---

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Naik Raghurib Singh and Constable Vijay Sahib Solanke of 96 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while countering an ambush by militants in Fatehgarh Sahib, Punjab on 10 August 1993. For their exceptional gallant action and courage, they were posthumously awarded the President's Police Medal for Gallantry. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

 Constable Nek Pal 168 Bn 28-6-1982 To 10-8-2014	 Constable Haribansh Singh Kushwah 168 Bn 7-7-1978 To 10-8-2014
---	---

DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Nek Pal and Constable Haribansh Singh Kushwah of 168 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely countering an ambush by Maoists in Raiguda, Bijapur, Chhattisgarh on 10 August 2014. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.

 Constable Jitendra Kumar 80 Bn 20-3-1988 To 10-8-2019	 DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Jitendra Kumar of 80 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice on 10 August 2019 after battling grievous injuries sustained in a pressure IED blast during ROP duty at Darbha, Bastar, Chhattisgarh on 12 April 2014. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
---	--

CANTONMENT BOARD, MATHURA

INVITATION OF E-TENDERS (DUAL BID SYSTEM)

Electronic Bids are invited by Cantonment Board, Mathura for the under mentioned works:

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Estimated Cost (Rs.)	Earnest Money 2% in (Rs.)	Tender Form Fee
1.	Repair and Renovation of Cantt. fund Buildings for the period of one year.	40.00 Lakh	80,000	1500

The interested contractors / firms shall upload all the documents related to above works on the website <https://defproc.gov.in/> w.e.f. starting date 10.08.2026 at 1600 hrs to ending date 31.08.2026 upto 1700 hrs. The terms & conditions for the above mentioned works may look up the ibid website.

NO. CBM/e-Tender/2026-27/370
Dated: 06 Aug, 2026

Chief Executive Officer
Cantonment Board, Mathura
(Akash Garg, I.D.E.S.)

WESTERN RAILWAY

Material Management Department

VARIOUS MATERIALS SUPPLY

E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE No. S/44/2026 Date 06.08.2026

S.N.	Tender No	Short Description	Quantity	T.O.D.
355	15260518	Double Acting Hydraulic Shock Absorber	1882 Nos	10-Sep-26
356	15260509	High capacity thermoplastic polyester elastomeric (HYTREL) low washer for primary suspension To RDSO DRG. NO.-CG-K-4059, ALT. 4conforming to RDSO SPECN. NO. C-K-409 REV.-3 of April-2023.	7278 Nos	10-Sep-26
357	15262092	Stainless Steel Footstep	1313 Nos	09-Sep-26
358	22265054	Set of cable terminal / sleeves	80 Set	09-Sep-26
359	23263537	POH Kit for KEO type Distributor Valve	2487 Set	07-Sep-26
360	22265052	Set of Programme switches	80 Set	07-Sep-26
361	15265013	Air spring Assembly 180 KN	671 Nos	07-Sep-26
362	07266100	Running Contract for one year for Electric Point Machine 220 mm throw and Clamp point Lock 60kg TWS As per Drg. No. RDSO/S-11000 and RDSO/S3395 Spec; IRS:S 24-2025 REV 3.0, along with Motor for Electric Point Machine with 400V RMS AC immunity with IP 67 protection, Spec: IRS:S37-2022 VER 2	800 Nos	03-Sep-26
363	10265043	Thin Walled Electron Beam Irradiated. Single Core Size: 300 Sq. mm	16000 Mtr	02-Sep-26

CORRIGENDUM

Please read the due date as "02.09.2026" for the Tender Notice No.: S-39-2026 Dated: 17.07.2026 at Sr. No. 331

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Zaheer names Brar as India's 'most promising young pacer'



Gurnoor Brar is in contention for a Test debut in Sri Lanka. CREIMAS

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 9

WITH INDIA yet to find able backups for Jasprit Bumrah and Mohammed Siraj, the team management has tested a young crop of fast bowlers over the last two years. India pace legend Zaheer Khan recently opened up about the steady rise of young fast-bowling options and named Punjab pacer Gurnoor Brar as the most promising seamer of all options.

The 6-foot-5-inch tall pacer was picked for the Test squad in June despite having featured in only a handful of First-Class matches and limited IPL experience.

The 26-year-old Brar subsequently made his ODI debut against Afghanistan, and has picked up 11 wickets in six matches. Brar also featured in India A's tour to Sri Lanka last month, picking up a 10-wicket haul in the first match at Galle.

"It's good to see a young crop of fast bowlers coming through that bowl high speeds. I believe Gurnoor Brar is the one who has the ability to have a good and lengthy career. Its good that he has been fast-tracked. Even when I spent some time with him, I could see exciting potential in him. We have to wait and see how his career materialises eventually, but on potential, he has impressed me the most," the 2011 World Cup-winning Khan said in an interaction with journalist Vimal Kumar.

Brar is currently featuring in India's three-day practice game against Sri Lanka Cricket XI. He picked up three wickets across two innings. A left-handed bat, Brar also chipped in with a quickfire 36 not out off 18 deliveries with four sixes.

With Jasprit Bumrah out injured, Brar is in contention for a Test debut next week when India meet Sri Lanka in the first Test at Galle. Besides Brar, Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna and Auzib Nabi make up India's pace attack for the two-mach series that begins on August 15.

The 6-foot-5-inch tall pacer was picked for the Test squad in June despite having featured in only a handful of First-Class matches and limited IPL experience

SEARCH GOES ON

BCCI's missing link: 18 months on, no sports science head at CoE

An Australian was finalised before he pulled out at the last moment

Venkata Krishna B
Bengaluru, August 9

MORE THAN 18 months since Nitin Patel, the head of BCCI's sports science at the Centre of Excellence, parted ways, its head VVS Laxman has revealed that the board is still searching for a suitable candidate who could be the missing link with regards to injury management. According to Laxman, and BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia, the board has had completed three extensive interviews to find a new candidate only for the selected candidate to pull out at the eleventh hour due to personal reasons.

Given the recent setbacks Indian cricketers have had with the injuries, questions have been raised about the fitness protocols in the team as well as at the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru. Despite Jasprit Bumrah and B Sai Sudharsan's names included for the Sri Lanka Tests subject to fitness clearance, they were ruled out of the series after they failed to recover in time. Once their names were withdrawn, the focus fell on CoE's handling of the injuries, which Laxman defended straight up.

"CoE is not merely a rehab centre. There are bigger roles to play for it in helping cricketers achieve excellence," Laxman said. But more importantly he spoke about the absence of a sports medicine head. "After Nitin left, we did not get anyone who can fill in that position. We had Andrew Leipus, everything was agreed upon, in fact, Devajit had two or three meetings with him but suddenly Andrew backed off at the last moment citing family reasons. We conducted a full-fledged interview process where we had Dr. Dinshaw Pardiwala, Dr. Ashish Soni, Dr. Rohan Khavte and myself, we shortlisted five candidates and number one was an Australian. After selecting him, suddenly he backed out saying he cannot move to Bengaluru," Laxman said.

Laxman then pointed out why it has been challenging to find a suitable candidate and



Jasprit Bumrah picked up an impact injury against England and is unavailable for the SL Tests. CREIMAS

• PILING LIST OF INJURIES

B SAI SUDHARSAN
Toe, since July 2026

The latest addition to India's prolonged list of absentees, B Sai Sudharsan is currently recovering from a toe stress fracture. Though initially named in India's squad for the Sri Lanka Tests, Sudharsan was eventually ruled out upon being declared not completely fit for Test cricket.

HARSHIT RANA
Hamstring, since July 2026

Harshit Rana returned to the national fold after a four-month knee injury layoff in June, but picked up a hamstring injury in India's third T20I against England last month.

VARUN CHAKARAVARTHY
Hamstring, since July 2026

In that same fixture, Varun Chakravarthy also sustained a Grade 2



HARDIK PANDYA
Quadriceps, since June 2026

Pandya has not played any cricket since IPL 2026. Nursing back spasms, he sustained a quadriceps strain while undergoing rehab at the CoE in June.

hamstring injury. Notably, he had missed the Ireland series preceding the England tour with a foot injury.

WASHINGTON SUNDAR
Hamstring, since July 2026

Washington Sundar was the third Indian cricketer to sustain a hamstring injury in the England tour, which he picked up in the process of taking a single.

JASPRIT BUMRAH
Knee, since July 2026

Jasprit Bumrah suffered an impact injury during India's second ODI against England on 16 July, which ruled him out of the two Tests against Sri Lanka.

NITISH KUMAR REDDY
Quadriceps, since June 2026

Nitish Kumar Reddy, who has been earmarked as Hardik Pandya's long-term replacement, is currently sidelined with the same quadriceps injury that he sustained during the ODI series against Afghanistan.

they had to divide the verticals to make-up for the absence of a sports medicine head. "One of the important conditions is that it is a full time job. It is not a part time one. It is day-to-day monitoring. Another professional (who we selected) was head of sports science at All Blacks (New Zealand rugby team). We engaged with him

and he almost agreed but at the last moment he too backed off," he said.

Grasp of Indian cricket

"To fill in the position, you require not someone of the stature but the knowledge and understanding of Indian cricketers. Because we did not get head of sports science, we di-

vided it into four verticals and I think a lot of credit goes to the professionals already in the team, because they have stepped up," he added.

Although the staff at the CoE have shared responsibilities, what can't be overlooked is the mounting injury crisis. Patel, for example, is credited for the manner he handled

Sarfaraz replaces injured Sai Sudharsan for SL Tests

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 9

THE BOARD of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) on Sunday officially announced that batter Sai Sudharsan was ruled out of the upcoming Sri Lanka Test series and named Mumbai batter Sarfaraz Khan as replacement.

"Sai Sudharsan has been ruled out of the Test series against Sri Lanka. The left-handed batter, who has been at the BCCI Centre of Excel-



Sarfaraz Khan (L) was named as Sai Sudharsan's replacement. PTI



lence (CoE) in Bengaluru, has made significant progress in his recovery from the right toe stress reaction and is recovering well. The BCCI Medical Team is closely monitoring his progress," the BCCI statement revealed.

"The Men's Selection Committee has named Sarfaraz Khan as a replacement for Sai Sudharsan for the two-match Test series against Sri Lanka. He will link up with the Indian squad in Colombo before the team travels to Galle for the

first Test match, starting August 15, 2026," it added.

Sarfaraz had last played a match for India in November 2024 against New Zealand. **INDIA'S UPDATED SQUAD FOR SL TESTS:** Shubman Gill (Captain), KL Rahul (Vice-Captain), Yashasvi Jaiswal, Rishabh Pant (WK), Dhruv Jurel (WK), Ravindra Jadeja, Kuldeep Yadav, Manav Suthar, Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna, Gurnoor Brar, Devdutt Padikkal, Saransh Jain, Auzib Nabi, Sarfaraz Khan

Amid injury concerns, Laxman says system working as intended

Venkata Krishna B
Bengaluru, August 9

WITH THE BCCI's Centre of Excellence (CoE) facing scrutiny of late over the injury crisis that has hit the Indian men's team hard, head of cricket VVS Laxman strongly asserted that there has been no communication breakdown between the CoE, team management and selectors over injury management.

After Jasprit Bumrah was ruled out of the Sri Lanka Test series, news emerged on Saturday that batter B Sai Sudharsan would also miss the trip as both continue to undergo rehabilitation at the CoE. Both players had been named in the squad but were subsequently withdrawn from what is a crucial two-Test series. While the BCCI had revealed that their availability was subject to fitness, their extended absence has raised questions over whether the right protocols are being followed at the CoE.

Asked if the CoE was being made a scapegoat for the recurring injuries, Laxman said: "I think we don't like to use the name blame. Because when you're using the name, then you're finding someone as a scapegoat. There's a brilliant coordination between the CoE, between the team management of both the teams and the SSM (sports science and medicine). And the selection committee."

Speaking specifically about Bumrah and Sudharsan, Laxman explained in detail the timeline and communication with the Ajit Agarkar-led selection panel.

"So, Bumrah and Sai Sudarshan were going to be picked to Sri Lanka subject to fitness clearance. And as I told before, you assess them, you move them from one stage to the next stage and if the progression is slow, you communicate to the selection committee chairman and the head coach, which is happening seamlessly. And they [players] understand that they're not yet ready to participate in the national series. Always it's player-centric and team-centric. So that communication is happening seamlessly," Laxman said.

Laxman then pointed out that when the squad for the Sri Lanka series was announced, the BCCI release had an asterisk attached to both players' names.

"Now, Bumrah and Sai Sudarshan. You know, there's always an asterisk, and this is one thing which you all will know that when the media release comes from the BCCI, there's an asterisk attached to a player's selection. And what does that asterisk mean? It means subject to fitness. It's clearly mentioned that these players are picked subject to fitness. Means if they don't clear the fitness test, the selectors will know who the other players are who will go in their place if they don't clear the fitness test. I mean, it's basic common sense," he added.

BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia also pointed to the timing of squad selection, which can make it challenging to drop a player or include one who is still undergoing rehabilitation.

"We basically have our selection meetings at least three



VVS Laxman affirmed CoE and the team's synergy. PTI

“There's a brilliant coordination between the CoE, between the team management of both the teams and the SSM (sports science and medicine). And the selection committee.”

VVS LAXMAN

to four weeks before the team departs. So therefore, three weeks before or four weeks before, we do not know the exact status of the player. So if he gets fit within the period of 21 days or 28 days, he will be taken into the team. We do not outrightly reject him because [he's not fit] on the date of selection. But by the time he will be effectively required to travel or to play the match, by that time, he may be totally fit. So in that situation, we always keep subject to fitness. So we do not deprive the player also," Saikia said.

When the squad was announced, India's primary concern centred on Bumrah, while there was an expectation that Sudharsan would be fit enough to make the cut for the warm-up fixture. But a setback suffered during his rehabilitation meant his return to play was delayed, forcing the selectors to name a replacement.

"This is very uncertain that within 21 days, he will get picked or not. Nobody can predict that, and as VVS has rightly said, it is a human body. It is not a machine. So he may take 14 days' time or he may take 28 days' time [to fully recover] subject to his own body composition," Saikia said.

Beyond the two, there are also growing concerns around all-rounder Nitish Kumar Reddy, who has had a series of injury setbacks. After adding 10 yards of extra pace during the IPL, he broke down with a quadriceps injury. Laxman said efforts were being made to help players understand workload management better. "Nitish, being an all-rounder, obviously there is a lot of workload on him and how he becomes fitter. Not only when he is playing various tournaments but also when he is not part of any tournaments.

"And I think it is an ongoing process now of getting better from your fitness levels. Because everyone knows, now you go to IPL, you play state franchise, and then you start playing domestic cricket or international cricket," Laxman said.

• OPENERS COME GOOD

Day of positives: Gill and Jaiswal fluent; bowlers rediscover sharpness

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 9

AFTER EIGHT sessions of play in the warm-up match against Sri Lanka Cricket XI at Colombo's Nondescripts Cricket Club, India had found answers to most of their questions. Gurnoor Brar had impressed, Devdutt Padikkal had strengthened his case at No. 3, and the spinners had enjoyed a workout. One significant question, however, remained unanswered. It was addressed in the final session, with India chasing 207 in 45 overs for victory, as Shubman Gill came to the middle with Yashasvi Jaiswal.

His return with the bat was therefore less about the 44 runs he made than what the innings said about his readiness for the first Test in Galle on Saturday. Gill had a batting stint in the

nets when India were bowling in the second innings, and there were few signs of discomfort during his stay in the middle in India's chase. He looked assured and unencumbered. He defended, left and rotated strike, while his movement into shots remained fluent.

There were some Gill highlights. He caressed Vishwa Fernando through cover, punched Lahiru Kumara through cover point and produced a fine on-drive in the fifth over off Fernando. He stayed balanced in defence, got behind the line and was comfortable moving forward and back against both seam and spin.

The Sri Lankan Cricket XI bowlers also tested him. In the second over, Gill was struck in front by a full delivery and survived a close lbw appeal. Later, he handled deliveries that came

back into him and those that held their line outside off without showing any reluctance to play them. He used his feet confidently against spin, coming down the pitch and working the ball into the leg side.

His 44 came from 54 balls, with seven fours, before Kesara Nuwantha had him caught. But the score mattered less than the manner in which he accumulated it. There was no visible grimace, no repeated examination of the finger and no restriction in his shot-making or movement.

That was what India would have wanted from the innings. Gill did not need to make a score in a 45-over chase; he needed to show that he could bat naturally and without inhibition. For much of his stay, he did exactly that.

Jaiswal responded to his



Shubman Gill scored 44 in India's victory on Sunday. CREIMAS

first-innings duck, producing 61 off 46 balls before retiring hurt. The innings was less about the number of boundaries he struck than the manner of his response to the earlier dismissal.

The left-hander was posi-

tive from the outset without looking rushed. He attacked anything wide, drove confidently through cover and point, and handled the short ball better than he had in the first innings. His upper-cut off

Lahiru Kumara was well judged, while he repeatedly used his stride and high backlift to put away fuller deliveries.

Jaiswal was aggressive against spin. He cleared his front leg and swept a flat six over midwicket off Ramesh Mendis, then brought up his fifty with another slog sweep off Nuwantha. He retired hurt with India's score 100/0.

Rishabh Pant, who, like Jaiswal, had fallen cheaply for two runs in the first innings, made the most of his promotion to number three, occupying the crease instead of playing in his flamboyant style.

The left-hander took 22 balls to get off the mark, hitting Nuwantha for a six as he resisted the urge to take on the spinners, unlike in the first innings.

Pant looked set to take India home, but fell while trying to

clear the long-on boundary for 28. Ravindra Jadeja, along with Manav Suthar, took India towards the target before the former retired hurt.

Just when the match looked like petering towards a draw, Mohammed Siraj produced a blistering late cameo, smashing Nuwantha for three consecutive sixes in the last over to help India cross the target.

Earlier, India, like Sri Lanka Cricket XI, declared their first innings overnight, handing the hosts a six-run lead. It offered Mohammed Siraj and Prasidh Krishna a second chance to find their rhythm. The contrast with Day 1, when both pacers leaked runs with the new ball, was stark.

Siraj repeatedly hit the channel, generated movement and finished with 1/25 in eight overs, including three maidens, while

Prasidh was tighter and claimed Pasindu Sooriyabandara's wicket, ending with 1/35. Gurnoor Brar again impressed with his bounce and seam, taking two wickets, including that of captain Sonal Dinusha, who edged one to Dhruv Jurel with the ball climbing on the wicketkeeper.

Jadeja found turn and bounce, taking Anjala Bandara at slip before stumping Nipun Dhananjaya. Auzib Nabi, bowling for the first time, offered control and variation but went wicketless for 27 in five overs. **BRIEF SCORES:** Sri Lanka Cricket XI 363/8 decl. and 200/5 decl. (Nishan Fernando 63; Ravindra Jadeja 2/33) lost to India 357/6 decl. and 214/4 in 45 overs (Yashasvi Jaiswal 61 ret'd hurt, Shubman Gill 44; Keshara Nuwantha 2/57) by six wickets.

